

Genesis Schwarzschild
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Vice Research Compendium

[v5.1.2 | Public Edition]

CVRS is dedicated to the public distribution and maintenance of our research database. Knowledge is power, and every advantage puts our patients one step closer to completing their Vice journey.

A digital version of this compendium is available online at bugdotpng.github.io/cvrs/vrc/index.html

Notice:

The Vice Research Compendium uses the term “Host” to refer to those infected with a Vice. While we recognize that this is regarded as insensitive to some, due to the technical nature of the compendium, the verbiage will remain unchanged to maintain transparency.

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The one-stop shop for all things vicology. Dive deep into what we know about these foreign organisms: learn about their life cycle, how they reproduce, and how they interact with the world around them.		Our team of dedicated agents are equipped with years of intense training to guide you through your Vice journey. We'll be here every step of the way. Take back control and schedule a consult today!	
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Vices are classified by shared behaviors and characteristics. These classifications provide insight on expected Vice behaviors and are crucial in preparing properly for rescission.		Learn about the sectors, teams, and agent roles that make up our institution and browse our services offered.	
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What Are Vices?

If you're having trouble wrapping your head around it all, as many do, read this high-level overview of Vices to gradually ease yourself into the world of vicology.

First discovered by a nurse via ultrasound in 1973, a Vicemortiferum [VEE-seh-mohr-TI-fehr-um] (plural: Vicemortifera) or more commonly known as a "Vice", is a parasitic creature that draws its energy from the products of our body's endocrine system. They feed and grow from many of the hormones released as we live our lives, such as cortisol, adrenaline, and epinephrine. Their origins remain largely unknown, as they are suspected to have been quietly living among us before their discovery. In the 70s, cases were so rare that they were considered medical anomalies, but over time, we have seen a steady increase in cases and roughly 62% of the population are estimated to be infected with a Vice. While a true immunity is not currently known, stronger immune systems seem to be able to fight off vitiumglomerorum—the spore-like vehicle of Vice reproduction, also known as VG.

The presence of a Vice is at best, inconsequential, and at worst, lethal; though, the advent of a Vice is not necessarily a death sentence. In fact, the majority of Hosts live long, full lives with their Vice, and many with less severe Vice classifications are able to keep them under control on their own. There are currently 10 primary classifications and 4 secondary classifications (subclasses), all with differing behaviors, characteristics, and even biology. Learn more about these in *Classifying Vices*.

Regardless of classification, Hosts—especially those with more severe classifications—are encouraged to enlist the help of an Adjunct(s) or Vice Management Administrator to establish a support system as early in the process as possible. Call us at (214) 877-8423 or email info@cvrs.com to schedule a consult at a Primary Care near you.

Vices have three stages in their life cycle: larval, adolescent, and mature. While all Vices are different, especially between classifications, specific behaviors tend to mark each life stage. Larvae are generally inactive and primarily focus on feeding. Adolescents drastically increase Branch activity and are generally regarded as more impulsive and aggressive. Mature Vices tend to be more calculated and discerning in initiating Branches. *Classifying Vices* goes into detail about what one can expect to see in each life stage for each of the 10 classifications.

A common side effect of a Vice infection is the manifestation of blights, which can be arranged into three categories: expulsion, drape, and extrusion. Expulsion blights—like smoke, for example—often manifest at advent and can be seen through all life stages. Drape and extrusion blights, however, only manifest after an adolescent Vice begins creating its network, a mycelial-like web of tracks. These tracks help transport VG and send captured hormones back to the core for the Vice to feed. As the network becomes more complex, the concentrations of VG can spur drape blights (scales or feathers) and extrusion blights (horns or claws) to manifest.

During a Vice's life cycle, a Host will become accustomed to the phenomenon known as a Branch, wherein the Vice floods the Host's body with VG and traps the Host's consciousness in a dream-like environment while it attempts to expand either its core (augmentation) or network (germination) throughout the body. Every Vice has a set of relatively static data that influences its Branches, known collectively as the Branch Policy.

Hosts are able to rid their body of their Vice through the process of rescission, where they destroy the Vice core during an active Branch. The process of rescission looks different between different classifications of Vices, but can generally be prepared for by observing a Vice's behavior in previous Branches, which can be addressed with a commit or suspension. Learn about the different ways to address a Branch in *Branch Options*.

Vice Biology

Dive deep into what we know about these foreign organisms, their life cycle and how they reproduce, and what drives them.

An integral facet to understanding Vice biology lies in exploring the properties of Vitiumglomerorum (VG, plural: vitiumglomerora). Over time, our body accumulates these spore-like cells. Due to the recent rise in Vice infections, we come into contact with VG on the daily. Stagnant clouds of VG are unavoidable in public areas with poor airflow, but even outdoor areas have a low, steady level of VG. While wearing a mask can prevent them from being inhaled, VG are still able to enter our body through other orifices, microscopic tears in the skin, and even our pores.

Our body is often able to destroy these spores much like it would defend against pollen or a virus by deploying antibodies, raising the body's temperature, or increasing mucus production. This reaction is typically triggered by large concentrations of VG being introduced to the body—by a detached rumen, for example—but a steady, gradual increase in VG over time will remain undetected as the body slowly acclimates.

Outside of the body, VG are so light that they are able to hang in the air, but once they are in the bloodstream, our plasma activates a “magnetic” property that allows VG to “find” its peers and clump together. This forms a thin, tacky film that can cover soft tissue or non-essential organs like the gallbladder or spleen.

Vices prefer to colonize low-traffic areas and generally avoid joints like the shoulder or elbow. They tend to congregate around hormone-producing organs and glands, such as the kidneys, thyroid, or pancreas, but they can also colonize nearby muscles and ligaments. While these clumps are generally benign on their own, heightened exposure to hormones is what ultimately prompts the mass to take root. This process is referred to as a Vice's advent.

Evolution & Intelligence

Though vicology is a relatively new field of study, Vices have grown and evolved immensely during their short time under our observation. In the earliest observed Vices, complex intelligence did not seem to be a present factor, even in more mature Vices. As more Vices facilitate successful dispersions, more unique mixes of VG birth Vices into existence, creating combinations of properties not yet observed, which often lead to anomalies and eventually, entirely new classifications. Vices will only continue to grow and evolve as time moves on, and as they do, so will we. CVRS is dedicated to following the progression of these Vices, and we are diligently researching new ways to combat these invasive, ever-changing creatures.

New Vices are tending toward higher threat levels and often tout higher levels of intelligence, leading to a massive increase in recent --gamma subclassifications. Even the Alpha Vices of today seem to be much more intentional in their behavior than their predecessors. We encourage Hosts to arm themselves with knowledge, regardless of classification. Vices of any class, in any life stage, can behave and react in ways that deviate from expectations, as they are fundamentally animals driven by instinct. The more we learn about these creatures, the more complex they seem to become, operating in methods and realms not previously explored.

As these creatures evolve, we need the community's cooperation and participation in research trials and observatory studies. Visit the nearest CVRS to establish a treatment plan today and help further the field of Vice research.

Vice Biology

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The advent of a Vice can be sudden or gradual. Sudden advents are triggered by a single event, while gradual advents occur over an extended period of time. Sudden advents tend to be more common in Vices with a lower threat level, while gradual advents often result in Vices with a higher threat level, though this is not always the case.		Vices are particular creatures, both about their diet and their environment. If either are disturbed or become unreliable, a Vice has many different ways that it takes action to ensure its safety and well-being.	
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All Vices are unique, and even those within the same classification can meet milestones at different times. This page covers the general Vice life cycle and outlines expected behaviors and biological changes. Understanding these properties helps to prepare Hosts for any potential changes in activity as the Vice matures.		Vices use vitiumglomerorum (VG) to reproduce. Once the core has been established, it can work on producing VG to be distributed in various ways, most commonly seen in the act of dispersion, though the detachment of rumen can also aid in reproduction.	
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After advent, a Vice immediately begins feeding on the hormones excreted by the Host, preferring those present in high amounts during advent. Vices use these hormones for a wide variety of processes, most commonly contributing to the growth of its core during the larval stage and serving as the energy source of Branch initiation and subsequent augmentation and germination as it matures.			

Advent

The advent of a Vice occurs in one of two ways: sudden or gradual. Sudden advents are triggered by a single event, while gradual advents occur over an extended period of time. Sudden advents tend to be more common in Vices with a lower threat level, while gradual advents often result in Vices with a higher threat level, though this is not always the case.

Sudden Advent

A sudden advent is triggered by an abrupt increase in hormone levels, typically due to an isolated traumatic event. This dramatic influx of hormones fuels the expedited creation of VG. The excessive spawning of these VG causes them to leak from the mass and flood the Host's system, prompting the first Branch, known as the advent Branch. The complexity of this Branch depends on the Vice's classification. Most advent Branches are simple and straightforward, with a fragile exhibition and simple Branch Domain that is pulled from the current environment. Though Vices are able to use the continued hormone influx to fuel the Branch, most Vices prematurely terminate the Branch and retreat due to their lack of established energy reserves, resulting in an uncharacteristically short Branch. Though, in the case of a Lambda advent, the advent Branch can be overwhelmingly complicated.

The properties observed during this advent Branch give valuable insight into preparing for future Branches—known collectively as the Branch Policy—as these properties tend to remain the same over time for the majority of classifications. Sudden advents provide relatively straightforward information that often helps in addressing future Branches or even avoiding them. Triggers are often pulled from the advent Branch, and the properties inside the Branch Domain, including its blueprint and the exhibition's presentation and attack strategy, remain relatively the same through the Vice's life cycle. Xi Vices, however, are able to enhance and optimize these properties between Branches.

The following classifications have sudden advents: Alpha, Theta, Lambda, Xi, and Phi. Sudden advents do not necessarily constitute a lower threat level, but instead suggest a more straightforward and predictable Branch Policy.

Post-Advent Classification Process

Sudden advents are unmistakable, and after a Host has experienced the advent Branch, they are advised to make an appointment with CVRS Primary Care. Upon admission by an Intake Coordinator, the Host will meet with a Record Proctor who will perform a VGDS to detect the presence of a core. Patients who receive a positive VGDS will be given a tentative, preliminary classification based on the information provided, which is subject to change. They will then be scheduled to meet with a Vice Management Administrator and establish treatment goals.

Gradual Advent

Gradual advents occur when the mass is exposed to a steady increase in hormones over a period of time, rather than being tied to a point in time. A Vice with a gradual advent prioritizes thickening its epithelium, which later becomes the foundation for its core, as opposed to producing large quantities of VG in its early stages.

Because there is no single event to trigger an advent Branch, Vices with a gradual advent tend to have more complex Branch Policies, influenced by the variety of events experienced as the Vice is forming. This often leads to larger exhibitions, more complex Branch Domains, and broad or convoluted triggers.

Vices with a gradual advent are typically indicated by increased and uncharacteristic fatigue. The first Branch initiated by the Vice often takes the Host by surprise, and due to the early emphasis on epithelium enhancement, these Branches are often more difficult to address and have more general defenses compared to those with a sudden advent. These Vices are still immature, however, and will eventually run out of steam and terminate the Branch, but due to the extended Branch time, the Vice core is often allowed to expand more than that of a Vice with a sudden advent.

The following classifications have gradual advents: Beta, Delta, Epsilon, Zeta, and Omega. The complex Branch Policy that results from a gradual advent helps to elevate the threat level of these classifications.

Post-Advent Classification Process

Because there is no advent Branch to verify the advent of a Vice, those who have a Vice with a gradual advent often have more difficulty initially being admitted. A Branch is required to pass admission, though a referral

from an external medical professional, such as a General Practitioner, will suffice. Upon admission, the Host will meet with a Record Proctor who will perform a VGDS to detect the presence of a core. Patients who receive a positive VGDS will be given a tentative, preliminary classification based on the information provided, which is subject to change. They will then be scheduled to meet with a Vice Management Administrator and establish treatment goals.

The Life Cycle of Vices

All Vices are unique, and even those within the same classification can meet milestones at different times. This section covers the general Vice life cycle and outlines expected behaviors and biological changes. Understanding these properties helps to prepare Hosts for any potential changes in activity as the Vice matures.

After advent, Vices enter the larval stage. Most Vices do not reach maturity, as rescission is often performed before a Vice can fully mature. Maturity does not always look the same or warrant the same degree of caution between classifications. For example, an adolescent Epsilon Vice typically poses a greater threat than a mature Alpha Vice, and two larval Vices from different classifications can exhibit completely different behaviors.

Generally speaking, however, larval Vices tend to be the most docile, focusing primarily on feeding. Adolescent Vices, on the other hand, are much more impulsive and aggressive, likely initiating the majority of Branches in this life stage. And finally, mature Vices tend to be more reserved and calculated. Vices can make attempts to and pursue dispersion at any stage, but it is most commonly executed to completion by mature Vices, while adolescent Vices tend to make the most attempts.

Stage 1: Larval

These young Vices spend the majority of their time storing energy and learning their environment. Branches at this stage are unlikely, as energy is typically directed toward establishing its core and producing VG instead. If a larval Vice does initiate a branch, they have a tendency to prematurely terminate it before the core sustains much damage, as Branches can often be too much of an energy sink for the core to function properly. This is most commonly observed in the initial Branch that occurs from a sudden advent, but it can also occur in subsequent Branches. Larval Lambda Vices in particular deviate from this expected behavior, and more can be learned about this life stage on their individual classification page.

Vices spend anywhere from 6 months to a year in the larval stage, and can be expected to initiate a Branch anywhere from one to five times, in most cases. Larval cores are relatively small, typically between 10 and 20mm, though they tend to be extremely dense and

compact, likely as a defense mechanism. Larval Vices do not have a network and typically present as a circular or oblong mass on a VGMS.

In this stage, many Hosts report uncharacteristic fatigue, brain fog, and elevated hormone production. While Vices do not directly stimulate hormone production, our bodies often begin overcompensating for the percentage ensnared by the core. Extreme cases can result in conditions like hypothyroidism, particularly seen in Zeta Vices due to their excessive feeding and specialized biology.

Larval Vices avoid setting off the Host's immune system by using hormones to fuel a steady, gradual core growth that is almost imperceptible and avoids being detected by most immune systems. Even during Branches, growth is minimal, as larval Vices tend to prioritize feeding rather than augmentation.

If a Host has a Vice with a gradual advent, many remain unaware of their infection, attributing their uncharacteristic fatigue to illnesses or other factors. Some particularly non-reactive Vices manage to avoid detection into adolescence.

Rescission is not commonly pursued at this stage, though it is recommended for some classifications to prevent particularly dangerous Vices from reaching maturity. Hosts with a Delta or Zeta Vice often pursue rescission at this stage for relief, as these classifications can be particularly draining, even moreso than other classifications.

Rescission at any stage poses risks, even at the larval stage. The Branch Policy of a larval Vice has not been determined and cannot be prepared for thoroughly, though the probability of an advanced exhibition and complex Branches are unlikely, save for Lambda Vices. Larval cores, too, can sometimes be more defensive, leading to difficulty with rescission.

Browse the *Classifying Vices* section for classification-specific rescission guidance at the larval stage.

Stage 2: Adolescent

After a Vice has established its core and familiarized itself with its environment, it will move into the adolescent stage. Using the resources hoarded as a larva, a Vice will begin initiating Branches more regularly in an attempt to expand its network (germination) and grow its core (augmentation).

Adolescent Vices are visually distinct from larval vices due to the beginnings of a network, which can be seen using a VGMS, though they tend to be faint in this stage. During Branches, Vices begin stretching their core, protected by their thickened epithelium as they unfurl from their previously compact state. During this stage, a Vice core can range anywhere from 15mm to 50mm, depending on varying factors such as classification, access to resources, and Branch activity and duration. Certain classifications prioritize augmentation over germination, or vice versa, leading to a large variation in sizes at the life stage.

As the network becomes established, individual tracks are assigned specific duties, with thinner tracks monitoring environmental changes and thicker tracks transporting hormones for feeding. Some tracks are even embedded into organs like lymph nodes, pituitary glands, and even parts of the brain, or are extended outside the body—known as a stolon—to monitor a wealth of environmental properties, like temperature, sound, or even relative humidity.

A Vice's Branch Policy is generally established at advent, but many of its properties will become more apparent in adolescence compared to the larval stage, particularly due to the increase in Branch initiations. The Vice's newly established network plays an essential role in detecting changes in its environment that instruct the Vice when to best and most effectively initiate Branches. The network explicitly "looks" for external circumstances that mirror those found at advent. In adolescence, most Vices initiate Branches without a second thought, so many Hosts are able to predict or even bait Branches using the criteria established in the Branch Policy.

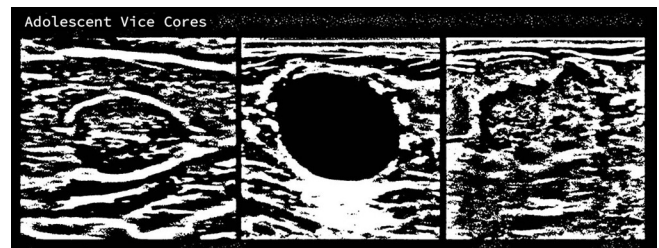
Each Branch requires massive amounts of energy to fuel germination, augmentation, and the creation of the exhibition and Branch Domain, so repeated Branches in quick succession are unlikely. Most Vices have an average "cool down" period between Branches of roughly 2 weeks. Even if the environmental triggers are present, many do not have the established resources for another Branch initiation, especially at this stage.

Vices typically spend a minimum of two years in the adolescent stage. Some classifications are simply unable to progress to maturity due to their lack of intelligence or ability to plan, but they should not be underestimated. Adolescent Vices are impulsive and inexperienced, but they are capable of initiating rogue

Branches that deviate from their Branch Policy if they feel threatened. Many are able to take their Host by surprise and capitalize on the prolonged Branch time as the Host regains their footing. Learn more about these rare, but dangerous Branches in *The Branch Phenomenon: Fringe Branch Events*.

Generally speaking, a successful rescission is fairly likely in this stage with the right resources thanks to the Vice's inexperience, but the longer a Vice spends in the adolescent stage, the more experienced and dangerous it becomes. If a Vice is particularly aggressive or deceptive, it is highly encouraged to instigate a Branch and pursue rescission with a support team before it matures further. Browse the *Classifying Vices* section for classification-specific rescission guidance at the adolescent stage.

An estimated 65% of Vices do not reach maturity; roughly 7% of these Vices are simply incapable of doing so due to their unique characteristics, as seen in Phi Vices. The remaining 58% are rescinded before they are able to reach maturity.



Stage 3: Mature

Vice maturity is marked by considerable expansion along its network, with cores typically ranging widely from 40mm to 150mm—though some mature Vices have been documented to be as large as 350mm, more than one foot in length! Mature Vice networks are much more established, and easily seen with a VGMS or Parsing Goggles. An established network means mature Vices tend to exacerbate blights more than other stages, resulting in more prominent chronic blights.

Mature Vices are also marked by their restraint; that is, demonstrating that they have learned to wait for the opportune time to initiate Branches, rather than initiating Branches every time the environment appears to be suitable as they do in adolescence.

Mature Vices have mastered the art of balancing feeding and Branches, optimizing their energy consumption and growth progress. Quality over quantity is the name of the game with mature Vices. They are much more calculated than adolescents, and while Branches are less common, they're much more dangerous. Mature Vices tend to wait for the most advantageous opportunities that guarantee longer Branch times, thus ensuring augmentation and/or germination progress, even if the Branch is committed.

Rumina are typically only established by mature Vices, as they require a level of awareness and foresight not typically observed in adolescent Vices. Establishing rumina has become more of a common practice among mature Vices as of late, indicating an increase in overall intelligence. Mature Vices of every classification are capable of establishing a rumen, but it is much more common in those with higher threat levels, seen often in Zeta Vices.

Rescission in this stage is not guaranteed and will likely require a team of dedicated Adjuncts, no matter the Vice's classification. Some Vices—notably Epsilon and Omega Vices—are capable of obfuscating or even altering their Branch Policy as a defense mechanism, often making for precarious rescissions. Having an established CVRS care team will greatly improve the chances of a successful rescission. Browse the *Classifying Vices* section for classification-specific rescission guidance at the mature stage.

Feeding & Energy Management

After advent, a Vice immediately begins feeding on the hormones excreted by the Host, preferring those present in high amounts during advent. Vices use these hormones for a wide variety of processes, most commonly contributing to the growth of its core during the larval stage and serving as the energy source of Branch initiation and subsequent augmentation and germination as it matures.

The Vice's network is its central energy management system, but it only begins establishment in early adolescence. In the larval stage, Vices are passive feeders, subsisting on hormones as they pass by the core. Some classifications, such as Beta Vices, have altered biology that help them feed more efficiently in this stage. Larval Zeta cores in particular are known for being able to attract hormones, acting more as a magnet than a static trap. Additionally, the --sigma subclass is capable of feeding on any and all hormones, even extending its palate to other bodily secretions, such as plasma and interstitial fluid. Learn more about these biological differences in *Classifying Vices*.

In order to fully grasp a Vice's energy management, the core's importance cannot be understated. The core is essentially the Vice itself, a pulsing, fleshy mass of intricate systems and mechanics. The core is the primary resource hoard, yes, but it is also the control center, directing resource distribution, prioritizing functions, and using its network to monitor environmental conditions.

In adolescence, a Vice will begin to establish its network throughout the Host's body, using its tendril-like tracks to ensnare hormones over a broader surface area and feed more efficiently. These tracks gradually seek out hormones, often expanding to congregate around high-traffic areas such as the brain stem and pituitary gland.

While a core is dense enough to sustain Branches in its larval stage, it relies heavily on its network in adolescence and maturity, which allows it to perform multiple functions at once. Vices use their network to transport energy and resources to and from the core, fueling Branches, increasing their monitoring capabilities, and even scouting for potential rumina. In addition to the role it plays in feeding, the network is

also the path that the core expands along during augmentation. The core can only expand so far until germination progress is required to guide its augmentation.

While the majority of energy is stored in the core, the network is also able to hoard pockets of energy to further fuel Branches and augmentation. These pockets are typically stored in junctions in the network where the VN has branched in many directions and grown a thick outer layer of protection. VG cannot be released from junctions, but in return, these energy pockets are shielded from AV or other immune responses.

In summation, Vices cannot thrive without their network. While the core is the powerhouse, the network is what allows the core to expand during augmentation and set the stage for dispersion. The network and all its capabilities are explored in further detail below.

Network Fundamentals

Once a Vice reaches adolescence, it will begin to establish its network, a mycelium-like collection of tracks that branch throughout the Host's body, originating from the Vice core. These tracks are densely-packed vitiumnexa (VN) that transport hormones and VG.

New tracks are extremely fluid and easily damaged but become thicker as the network becomes more established. While the primary purpose of tracks is to monitor surroundings and send nutrients back to the core, it is also the nutrient-rich path that the core expands along during a Branch. Tracks typically follow blood vessels and are able to phase through the endothelium to ensnare passing hormones.

As the network grows and new tracks branch off of older ones, these junctions begin to form a thick, calloused outer skin that shields the VN and VG inside. Though not impenetrable, it takes much higher concentrations of AV to damage these junctions, and as a result, Vices tend to hoard VG and hormones in these areas, often causing extrusion and drape blights. These are most commonly found adhering to ligaments and surrounding joints. Because of this, well-established networks can present as joint pain and bodily fatigue, even going so far as to restrict range of motion in extreme cases.

Tracks are not limited to the Hosts body and often extend beyond the body to monitor external conditions. These external tracks are known as stolons. Common Vices with low threat levels typically do not have a stolon, but those with a higher threat level can have multiple.

Stolons

While the network is predominantly internal, as a Vice matures, it can have a handful of tracks outside of the Host's body—called stolons—that can extend up to a quarter mile in extreme cases. These external tracks do not interfere with the environment and cannot be interacted with, unless one wields a patch. New stolons are generally sparse and used primarily to monitor their environment for potential Branch triggers.

Most Vices have one or two stolons at a time. While VG is small enough to phase through our pores, as a concentrated stolon that also contains a VG barrier, they require larger orifices to enter the environment, such as the ears, nostrils, or mouth. Stolons are not felt by the Host, nor are they painful or uncomfortable at this stage due to their sparse makeup. But as the Vice matures and stolons become more established, these can begin to hold a presence. For example, Hosts have reported an uncharacteristic tautness to their mouth or an inexplicably stuffy nose.

In addition to monitoring their environment and scouting for potential environmental triggers, in some classifications, these stolons also spend their time hunting for a suitable organic mass to infect and establish a rumen, an external energy reserve.

Establishing Rumina

While Vices are capable of storing small amounts of excess energy in the core, it is typically a limited amount and best suited for initiating standard Branches. The circumstances that result in a rumen are simultaneously calculated and hinge on luck; for this reason, rumina tend to be relatively rare. Though, as Vice intelligence continues to trend upward, rumina are becoming more common.

Vices use stolons—elongated, external tracks—to scout for energy-rich organic matter, most commonly in the form of freshly deceased vermin. If detected, the stolon will attach to the mass, which prompts the core to send a small, but steady stream of VG through the stolon to colonize the mass and act as a beacon if the

connection is lost. Stolons, during this time, remain flexible and do not funnel out too many resources, as the Host is likely to stray outside of the stolon's reach, causing it to detach. If the Host returns to the designated radius of where the beacon was set, the Vice will attempt to reattach.

If a Host remains within the radius for roughly two weeks—though, this time frame is flexible between classifications—the Vice will begin funneling excessive amounts of VG to colonize the mass and begin altering its form to mimic the core and become a rumen. Because the tissue is not alive, a new Vice is not created; rather, a non-sentient “copy” of the Vice is established. All auxiliary stolons are re-routed to the rumen to reinforce the attached stolon, creating a singular track that is much more rigid and less likely to break. In extreme cases and in instances of higher traffic, this dense stolon can be seen with Parsing Goggles or even with the naked eye. Note that some Vices are able to camouflage their network, including their stolon, known as --omicron Vices. Some Hosts are even able to feel the stolon in the form of a stuffy nose, blocked ears, or sore throat.

Over time, and as more resources are deposited, the rumen begins to resemble its core, becoming a pile of dark, pulsing flesh that emanates the smells present at advent. Long-standing rumina have been known to develop simple eye-like growths that help monitor the goings-on around them. While these growths do not literally “see” they do help monitor environmental fluctuations and can sense movement or changes in light and temperature. Bone, teeth, and nails from the original carcass are likely to shift within the rumen as it grows and are sometimes visible in its thick outer skin. In extremely established rumina, these organs can sometimes begin to resemble those of the Host.

Rumina are not ambulatory, though larger masses tend to pulsate as they internally redirect their energy reserves. Some have also been known to stretch or contract in response to stimuli. They are not sentient like the core, and information is not stored in rumina.

A rumen is created as an external energy reserve that can be used to supplement feeding, but they are most commonly used to fuel explosive core growth during an advantageous Branch. When the Vice initiates a Branch near an established rumen, the Vice core will “suck” the contents of the rumen into the Host's compromised body using the stolon. It tends to enter the Host's system through orifices, such as the mouth,

nose, or ears. This transportation can be interrupted by those outside of the Branch by summoning a patch to destroy the remaining rumen or sever the stolon.

Most Vices that do deign to establish a rumen do so multiple times throughout their life cycle, with more mature Vices being able to manage multiple rumen at once. All rumina must maintain connection to the core through its stolon, and any disruptions in connection can trigger the rumen to begin disintegrating. While this stolon is not rigid in a literal sense, the further a Host strays from an established rumen, the more strain the stolon puts on a Vice's network, and by extension, the Host's body. This is often observed in complaints of exhaustion, inexplicable body aches, and lack of motivation. The closer the Host gets to the stolon's limit, the more inexplicable pain and exhaustion is inflicted. Sharp headaches and aching joints are common complaints.

If the Host strays too far from the rumen, the stolon will snap or detach, rendering the rumen temporarily unusable. If the Host returns to frequenting the area where the rumen was established—and not too much of it has disintegrated—the Vice can reattach the rumen to its core using its stolon.

When a rumen detaches from its core or if a rumen is destroyed, a burst of VG is released, the frayed stolon and disintegrating rumen spewing VG into the environment. Because there is no longer a drain on their system, Hosts often feel a sudden, inexplicable increase in energy that, in some cases, can be disorienting or nauseating. The increased level of VG in the surrounding environment tends to agitate or excite Vices nearby, often spawning rogue Branches. This process floods the surrounding environment with VG and aids in the reproduction of Vices.

Reactivity & Defense

Mechanisms

Vices are particular creatures, both about their diet and their environment. If either are disturbed or become unreliable, a Vice has many different ways that it takes action to ensure its safety and well-being.

Vice cores prefer a relatively steady flow of hormones and a stable environmental temperature of anywhere between 98 and 100 degrees fahrenheit. Because this is not always guaranteed, larval Vices focus on hoarding hormones for times of scarcity and uncertainty. Many larval Vices also redirect their energy reserves to bolster their epithelium—a thick, blubbery outer layer that acts as insulation for the core in harsh environments. This layer not only helps the Vice regulate temperature, but it can also shield against attacks, such as AV, antibiotics, or white blood cells. This layer is not impenetrable, however, and needs to be repaired often.

Once a Vice matures to the adolescent stage, it begins establishing tracks, known collectively as the network. Tracks are not literal extensions of the core, rather, these tendril-like appendages are dense collections of vitiumnexa (VN), unique cells that sense changes in the environment and send rudimentary information back to the core for processing.

More established tracks are also able to ensnare passing hormones, which are absorbed into the porous track and sent back to the core for processing. A network is essentially how a Vice is able to "see" their environment and learn their Host's behaviors in order to brace for any impending threats or act on an opportunity to initiate a Branch. Some Vices even create external tracks—known as stolons—to monitor the properties of the environment outside of the Host, such as temperature, humidity, and even smells and sounds.

The exact details of what a Vice considers threatening varies between classifications and even individual Vices. Though, generally speaking, Vices consider drastic changes in the environment as a threat, such as a sharp increase in body temperature, a sudden drop in hormone production, or an unexpected wave of AV—from a Suppressant dose, an AV Shot, or even from an attack by a blunt patch.

Every classification shares a similar "core reactivity". This gauge gives an overview of how quickly a Vice is

to "retreat" when being attacked. Most combat is done in the Branch Domain, with the most efficient form of taming a Vice's growth being a commit, wherein the Vice is driven to terminate the Branch once the core is damaged. Suspension, similarly, is achieved when the core is threatened while a Branch is in staging, causing the Vice to terminate the Branch. Core reactivity gives a good idea of how much damage (or threat of damage) is required to force the Vice to terminate the Branch. Neither low nor high reactivity indicates elevated threat; it instead informs potential attack strategies and suggests the type of patch that will best combat the Vice's exhibition. Learn more about the core reactivity of individual classifications in *Classifying Vices*.

Common Defense Mechanisms

Rogue Branches

While Vices tend to follow patterns when initiating Branches—these patterns being part of the Branch Policy—in rare instances, they can deviate from their expected behavior and initiate Branches in reaction to a perceived threat, known as a rogue Branch. Rogue Branches are often used to distract a Host and catch them off guard if a Vice feels that it is losing a clear view of the Host's status, often the result of unexpected biofeedback, a sudden drop in hormones, or even an influx of AV from an AV Shot. Rogue Branches can be further explored in *The Branch Phenomenon: Fringe Branch Events*.

Fusion

If a Vice core is threatened outside of the Branch Domain, particularly by manual intervention, the core is likely to fuse with the Host's body, solidifying its form to withstand external stressors. Fused cores are temporarily unable to continue growing, though after the threat has passed, their rigid structure begins to soften. Many Vices will also choose to fuse specific parts of the core, in what many see as a warning, wherein the Vice will fully perform fusion if the stressors persist.

The act of fusion, especially when performed on or near vital organs, can be lethal, as the fused viscera loses its anatomical function, essentially becoming dead tissue, even after the Vice has softened. While the fused core itself does not spread, the damage can leech out into and kill surrounding tissue, often resulting in the need for amputations or organ transplants.

Fusion is not without its drawbacks, however. This process can also damage the Vice core if sustained for too long, making it more susceptible to attacks from AV and patches. A fused core, even partially, cannot initiate dispersion, which requires the Vice core to stretch itself throughout the Host's body. For this reason, fusion is only executed when the Vice is under extreme duress as a last-ditch effort to avoid rescission.

Vice cores only initiate fusion when they are externally threatened, and the damage incurred in the Branch Domain does not put the core at risk of triggering fusion. However, suspension can run the risk of prompting fusion, particularly when piercing or slashing patches are used. If a core fuses during staging, the Branch will be suspended, though the benefits of suspending a Branch do not outweigh the potentially lethal side effects of fusion.

Shedding (Delta Vices only)

Shedding is a defense mechanism unique to Delta Vices. Shedding is only triggered when the Vice feels threatened, but Deltas have extremely reactive cores and a broad definition of what is deemed a “threat”, especially in the larval stage. They can react to direct, intentional threats, such as AV Shots and committing Branches, or entirely benign and unintentional behaviors, such as shifts in hormone levels and contracting the flu. As the Vice matures, this sensitivity tends to dull, and the Vice begins exhibiting discernment instead of reacting to every possible trigger. Shedding is, after all, extremely energy-intensive.

When threatened, a Delta will “shed” a modified, information-rich protrusion from its core. This protrusion—called a core extension—contains the information for the Branch Domain and exhibition presentation. The rest of the core—called the core body—houses the remaining Branch Policy, stores VG, creates the network, and handles energy processing. Each shed results in a clean slate for the Branch Domain and exhibition presentation and allows the Vice to “revise” its plans, using information stored in the core body to concoct its next iteration.

Learn more about the shedding process in *Classifying Vices: Delta Vices*.

Branch Policy Obfuscation (Epsilon Vices only)

Epsilon Vices are one of the only classifications to intentionally withhold key properties of the Branch

Policy. An Epsilon's gradual advent provides it with an incredibly complex Branch Policy that it can selectively and intentionally choose to shroud pieces of, even as the Vice matures. For example, Epsilon exhibitions tend to have hydra-like characteristics or multiple sets of limbs. They prefer to keep these appendages shrouded by long hair or dense feathers and only reveal them as a trump card when they have been cornered or are attempting dispersion. Additionally, as the Vice matures, its Branch Domain can reveal previously hidden areas, called “stages”.

Epsilons hold on to these obfuscated properties as they mature. Only once it's backed into a corner will an Epsilon reveal these properties in an attempt to swing the Branch back in its favor. Unlike rogue Branches that explicitly deviate from the established Branch Policy, an Epsilon's Branch obfuscation is much less risky, pulling from conditions explicitly established during advent.

Learn more about this defense mechanism and how it changes as the Vice matures in *Classifying Vices: Epsilon Vices*.

Vice Reproduction

Vices use vitiumglomerorum (VG) to reproduce. Once the core has been established, it can work on producing VG to be distributed in various ways, most commonly seen in the act of dispersion, though the detachment of rumen can also aid in reproduction.

Vitiumglomerorum (VG)

Due to the recent rise in Vice infections, these microscopic spores are found in detectable amounts throughout our world and can even be seen with the naked eye in high concentrations. VG most commonly enter our body through orifices and microscopic tears in the skin, but are small enough to enter through our pores as well. Over time, large concentrations of VG in the body can drastically alter the genetic makeup of soft tissue and benign masses to result in the birth of a Vice.

Vices begin creating VG from the moment of inception. In addition to its reproductive services, VG plays an important role in initiating Branches. The trademark disorientation around Branches would not be possible without the release of VG. Because of this increase in free-roaming VG throughout the body, Branches often result in a slight increase of environmental VG, as some are bound to leave the body.

Ultimately, Vice reproduction occurs as a result of the VG that we amass from our environment. Large concentrations—whether they're the result of dispersion or rumen detachment—tend to deposit considerable amounts of VG in the body when disturbed. The VG lay dormant until a burst of hormones brings it to life in a sudden advent. Alternatively, a gradual increase in hormone levels over a longer period of time can result in a gradual advent.

VG are unavoidable, but they're not indestructible. Our bodies are able to defend against these invasive spores using traditional biological tactics, such as deploying white blood cells or raising the body's internal temperature. Recently, our bodies have adapted and begun producing antivitiumglomerorum (AV), the perfect counter-molecule to VG. These defense measure are only deployed, however, if the body detects VG.

Vices successfully reproduce in one of two ways. The large majority of VG that collects in our bodies is done so gradually, where the overall levels of VG increases at a near-imperceptible rate until it results in advent. Conversely, massive introductions of VG to the body tend to overwhelm the immune system, and even if defensive measures are deployed, they are not efficient or effective enough to combat the extreme VG levels. Our defense mechanisms tend to only be triggered when a Vice takes action and pursues augmentation or germination during Branches.

Reproductive Methods

Vices reproduce using VG, but they also have specialized methods of projecting these spores into the environment. While Branches can result in some VG leakage, dispersion and rumen detachment are a Vice's primary and secondary reproductive methods, respectively.

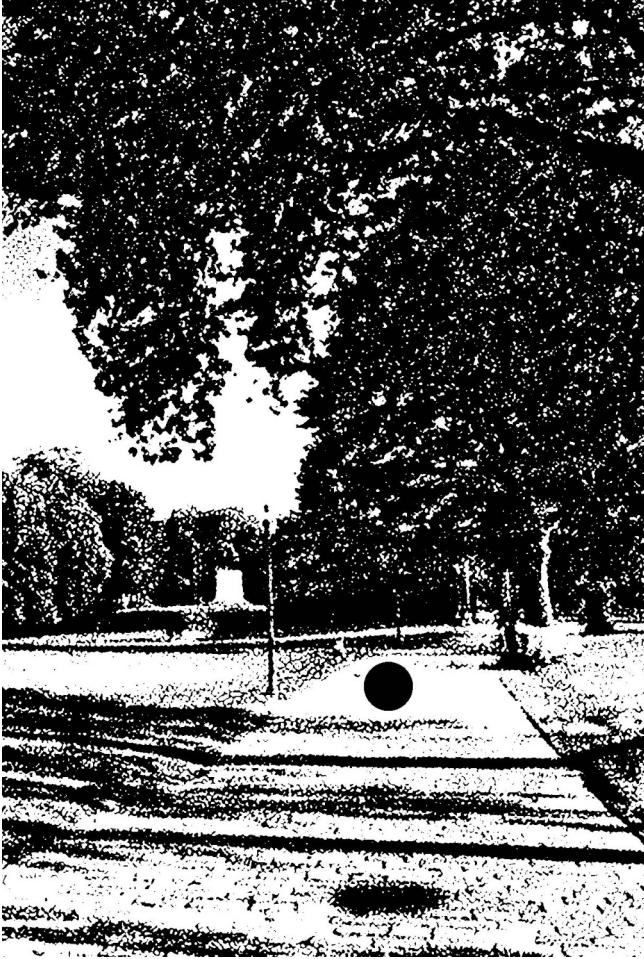
Content Warning

The passages below contain information that may be uncomfortable for some readers. The act of dispersion entails the mutilation of the human body, which is outlined in detail below. Proceed with caution or skip to the next section (*pg. 19: Rumen Detachment*)

Dispersion

Dispersion is a process expressly reserved for reproduction and therefore has the highest return on investment. Dispersion is the result of an unaddressed Branch—one that is not suspended, committed or rescinded. This means that the Branch keeps the Host and any Adjuncts trapped in the Branch Domain while the Vice continues germination and augmentation. Some Adjuncts are capable of exiting the Branch in this state, though it is extremely difficult to do so, as the longer an Adjunct is kept in an active Branch, the deeper their ties to the Host and the more powerful the trance.

During a Branch, most Vices pursue either augmentation or germination. Germination is the act of expanding the network, while augmentation entails growing the core. Most classifications pursue germination before augmentation, as a well-established network lays a nutrient-rich path for the core to expand along. While high network density is not required for successful dispersion, it makes the augmentation process much more efficient and provides the growing core with the nutrients needed to continue expanding.



If a Branch is allowed to progress for an extended time, the Vice will inevitably begin pursuing excessive augmentation, resulting in a berserk Host. Despite the body's best efforts, it will not be able to defend against the advancing Vice, which will continue to expand its core until the Branch is addressed. If no action is taken, or if the extensions fail in addressing the Branch, the Vice will expand its core throughout the entirety of the Host's body, following the network. After it has finished expanding, the core will begin fusing with the soft tissue, muscles, and organs nearby, resulting in a comatose Host. Branches can still be addressed at this stage, though the Host is likely to incur significant internal damage. If the Branch remains unaddressed, dispersion begins.

Dispersion typically occurs in the blink of an eye, in an explosive event that often results in electrical surges or power outages. After the Vice core has fused with more than 75% of the Host's body, the fused

parts liquidate into a slurry of the expanded core and the Host's viscera, which is quickly sucked back into the core's center, bringing the surrounding parts of the Host's body with it in a grotesque display of cracking bones and squelching organs. The entirety of the Host's body is compacted inside the core to create an incredibly dense concentration of matter in a two-inch sphere so dark that it absorbs light and appears flat.

The second that the core initiates this retraction, it dismisses the Adjuncts from the Branch Domain. Adjuncts have at most 3 seconds to distance themselves from the Host, though this is often difficult to do, as the act of dismissal is quite disorienting.

Upon retraction, the Vice then uses the Host's body as fuel to disperse hundreds of millions of VG in an explosive, shockwave-like event. Due to their proximity, the bodies of the recently expelled Adjuncts are overwhelmed with the super-charged VG that immediately latch onto and fuse with their organs in incredibly dense collections. The sheer force of dispersion provides these VG with the power to overtake the Adjunct's body and perform the process of dispersion yet again, sucking the Adjunct's body into a dense sphere that sends another round of VG out into the ether to infect passersby. This domino effect occurs regardless of the Adjunct's infection status and drastically increases the reach of VG.

Those within an immediate radius but not brought in as Adjuncts are the most susceptible to a higher, but not lethal, concentration of VG. Those as far as 10 meters away are still susceptible to contracting noticeable amounts of VG. Dispersion is generally regarded as a traumatic event, and witnessing a dispersion in person often results in the advent of a Vice, due in large part to the elevated hormone levels from stress and the newly-acquired VG from the nearby dispersion. If a Host is already infected, the influx of VG often excites the Vice and results in a rogue Branch.

All things considered, dispersion is relatively uncommon, only observed in the event of unaddressed Branches from particularly intelligent and mature Vices. Refer to *Classifying Vices* to see which classifications pose a higher threat of dispersion.

Failed Dispersions

While most Vices that initiate dispersion are successful, some less mature or less intelligence Vices have been known to "panic" and prematurely initiate

dispersion before 75% or more of the body has been fused with its core. While extremely rare, this results in what is essentially a disemboweling, where the core is only successful in retracting some of the Host's body. The attempted shockwave is drastically impeded by the mostly still in-tact Host's body, resulting in a burst of energy that typically shatters the Host's bones, muscles, and skin. The VG stored for dispersion are still released, but are typically confined to a finite radius and can be easily cleaned up by a Branch Recovery Specialist. While rare, no Host has ever survived a failed dispersion. Failed dispersions are unlikely, as most Vices that are less mature or less intelligent will resort to other defense mechanisms—such as fusion—before prematurely initiating dispersion.

Rumen Detachment

Most Vices that manage to create a rumen typically experience rumen detachment at least once in its life cycle. Rumen detachment occurs when a Host strays too far from the established rumen, putting immense strain on the Vice's rigid stolon, causing it to snap. This removes the drain of nutrients from the Host, often resulting in an inexplicable burst of energy. Rumen can also be manually detached from the Host by using a patch to sever the stolon.

Immediately, the rumen begins disintegrating, emitting a steady stream of VG into the environment. Because the act of rumen detachment is a relatively low-energy process, the VG expelled tend to hang around the area, permeating a two-meter radius around the disintegrating rumen. Only those that breach the radius are at risk of coming into contact with the VG.

Orphaned rumina are typically dealt with using an AV Charge or can be damaged manually by using a summoned patch. If a rumen is damaged using a non-AV-charged object, it deploys a behavior similar to core fusion wherein the rumen hardens, then becomes extremely brittle. Even gentle touch can trigger a collapse, releasing a cloud of VG into the air.

Even attached rumen can be a threat. If you encounter a rumen—attached or detached—please contact your local Public Deployment, and a Branch Recovery Specialist will be dispatched to address the situation.

Classifying Vices

Vices are classified by shared behaviors and characteristics. These classifications provide insight on expected Vice behaviors and are crucial in preparing properly for rescission.

Receiving a professional classification is encouraged, as some Vices are known to be deceiving or are difficult to observe. While the classifications outlined below serve as a general guide for understanding these Vices, anomalies can and are likely occur. Please contact info@cvrs.com with any anomalies, questions or concerns. Before diving into classifications, we recommend familiarizing yourself with *The Branch Phenomenon* to establish a foundation in Branch mechanics.

Class Evolution

As stated in *Evolution and Intelligence*, Vices continue to evolve at an alarming rate. As new behaviors are established, our Behavioral Analysts present possible classifications and sub-classifications to help prepare our agents.

It is understood that all Vices originated from Alpha Vices, with Beta, Xi, and Theta being the first classifications to branch off. While it is relatively difficult to follow the exact path of evolution due to their reproductive method, the levels below gives us valuable insight into shared behaviors and can even aid in constructing plans of attack.

Threat Levels

Vice classifications can be further categorized by their threat level, ranging from low to critical. This threat level informs Record Proctors and Vice Management Administrators on what materials or staff are needed for treatment and determines the probability for success.

Low

Vices with a low threat level can often be rescinded without Adjuncts. Patches are recommended if planning to self-treat. If desired, Vices in this category can be treated with exposure rescission.

Medium

Adjuncts are encouraged when addressing Vices with a medium threat level. Patches are also encouraged if planning to self-treat. Professional treatment via CVRS provides the highest chance of a successful rescission.

High

Multiple Adjuncts and patches are mandatory when addressing Vices with a high threat level. Self-treating is not advised. Establishing a CVRS care team early in the Vice's life cycle is imperative to a successful rescission.

Critical

Rescission is not guaranteed and is unlikely, regardless of Adjuncts, patches, and preparation. This threat level is reserved exclusively for Omega Vices.

Classifying Vices

Table of Contents

Primary classifications serve to inform Hosts of their Vice's expected behavior. A Vice's classification is synonymous with its primary class. The classes outlined below each have their own page that goes into more detail and provides high-level guidance on approaching rescission for each life stage, as well as expected Branch Policies, and a recommended care team. We recommend that all Hosts, regardless of their Vice's threat level, seek counsel and treatment from a CVRS team.

Classification is not an instantaneous process. Multiple appointments and consultations with a Record Proctor may be required to perform accurate classification. Classifications may change in the early larval stage as they reveal more information, but anomalies at any stage are likely to occur. Some classifications are capable of deceit and restraint, making accurate classification difficult, and some even mimic others in early life stages.

Alpha^{LOW} 23

Alpha Vices are the most common of the classifications, making up 65% of all Vices. These Vices are typically straightforward to treat due to their relatively predictable nature and low intelligence. Alpha Vices are generally considered to be the initial pool from which all other Vices evolved and deviated.

Beta^{MEDIUM} 26

Beta Vices are often viewed as the more intelligent, "evolved" version of Alpha Vices. Due to their gradual advent, these Vices have a more complex Branch Policy and higher threat level compared to Alpha Vices. Their prioritization of germination results in complex, well-established networks and small, elusive cores.

Delta^{MEDIUM} 29

Delta Vices are a unique, elusive classification that can be tricky to treat without the proper resources. These timid Vices undergo the unique process of core "shedding" when threatened, wherein the Vice abandons both the Branch Domain blueprint and exhibition presentation properties of its Branch Policy. This disorienting defense mechanism often results in the Host's memory loss.

Epsilon^{HIGH} 33

Epsilon Vices are extremely difficult to treat due to their deceptive nature. While Delta Vices shed, Epsilon Vices instead opt to keep parts of their Branch Policy hidden. Information can be gathered for all properties, but it may be incomplete. Epsilon Vices will use this gap in knowledge to their advantage to surprise Hosts and Adjuncts in the Branch Domain by expanding hidden areas of the domain or even revealing previously shrouded exhibition characteristics.

Zeta^{HIGH} 37

A Zeta core has a unique epithelium that attracts hormones from throughout the body, acting as a lightning rod that allows them to feed consistently through all life stages. Because of this, Hosts with Zeta Vices tend to display extreme, visible signs of fatigue. These Vices have advanced storage capacity and are able to hoard more resources than the average Vice, in addition to having a penchant for establishing rumina. If allowed to mature, Zeta Vices can be extremely difficult to address due to their established, often numerous energy reserves.

Theta^{MEDIUM} 41

Theta Vices thrive on chaos and are notorious for their trademark explosive Branch after a period of sustained feeding. Theta Vices have a wider-than-average staging radius and aim to admit as many tertiary Adjuncts as possible to this attempted dispersion. Though intimidating, these Vices can be easily addressed if caught early.

Lambda^{HIGH} 44

Lambda Vices are a relatively rare classification of Vice that deviates from all expected behavioral norms. Lambda Vices always have a sudden advent, but the Branch initiated at advent is leaps and bounds more complex than any other classification's. Hosts with a Lambda Vice should be addressed by a Branch Administrator. If the Branch is addressed, future Branches will drastically decrease in severity.

Xi^{MEDIUM} 47

Xi Vices are often misclassified as Vices due to their relatively predictable early life. As these Vices mature, Branches become more complex, including exhibitions. While some tweaking to the Branch Policy between Branches is to be expected, the rate at which these properties evolve in Xi Vices can quickly become threatening.

Phi^{LOW} 50

Phi Vices are a somewhat uncommon and bizarre classification of Vice that is so chaotic and dysfunctional in its makeup that it barely has enough energy to maintain its form--let alone the Branch initiated at its sudden advent. While these brittle Vices can easily be addressed, Hosts should remain vigilant, as the advent of a Phi Vice indicates a susceptibility to infection that can result in contracting another Vice.

Omega^{CRITICAL} 51

This extremely rare classification is often applied post-dispersion, as the properties of Omega Vices tend to shift in unexpected, unprecedented ways that other classifications do not, often resulting in lethal misclassifications. The Omega classification is reserved for Vices that cannot be categorized by any of the other classifications, essentially acting as a fringe category of Vices.

Subclasses 52

In certain cases, further classification may be applied to provide a more complete understanding of a Host's Vice, called subclasses. Subclasses differ from primary classes in that they are unique behaviors or characteristics found throughout all classifications. They are typically concerned with a single behavior or characteristic, rather than a set of criteria.

Alpha Vices

Alpha Vices are the most common of the classifications, making up 65% of all Vices. These Vices are typically straightforward to treat due to their relatively predictable nature and lack of aggression. Alpha Vices are generally considered to be the initial pool from which all other Vices evolved and deviated.

- **Threat Level:** Low
- **Intelligence:** Low
- **Core Reactivity:** High
- **Energy Use:** Augmentation
- **Relative Core Size:** Small
- **Exhibition:** Meso-offensive
- **Advent:** Sudden

Alpha Vices are known for their sudden advent with a weak, but stable Branch initiation. As they mature, they have non-threatening blights and regular, predictable Branches with a transparent Branch Policy. This collection of properties typically results in straightforward treatment plans that involve observing early Branches and performing rescission in the adolescent phase before the Vice can mature. Alpha Vices rarely progress past the adolescent stage and only occasionally result in berserk Hosts, as their Branch Policies are easy to prepare for and their prioritization of core augmentation often result in a compromised core susceptible to attacks. Alphas are typically classified in the early to mid larval stage, roughly 2-3 weeks after advent.

Because Alphas prioritize augmentation before germination, blight activity is generally quite rare before late adolescence; though, an expulsion blight is likely to manifest in the late larval or early adolescent stage due to the core augmentation.

Both blight activity and Branch activity are not used in determining the initial classification; rather, they are instead used to look for misclassifications. Theta and Xi Vices are commonly misclassified as Alphas in their early life stages due to their similarities, and agitated blights or elevated Branch activity in the larval stage can be indicative of other classifications. Learn more about behavioral distinctions below in *Misclassifications*.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

In the larval stage, Alpha Vices are relatively calm, focusing primarily on feeding and storing VG for

future Branches. While not terribly active, they can still be expected to initiate a small handful of exploratory Branches. These early Branches are quite predictable, as many of the properties found at advent are likely triggers, and Branch Domains remain quite simple. They tend to be less threatening and can be easily addressed with any patch, though patches often do not manifest until adolescence, when the Vice becomes a marginally larger threat. Objects found in the Branch Domain and even manual combat are perfectly suitable alternatives to a patch and can easily overwhelm a larval Alpha exhibition.

Young Alpha exhibitions are inexperienced and reactive. They are quick to concede with only minimal damage being applied to the core. Because of this, rescinding at this stage can be tricky, but can be performed with brute force, if needed.

Expulsion blights tend to manifest shortly before adolescence, signaling the attempted advancement of the Vice core and marking the shift toward more aggressive behaviors.

Rescission Guidance

While it may sound counter-intuitive, rescinding larval Alpha Vices tends to be more challenging than rescinding adolescents. Alpha cores are small and dense, making it difficult to land accurate blows without triggering the premature termination of a Branch. It is recommended to spend the larval stage learning its Branch Policy and committing Branches until it matures to adolescence and has a larger, less dense core. If rescission must be pursued, we recommend doing so with a Vice Management Administrator.

Stage 2: Adolescent

Branch activity increases drastically in adolescence, greatly limiting the time between Branches. Adolescents tend to initiate Branches at every possible trigger established at advent, making it relatively easy to prepare for or even bait Branches. While other classifications often require a Bypass to instigate a Branch, adolescent Alphas are so reactive and eager to initiate a Branch that a subtle change in environment to mirror the properties of advent can be enough to bait a Branch.

Repeated Branches often trigger the manifestation of a patch in early adolescence as the Host's body adjusts to the increase in Branch activity.

While most adolescent Vices prioritize germination before augmentation, adolescent Alphas stay true to their impulsivity and pursue augmentation at every possible instance. Because of this unbiased prioritization, adolescent Alpha cores tend to stretch and become less dense. They are often brittle and much more susceptible to lethal attacks in the Branch Domain compared to their larval counterparts. Additionally, adolescent Alpha cores typically reach a cap in augmentation, as germination progress is needed to grow the core past a certain size.

As adolescent Alphas pursue augmentation, expulsion blights often become agitated, resulting in repeated instances of acute blights. This differs from chronic blights, in that these individual instances only last for short bursts of time, up to two days at most; whereas, chronic blights can last for months at a time. Because of their lack of germination progress, drape and extrusion blights are typically not common in this life stage, and any elevated blight activity can be easily drawn to augmentation progress.

Rescission Guidance

When looking to rescind an Alpha Vice, doing so at the adolescent stage yields the most successful results. Because adolescent Alphas are so impulsive and reactive, pursuing rescission is recommended at this stage, as it is easy to take advantage of these characteristics and bait a Branch to pursue rescission on the Host's own terms, when the proper resources have been gathered. While not integral to success, we always recommend pursuing rescission with at least one secondary Adjunct. Adolescent Alphas tend to ignore Adjuncts and primarily target the Host, often leading to a quick and efficient rescission if the Adjunct wields their patch well. Because adolescents have begun prioritizing augmentation, their core is much less dense and more susceptible to lethal blows.

Stage 3: Mature

Many Alphas do not make it to maturity, as the intelligence and discernment required to mature to this stage are not typically exercised. Alphas that have been allowed to mature tend to show a bit more restraint than in adolescence. Though, mature Alphas are still considered impulsive and do not display as much discernment in initiating Branches as those with a higher threat level do; however, they are less likely to be baited into Branches, and manual Branch instigation will be required to trigger Branches when pursuing rescission.

Alphas that do make it to maturity tend to prioritize augmentation less and focus more on germination, as they have realized that neglecting germination progress in their youth has generally capped its augmentation capabilities. Germination, as a process, is viewed by mature Alphas as a means to an end; as such, complex networks are not terribly common. Rather, short bursts of progress are made before refocusing on augmentation, showcasing more of the trademark Alpha impulsivity. For this reason, mature Alphas generally don't exhibit complex networks, and blights are never terribly agitated outside of the expected expulsion blights.

Mature exhibitions are typically at the larger end of meso-exhibitions at around five feet tall. The primary difference between adolescent and mature Alpha exhibitions lies in their power. Rescission is still likely if the proper preparations are made. Adjuncts are recommended at this stage, as it is relatively easy to overwhelm them with multiple extensions in the Branch Domain.

Rescission Guidance

While most Alphas do not make it to maturity, the same strategy used for rescinding adolescents can also be applied to mature Vices. The primary difference between the two stages lies in the Vice's increase in power, though with a dedicated team of Adjuncts, rescission should be just as achievable. Mature Alphas do still tend to target the Host in the Branch Domain and can be distracted or even overwhelmed by multiple primary or secondary Adjuncts. Due to the prioritization of augmentation, mature cores tend to be larger, which are able to fuel their power, but are still relatively vulnerable during Branches.

Branch Policy Properties

Alphas are known for their strict adherence to their established Branch Policy. The properties explored below are generalizations and are not guaranteed to apply to every Alpha Vice.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

An Alpha's sudden advent results in straightforward and predictable Branch triggers. Alphas tend to favor smells and specific seasonal indicators, such as a heat wave or sudden thunderstorm; though, they are often not terribly picky in the triggers they choose to act on. Adolescent Alphas are known for their impulsivity and reactivity, which isn't dulled much in maturity.

Because of their strict adherence to their Branch Policy, rogue Branches are not common, unless severely threatened.

Branch Domain Blueprint

Due to their sudden advent, Alpha Branch Domains tend to be relatively simple, often consisting of a single room or “stage”. Because of this, Alpha staging times are generally shorter than those of other classifications. Details of the Branch Domain start out as fuzzy and vague, and increase in sharpness and clarity with maturity, though they rarely increase in complexity.

Exhibition Presentation

Alpha exhibitions are typically between four and five feet tall, most commonly hovering around the higher end. Because they generally prioritize offense, they often have a stronger upper body and share characteristics with common mammalian predators, such as dogs, wolves, and big cats. Over time, its offensive features are likely to be emphasized, leading to larger teeth and claws.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

Alpha exhibitions are generally offensive and mimic the hunting habits of the mammalian predators they often resemble. This leads to many engaging in a sort of “stalking” behavior before attacking. Alpha exhibitions prioritize attack, but often leave themselves vulnerable in the process by coming into close range of the Host or Adjuncts. Alpha cores are also highly reactive and typically terminate Branches after the core has received minimal damage.

Priorities

Alpha cores tend to prioritize core augmentation over germination, often resulting in vulnerable cores that are extremely susceptible to damage from successful commits. Because of their neglected network, Alpha cores tend to cap out at specific sizes.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address an Alpha Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are

experts on your specific Vice’s behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Vice Management Coordinator

These agents are often enlisted to help Vice Management Administrators keep track of Vice details and provide extra firepower in the Branch Domain, if necessary.

Misclassifications

Because all classifications originated from Alpha Vices, many are erroneously classified as Alphas before their true nature is observed. Xi and Theta Vices in particular bear a striking resemblance to Alpha Vices in their early larval stage, but begin to deviate into their own as they mature.

Especially in adolescence, Theta Vices are more concerned with establishing their network, and Xi Vices begin to enhance their Branch Policy to a degree never observed in Alphas. Adolescent Theta Branch activity is often much higher than that of adolescent Alphas, and Xis tend to exhibit a thoughtful, calculated approach in the Branch Domain that contrasts greatly with Alphas’ impulsivity and lack of tact.

Learning the subtle differences between these classifications can help lead to proper classifications and avoid allowing Vices to mature into something unmanageable.

Beta Vices

Beta Vices are often viewed as the more intelligent, “evolved” version of Alpha Vices. Due to their gradual advent, these Vices have a more complex Branch Policy and higher threat level compared to Alpha Vices. Their prioritization of germination results in complex, well-established networks and small, elusive cores.

- **Threat Level:** Medium
- **Intelligence:** Low
- **Core Reactivity:** Moderate
- **Energy Use:** Germination
- **Relative Core Size:** Small
- **Exhibition:** Meso-balanced
- **Advent:** Gradual

Beta Vices were the first classification to deviate from Alpha Vices, due in large part to the introduction of gradual advents. The complexity of gradual advents led to Vices with more aggressive blights and a higher propensity for what many mistake as “rogue” Branches. These Branches are not so much “rogue” as they are simply Branches pulling from a broad collection of environmental triggers established during the Vice’s often lengthy gradual advent.

A Beta Vice prioritizes germination, resulting in more Branches throughout its life cycle, especially in adolescence. Because their broad pool of triggers is difficult to prepare for in early stages, Beta Vices result in berserk Hosts more often than Alpha Vices. More mature Beta Vices use their complex, well-established network to pave the way for extremely thorough, well-timed augmentation prior to dispersion.

While these Vices have a higher threat level than Alpha Vices, they are no more intelligent or crafty in the creation of their Branch Policy. The key to addressing Beta Vices lies in unraveling its complex environmental Branch triggers, which can then be bested by maintaining composure and applying brute force. Beta Vices rely on catching Hosts off guard rather than prioritizing complex arenas and exhibitions.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

Beta Vices can be somewhat active in their larval stage, but are generally considered tame compared to Vices of the same threat level. Due to their gradual advent, the Branch Policy of a Beta Vice is often

difficult to pin down during the larval stage, leading to a broad, seemingly disconnected collection of environmental Branch triggers.

In anticipation of their germination as they mature, larval Beta Vices generally feed more than Alpha Vices and are more skilled at ensnaring passing hormones due to biological deviations. While Alpha Vices tend to have a smooth core, the epithelium around larval Beta cores are wispy, almost hairy, displaying what are essentially rudimentary network tracks. This causes them to appear somewhat fuzzy on a VGMS. This fuzziness results in quick classification times, which are often applied shortly after a positive VGDS.

Due to their “hairy” epithelium, Betas are more discerning in their retreat, using these fuzzy proto-tracks as a gauge to make more informed decisions. Even if a larval Beta core is not hit directly, but its epithelium senses and processes the attack as something life-threatening, it will terminate the Branch prematurely.

Rescission Guidance

Rescission at this stage is encouraged, as allowing the Vice to mature will only give it the opportunity to perfect its Branch Domain attack strategy. Larval Beta cores are still quite reactive, so accuracy, efficiency and power are all imperative when wielding a patch. After classification, establishing a CVRS care team is imperative to success. The varied arsenal of patches available from CVRS agents can aid in addressing a larval Beta Vice quickly and efficiently.

Stage 2: Adolescent

While most adolescent Vices are generally impulsive and rambunctious, adolescent Beta Vices tend to be even more so, eager to pursue a more complex network or capitalize on a recently-expanded network. Due to its gradual advent, the environmental Branch triggers can be relatively difficult to pin down. Beta Vices take advantage of this ambiguity by initiating Branches often, using different combinations of Branch triggers so as to avoid the Host accurately preparing for Branches. Additionally, adolescent Beta Vices use the time the Host spends on orienting themselves at the beginning of the Branch to establish and then greatly expand their network.

Because of these established networks, many Hosts exhibit severe acute blights during Branches and chronic drape blights between Branches. A Blight

Specialist is likely to prescribe daily Suppressants to provide relief, while a Record Proctor performs rigorous VGMS between Branches to monitor Vice behavior.

Relying on the more complex Branch Domains that result from a gradual advent, adolescent Beta exhibitions are often a product of their environment, having characteristics that enable them to efficiently interact with the domain. As they mature, they solidify this relationship with their domain, resulting in an attack style that balances attack, defense, and evasion.

Adolescent Beta cores tend to shed the fuzzy epithelium found in the larval stage in favor of its more advanced and efficient network. As the network expands, the core remains relatively compact, waiting for opportune times to pursue augmentation. Regular AV Shots can be used to both tame excessive germination and damage the elusive core, though they do risk instigating rogue Branches.

Rescission Guidance

Rescinding adolescent Beta Vices is generally straightforward, especially when the Branch is initiated on the Host's time as a result of instigation, rather than trying to orient oneself in an unexpected Branch where the Vice has the upper hand. Due to their prioritization of germination, adolescent Beta cores tend to remain generally small and compact, making them difficult to target; however, most Hosts receive their patch in early adolescence, and they are often well-suited for targeting these smaller cores. If a Host's patch is not efficient, patch calibration services are available through Primary Care, but we recommend instead pursuing care through a Vice Management Administrator who can enlist the proper resources to rescind the Vice before it can mature further.

Stage 3: Mature

Because Beta Vices prioritize germination so heavily during adolescence, they begin to exhibit a dangerous intentionality in maturity. Augmentation is now pursued thoughtfully, resulting in larger, but still incredibly dense cores. Because of their established networks, mature Beta Vices are likely to create rumina and better survey the environment with stolons to initiate more advantageous Branches and take advantage of high-stress situations to catch the Host off guard with potentially lethal Branches.

By this time, a Host is likely to have outlined the broad array of environmental Branch triggers, but the Vice has often begun prioritizing other facets of its Branch Policy, namely perfecting its exhibition and Branch Domain blueprint. Mature Beta exhibitions are extremely in-tune with their Branch Domain and are able to utilize the environment to bolster their attack, defense, and evasion strategies equally. Even if a Host is able to predict and prepare for a Branch, they often have trouble both defending against and attacking a mature Beta exhibition.

Rescission Guidance

Because of their dense cores, mature Beta Vices require a care team similar in composition to its adolescent stage, with a focus on power. The threat of mature Beta exhibitions does not necessarily lie in their intelligence, but rather in their efficiency and confidence. Though their calculated and methodical attacks can be intimidating in the Branch Domain, their attack strategies are not complex and can generally be bested with brute force, typically with the help of a Vice Management Administrator and a contracted Branch Administrator.

Branch Policy Properties

The most complex facet of a Beta Branch Policy is the vast pool of environmental Branch triggers, while the remaining facets are relatively simple. The properties explored below are generalizations and are not guaranteed to apply to every Beta Vice.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Due to their gradual advent, this pool of triggers is often vast and seemingly disconnected. While other classifications favor specific areas of triggers, such as smells or sounds, Beta Vices tend to exhibit a holistic approach, storing anything from minute details to common, vague characteristics broadly applicable to a wide variety of situations that make understanding these triggers difficult and frustrating. In their early stages, Beta Vices intentionally select varying sets of triggers to prevent Hosts from detecting patterns and avoiding Branches.

Branch Domain Blueprint

While gradual advents tend to result in complex Branch Domains, Beta Vices are often more concerned with establishing triggers from advent, and their Branch Domains tend to lose complexity as a result. These blueprints are still more complex than those of

Alpha Vices and typically feature multiple stages. Examining these stages can provide valuable insight into determining the varying sources of the wide variety of Branch triggers.

Exhibition Presentation

Beta exhibitions are not terribly complex and are often influenced by their Branch Domain; that is to say, if an arena is tall, the exhibition may have wings or a way to scale the walls. Beta exhibitions, like all other classifications, grow in complexity over time, often perfecting these methods of navigating their respective arenas. By maturity, Beta exhibitions are extremely in tune with their Branch Domain and can prove to be extremely difficult to take down.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

Beta exhibitions have a balanced approach in the Branch Domain, often swapping between attack, defense, and evasion. Unlike the more intelligent Xi classification, this swapping is less a result of observation and documentation, and more guided by impulse and instinct. For this reason, Betas can often be easily outsmarted and overpowered by the appropriate team.

Priorities

Beta cores prioritize germination, often resulting in chronic blights. They intend to fully establish their network in adolescence before pursuing augmentation in maturity, paving the way for an efficient dispersion once pursued.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address a Beta Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice's behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Vice Management Coordinator

These agents are often enlisted to help Vice Management Administrators keep track of Vice details and provide extra firepower in the Branch Domain, if necessary.

Solutions Architect

While Solutions Architects are typically enlisted as pseudo Adjuncts to provide attack strategies in the Branch Domain, these agents can also offer their problem-solving skills in determining a Beta Vice's broad pool of triggers in its tricky early stages.

Branch Administrator

These agents are master wielders of their patch and can bring much-needed firepower to addressing a Beta Vice in an efficient and timely manner.

Blight Specialist

Due to their extensive networks, Beta Vices often trigger chronic blights, which can be addressed and relieved by a resident Blight Specialist, either by prescribing Suppressants or administering AV Shots.

Delta Vices

Delta Vices are a unique, elusive classification that can be tricky to treat without the proper resources. These timid Vices undergo the unique process of core “shedding” when threatened, wherein the Vice abandons both the Branch Domain blueprint and exhibition presentation properties of its Branch Policy. This disorienting defense mechanism often results in the Host’s memory loss.

- **Threat Level:** Medium
- **Intelligence:** Medium
- **Core Reactivity:** Very High
- **Energy Use:** Shedding
- **Relative Core Size:** Small
- **Exhibition:** Micro-hasty
- **Advent:** Gradual

Delta Vices are fairly uncommon and require unique treatment solutions, as their cores undergo the distinctive process of “shedding”, wherein Vices abandon the part of their core that stores the information for two facets of their Branch Policy: the Branch Domain blueprint and the exhibition presentation. Learn more about this process below in *Shedding*.

Compared to other classifications, Delta Vices seem much less concerned with achieving dispersion and are focused more on prolonging their individual lives, which lowers their threat level that would otherwise be relatively high. In the Branch Domain, Deltas tend to prioritize avoiding damage over setting the stage for dispersion. Because of this, their network tends to be less established, and their cores remain relatively small throughout their life cycle. Blights also tend to be minor as a result of their less established network.

Different Vices will have differing degrees of sensitivity, but all are considered to have highly reactive cores compared to other classifications. For this reason, successfully rescinding Delta Vices can come as a bit of a challenge, as imprecise blows in the Branch Domain can easily result in a commit instead. Despite this, most Delta Vices do not achieve dispersion, and the few that do are typically mature, having executed numerous sheds.

Delta cores have a distinct shape that allows them to abandon part of their core in the shedding process, further explored below. This distinct core shape aids in early classification and can help Hosts prepare in advance for the shedding process. This early

classification also allows the Host to quickly establish a care team and pursue treatment if desired.

For reasons still unknown, Deltas tend to manifest after drastic life changes, where complex emotions fuel their gradual advent and become the basis of their Branch Policy, even after shedding.

Shedding

Shedding is a defense mechanism exclusively observed in Delta Vices. If a Delta is threatened, it will “shed” a modified, information-rich protrusion from its core. This protrusion—called a core extension—contains the information for the Branch Domain and exhibition presentation. The rest of the core—called the core body—houses the remaining Branch Policy, stores VG, creates the network, and handles energy processing. The body and extension are separated by a membrane similar to the cleavage furrow found in cell mitosis. During shedding, this membrane pinches the core and severs the extension from the body, releasing it into the Host’s bloodstream to be naturally degraded by AV over time.

After shedding, Delta Vices will enter a feeding-focused dormant period, where Branches are less likely. Cores are less reactive during this period, allowing time for AV-focused treatments without risking another shed or triggering a rogue Branch. The duration of this period varies between Vices.

Each shed results in a clean slate for the Branch Domain and exhibition presentation and allows the Vice to “revise” its plans, using information stored in the core body to hone its next iteration. Delta Vices do have a complexity cap, however, and this increase in complexity comes at the expense of energy that could otherwise be put toward germination or augmentation.

During dormancy, it focuses on revising the shed parts of its Branch Policy. Because Delta Vices tend to be nonconfrontational, these increasingly “complex” changes serve to enhance its ability to retreat and hide, rather than fight back. Only in maturity can these upgrades between sheds begin to pose a problem if left unchecked.

Triggers

Delta Vices only trigger sheds when threatened, but they have extremely reactive cores and a broad definition of what is deemed a “threat”, especially in the larval stage. They can react to direct, intentional threats, such as AV Shots and committing Branches, or

entirely benign and unintentional behaviors, such as shifts in hormone levels and contracting the flu. As the Vice matures, this sensitivity tends to dull, and the Vice begins exhibiting discernment instead of reacting to every possible trigger. Shedding is, after all, extremely energy-intensive.

Side Effects

Many Hosts claim they are able to “sense” when shedding occurs. The sensation tends to be mildly disorienting, resulting in a feeling many liken to forgetting why one has walked into a room. Others claim the sensation is more akin to knowing a task needs to be completed, but being unable to remember what it is. Mild unease, brain fog, and acute aphasia have also been documented as immediate side effects of shedding.

Perhaps the most disruptive side effect of shedding is memory loss, which has been reported by 82% of Hosts with a Delta Vice. Hosts who have experienced shed-induced memory loss are not guaranteed to experience it each time; likewise, Hosts who have not experienced shed-induced memory loss are not guaranteed to avoid doing so after future sheds.

The severity and scope of memory loss can also vary—both between Hosts and between a Host’s individual instances—and don’t seem to depend on any specific factors. This variability is a common point of concern, as there is no way to know its impact in advance. Memory loss can be as benign as forgetting what one had for breakfast for the past few weeks, but many have experienced memory loss at a scale that disrupts their personal and professional lives, going so far as to forget appointments, commitments, and important decisions made. Even people’s names and established relationships can be lost. Thankfully, memory loss has not been documented outside of a designated time period; that is to say, if the Vice is shedding a core extension that it had for three weeks, memories can only be lost from those specific three weeks. The longer the time between sheds, the more likely memory loss is to occur.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

Larval Delta Vices are extremely timid and nonconfrontational, but highly reactive. Delta Vices in general take threats to their core very seriously, doubly so as larvae, and even the slightest attempt at treating

one’s Vice can result in not only an initiated Branch, but trigger shedding as well. Because of this, Delta larvae have an unnaturally active larval period. Due to this heightened sensitivity, Branches are likely to be initiated exclusively in self-defense, and often. Considerable augmentation or germination progress is unlikely at this stage.

Larval Delta exhibitions are unlikely to be well-developed, knowing it will likely be scrapped after future shedding. Early Branch Domains, too, tend to be relatively simple. Though, as the Vice matures and triggers multiple shedding cycles, the complexity of both is sure to increase. During the larval stage, however, complexity is likely to cap relatively quickly, and increased complexity will only be able to come with time, and thus, maturity.

Larval Delta cores are quite small, typically a bit smaller than Alpha cores. On a VGMS, the core body is likely to be quite dense and appear as solid white, while the core extension is less opaque, appearing as a medium gray.

Rescission Guidance

Because shedding tends to increase the complexity of the Branch Domain and exhibition, Vices that have favored shedding in this stage are likely to have more complex (though not extreme) attributes compared to those who may only shed once or twice. At their core, Delta Vices will always prioritize escape and safety over brute force. Exhibitions are likely to increase in complexity in a way that benefits retreat, and Branch Domains tend to become more detailed, increasing the number of potential hiding places. Solutions Architects can provide Branch-specific guidance as a pseudo Adjunct to help pinpoint behaviors and scan the Branch Domain for hiding places, while a Vice Management Administrator is more than equipped to face the exhibition head-on, once found, no matter its shed count.

Stage 2: Adolescent

While most Vices tend to skew aggressive and impulsive during adolescence, Delta Vices are unique in that they actually begin to exhibit a thoughtfulness not previously observed in their behavior. Where larval Deltas are highly reactive, adolescents are able to quell their reactivity and display discernment in what they allow to trigger both Branches and shedding.

Adolescent Delta cores are a bit larger than those of larvae, with the majority of the growth coming from the core body. Though the core extension mostly remains the same size, the more the Vice sheds, the denser it becomes, skewing closer to white in a VGMS. This suggests that the information for the Branch Domain and exhibition presentation are becoming more complex.

While the complexity is ultimately determined by the shed count, adolescent exhibitions really begin to live up to their hasty classification. This is further supported by their ever-evolving Branch Domain that allows the exhibition to dodge, retreat, and hide from attacks effortlessly, likely leading to increased frustration from extensions.

Rescission Guidance

Delta Vices, at this stage, can prove to be quite frustrating in the Branch Domain. Once found, the exhibition is not difficult to injure, but because Deltas spend the majority of the Branch in hiding, addressing it in a timely manner becomes the challenge. Still, due to their immaturity, Deltas are not pursuing augmentation and germination in large amounts during Branches, and the Host can take longer to address Branches without the risk of becoming berserk. The bird's eye view provided by a Solutions Architect is an essential tool to have in one's arsenal. These agents will be able to assess the domain from an unconventional vantage point without alerting the Vice of their presence. Because the Vice is only trying to hide from the extensions, the unique viewpoint of a Solutions Architect can help pinpoint its location much quicker than those on the ground.

Stage 3: Mature

As with most classifications, mature Delta Vices exhibit discernment in initiating Branches, as well as triggering shedding. At this point in its life cycle, it has likely shed anywhere from three to upwards of twenty times or more. Those that have shed more often have been rewarded with agile exhibitions and complex Branch Domains. This combination can prove extremely difficult to address in a timely manner. The medium threat level has been applied to Deltas explicitly due to the complexity and difficulty of addressing mature Delta Branches.

A mature Delta sheds less often than larvae and adolescents, saving this energy-intensive maneuver only to gain an upper hand when it feels lethally

threatened by its Host. Mature Deltas utilize shedding as more of a trump card, rather than a signature move. Though, because of the longer time between sheds, the chances of memory loss increase significantly.

The core of a mature Delta has also shifted, now resembling a cell in telophase. Both the core body and core extension are roughly the same size, though the core body tends to be denser, as it contains much more information overall. This drastic change in size happens over time, the core extension growing more complex with each shed.

It is only after reaching maturity when Delta Vices begin pursuing both germination and augmentation during active Branches, making time a valuable resource in the Branch Domain. Solutions Architects are necessary to address Branches quickly so as to not allow the Host to become berserk.

Rescission Guidance

Mature Delta Vices are at their most discerning, and their exhibitions and Branch Domains are at their most evolved. The timid, nonconfrontational behaviors of larval and adolescent Deltas have been replaced with intentional, evasive behaviors that trap extensions in the Branch Domain while the core pursues augmentation and germination. Unprepared Hosts are at risk of becoming berserk, or worse. At this point, a Host and their Vice Management Administrator should have a solid understanding of both environmental Branch triggers and shedding triggers. Branches should be avoided to the best of one's ability until the proper resources have been gathered. A Vice Management Administrator is likely to enlist the help of a Solutions Architect (or multiple) to locate expertly-hidden exhibitions among the Branch Domain. A Branch Administrator and Branch Coordinator can provide much-needed firepower in delivering precise, but devastating blows that don't allow the Vice to terminate the Branch. Destructive patches with large attack radii can also help weed out concealed exhibitions.

Branch Policy Properties

Delta Vices are unique in that they are the lone classification of Vices to intentionally discard and rework part of their Branch Policy. An additional oddity is that as they mature, the circumstances that trigger shedding almost becomes a pseudo property of its Branch Policy, though it is still being debated among experts whether or not this property should be

officially added. Regardless, learning those triggers can be a welcomed constant among the other changing properties.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Especially in their larval stage, Deltas are extremely sensitive and reactive when initiating Branches. Even though they learn discernment as they mature, Deltas are still regarded as one of the most reactive classifications. A Delta's wide pool of triggers is a result of its gradual advent, and as it matures, it will begin to favor specific triggers.

Branch Domain Blueprint

One of the two properties discarded during shedding, the Branch Domain blueprint changes drastically and often. While the plans themselves are scrapped, the lessons learned are stored in the core body, meaning that future iterations are likely to implement enhancements, such as more hiding places. Like most Vices, domains pull from the Host's experiences at advent, but after a few instances of shedding, Delta domains can mimic the environment of experiences as recent as one month prior.

Exhibition Presentation

The second of the two properties discarded during shedding, Delta exhibitions tend to vary widely, though they typically retain some similarities between sheds. While explicit characteristics are unlikely to remain after a shed, general concepts and ideas are shared. For example, if a Delta's first exhibition is a small quadruped with scales, all consecutive exhibitions are likely to mirror those properties but execute them in different ways.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

Though their exhibitions may change, their attack strategy stays the same. Delta exhibitions are known for their evasive, nonconfrontational strategy in the Branch Domain. To avoid combat, they live up to their hasty classification and squeeze into hard-to-reach spots or even camouflage with their surroundings. Their strategy is to drag out Branches for as long as possible. Once found, however, Deltas can be easily addressed with precision and low-to-moderate strength.

Core Priorities

Rather than prioritizing germination or augmentation like most classifications, Delta Vices funnel the

majority of their energy into the shedding process. Only in maturity are they able to also focus on augmentation and germination. Though, no matter the life stage, shedding will always take priority, with Deltas sometimes even sacrificing growth and network advancement in order to do so.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address a Delta Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice's behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Vice Management Coordinator

Due to the ever-changing properties of Delta Vices, these agents are often enlisted to help Vice Management Administrators keep track of Branch Policy changes between sheds.

Solutions Architect

These agents are imperative to success when addressing Delta Vices. Their bird's eye view as a pseudo Adjunct provides information about the particularly evasive Deltas and their potential whereabouts within the Branch Domain.

Branch Administrator

These agents are master wielders of their patch and can bring much-needed precision in addressing a Delta Vice in an efficient and timely manner.

Branch Coordinator

Branch Coordinators are often enlisted to help search for the particularly elusive Deltas within the Branch Domain, especially in maturity. Multiple agents are often enlisted to increase the odds to locating the exhibition quickly.

Epsilon Vices

Epsilon Vices are extremely difficult to treat due to their deceptive nature. While Delta Vices shed, Epsilon Vices instead opt to keep parts of their Branch Policy hidden. Information can be gathered for all properties, but it may be incomplete. Epsilon Vices will use this gap in knowledge to their advantage to surprise Hosts and Adjuncts in the Branch Domain by expanding hidden areas of the domain or even revealing previously shrouded exhibition characteristics.

- **Threat Level:** High
- **Intelligence:** High
- **Core Reactivity:** Low
- **Energy Use:** Germination
- **Relative Core Size:** Large
- **Exhibition:** Macro-hasty
- **Advent:** Gradual

Epsilon Vices are incredibly deceptive, intentionally withholding key properties of their Branch Policy to surprise Hosts in the Branch Domain. These Vices display a keen sense of situational awareness, often known for their “stalker-like” behavior, as they assess the Host’s emotions and situation to initiate a Branch at the most opportune time. Many Epsilons have the --gamma subclass and are able to communicate with their Host within the Branch Domain. Though, conversation is often limited to single words and broken sentences. Learn more about these abilities and the threats they can pose in *Subclasses: --gamma*.

All Epsilons are born from a gradual advent. The complex emotions, sensations, and experiences that make up this period are responsible for the relatively complex Branch Policy. Simply put, the pool to pick from is quite large, and what may look like the whole picture could actually be only a fraction of it. Their large cores help to house the information for this complex Branch Policy.

Epsilon exhibitions tend to have hydra-like characteristics or multiple sets of limbs. They prefer to keep these appendages shrouded by long hair or dense feathers and only reveal them as a trump card when they have been cornered or are attempting dispersion. Epsilon Branch Domains are generally quite large to accommodate the larger exhibition, while maintaining details typically only observed in smaller domains. As the Vice matures, this domain can expand even further, revealing previously hidden areas often through doors, hallways, or physics-defying architecture. Epsilon

exhibitions are also masters of camouflage and able to blend in with their Branch Domain despite their large stature.

Generally speaking, however, Epsilons are incredibly nonreactive. Larval Epsilons rarely initiate Branches, if ever, and mature Vices are more prone to lying in wait for the most opportune attack. Most Branch activity happens during early adolescence, when the Branch Policy is the least understood. While these consecutive Branches may feel like they provide enough information, if the Vice is allowed to mature or if rescission is pursued, it will reveal the full extent of its Branch Policy and likely surprise the Host in multiple ways.

An Epsilon’s network is established early in adolescence, when Branch activity is at its highest. Their complex networks result in highly-attuned stolons that monitor external conditions and can even detect specific phrases or tones of voice. With their well-established network, Epsilons are primed (though not guaranteed) to create or attempt to create a rumen at least once in its life cycle. This behavior is typically only observed in mature Vices.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

Larval Epsilon Vices are extremely nonreactive, some going so far as to never initiate a Branch before adolescence. Because of this, Epsilons are extremely difficult to classify early on, and some even avoid detection altogether due to their gradual advent. Many discover their Epsilon Vice after the larval stage, only after other biological factors have been ruled out as cause for their inexplicable fatigue.

As a young Vice, Epsilons spend the majority of their time feeding. While they may not have the biological advantages of Zeta Vices, their abstaining from Branch initiation ensures full energy reserves going into adolescence. Because most Epsilons avoid initiating Branches during this stage, their Branch Policies have an unnaturally long incubation period, resulting in broad, complex policies.

Epsilon cores tend to be quite large, even during the larval stage. Those that have been documented display a density typically only observed in more mature Vices of other classifications.

Rescission Guidance

Because most Epsilon Vices avoid detection in the larval stage, there is not enough data on rescission during this stage to provide general guidelines. However, due to the higher threat level, it is recommended to pursue rescission alongside an established CVRS care team.

Stage 2: Adolescent

Many Hosts become aware of their Epsilon Vice once it reaches adolescence and begins initiating Branches. Because of their gradual advent and generally dormant larval stage, many Hosts misinterpret this initial Branch as the result of a Vice's sudden advent and drastically underestimate the complexity of the Branch.

Upon first glance, adolescent Branch Domains are not terribly complex, but as time moves on, the domain can seem to expand at an alarming rate, especially at the Vice approaches maturity. This expansion typically takes place between Branches, but can be executed during production if lethally threatened. Because of its gradual advent, expansions to the domain may not make sense, with areas from different environments stitched together in physics-defying ways.

Epsilon exhibitions are hasty and do not hit hard, and like Delta Vices, they prey on frustration and disorientation, dragging out Branch times as they expertly evade attacks. Because they are still young, adolescents are less graceful and in-tune with their domain, but with time, the domain expansions along with their increasingly complex exhibition can begin to pose a real challenge.

Adolescent cores are quite dense, appearing as a large, white mass on a VGMS. At this stage, their network has begun establishing itself and is visible on a VGMS as well. Adolescent Epsilon networks are quite complex and well-established compared to most other adolescent classifications. Though the concept of networks have only recently been introduced to adolescent Epsilons, they tend to expand rapidly. After established, this network begins perfecting the feeding process to expertly allocate resources to various biological processes, even as an adolescent. Allowing an adolescent Epsilon Vice to mature can be lethal, as its well-established network and broad Branch Policy can mature into a truly formidable adult Vice.

Rescission Guidance

Because Branch activity halts almost completely in maturity, we highly recommend rescinding Epsilon Vices as adolescents. Adolescent domains are often disorienting and constantly expanding. A Solutions Architect will be able to provide a much needed overview of the domain layout, while a large team of Branch Administrators and Branch Coordinators can aid the Vice Management Administrator in tracking down the exhibition in a timely manner. No matter its age, when an Epsilon is cornered, it will begin to reveal previously hidden properties of its Branch Policy. In an active Branch, this includes expanding the Branch Domain's blueprint, possibly unveiling additional appendages or heads of the exhibition, and even slightly altering its attack strategy. If a Vice feels it is being lethally threatened—especially in the instance of Branch instigation—it will unveil all of these properties, causing a drastic increase in complexity and risk. Building a strong, detail-focused, and quick-thinking team is imperative for success.

Stage 3: Mature

Like many other classifications, Epsilon Vices tend to display heightened discernment in their maturity, and the rate of Branches decreases from adolescence. Mature Epsilons in particular become quite observant, utilizing their complex, well-established network to monitor internal and external conditions and choose the most effective time to initiate Branches.

Most mature Epsilons only initiate Branches under two circumstances: lethal threat and a clear line to a successful dispersion. Additionally, due to their widespread network, many Hosts are at risk of becoming berserk, as augmentation is easily pursued during active Branches. For this reason, we recommend rescinding Branches as quickly as possible.

Mature Epsilon cores tend to be quite dense, appearing as solid white on a VGMS, along with its established network. While most networks are relatively faint in comparison to the core, some high-traffic junctions in mature Epsilon networks can be almost as dense as the core itself. Because of this network, a Host with a mature Epsilon Vice is likely to have chronic drape and extrusion blights. Many seek treatment from a Blight Specialist to tame their symptoms.

While mature Epsilon exhibitions may have a similar attack strategy to Delta Vices in hiding throughout the

domain, Epsilon are especially dangerous because they can also fight back once found. Additionally, their larger stature often requires multiple Adjuncts for backup, and previously hidden limbs or features can cause quite the challenge.

Rescission Guidance

While we recommend that Epsilon Vices be rescinded in the adolescent stage, we understand that one may not have the proper resources at their disposal. Rescinding a mature Epsilon Vice is extremely difficult, and building a care team in advance is imperative to success. Most Branches require multiple Adjuncts to both locate the elusive exhibition and attack it once found. Many Hosts are not bested in combat during a Branch; rather, they run out of time. Keeping a level head and staying alert are key at this life stage. Solutions Architects can provide a much-needed change in perspective, similar to their role with Delta Vices; however, due to their impressive camouflaging capabilities, some may still struggle with detecting them. Once the exhibition is found, Branch Administrators can provide the firepower to overwhelm the exhibition, though they may need backup.

Branch Policy Properties

The Branch Policy of Epsilon Vices tends to be quite complex. This is due in large part to their often long, drawn-out gradual advent. Epsilons are known for their ability to only reveal select properties of their Branch Policy. Many reveal these previously hidden properties when cornered or pursuing dispersion. Epsilons are extremely nonreactive, going so far as to avoid initiating Branches completely until adolescence. Because of this, many of the properties below only start to become known in adolescence. An Epsilon's complex Branch Policy is not infinite, of course, and repeated attacks can force it to reveal all its cards. At a certain point, an Epsilon will have nothing left to reveal, but it is still best to operate with the assumption that at any given time, an Epsilon likely has something up its sleeve.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Because of their longer gradual advent, the pool of experiences to choose from is quite large. Epsilons are able to "hide" many of these triggers, utilizing them during times of stress. Many mistake these Branches as "rogue", which is inaccurate. Epsilons do not select properties outside of their established pool, as rogue

Branches suggest; rather, the pool is simply so large that some of these triggers were simply not utilized until this time. Knowing the general time frame encompassed by the gradual advent can help Hosts prepare for future "reveals" of this property.

Branch Domain Blueprint

Epsilons are known for their complex Branch Domains. They are often disorienting in their architecture, and uncannily detailed when observed up close. As an Epsilon matures, it may deign to reveal previously hidden "stages" of their Branch Domain. These stages are often separate areas, stitched with the original domain using doors or hallways. Transitions between these stages can be confusing and unsettling, often placing Hosts and Adjuncts in unnatural positions once they fully cross over. Epsilons use these hidden stages to prolong Branch time and avoid capture.

Exhibition Presentation

Epsilon exhibitions are quite tall, typically towering over the average person. While they may have an impressive height, they are usually not bulky; though, due to large volumes of fur, feathers, and hair, their stature can still be quite imposing. Epsilons use their voluminous integuments to also conceal certain characteristics of their exhibitions. Many hide additional limbs, heads, or even wings and reveal these features when cornered or pursuing dispersion. For example, a cornered Epsilon exhibition may reveal a set of wings to evade combat, or a Vice that sees a line to dispersion may reveal a second set of limbs to enhance its combat abilities.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

During production, Epsilon exhibitions generally avoid combat. Rather than perfecting evasion tactics like Delta Vices, as they reach maturity, Epsilon exhibitions become masters of camouflage. Their strategy is to essentially hide in plain sight and wait for the Host or Adjuncts to become frustrated, then attack. If an exhibition becomes cornered, they may reveal an additional stage of their Branch Domain to sow confusion, or they may reveal previously hidden features, as explored above.

Core Priorities

The lone property of an Epsilon's Branch Policy that is not complex, Epsilons prioritize germination, simple as that. Epsilons use their camouflaging abilities in the

Branch Domain to draw out Branch times, allowing for germination to occur. Their complex network not only helps them monitor conditions, but it also provides a clear path for augmentation once dispersion is being pursued. While chronic blights can be difficult to maintain, we recommend avoiding AVShots and Suppressants so no changes in behavior are missed.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address an Epsilon Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice's behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Solutions Architect

Because Epsilons are masters of camouflage, Solutions Architects typically focus on mapping the Branch Domain. As a pseudo Adjunct, an agent's bird's eye view can provide much-needed insight into the expanding and convoluted Branch Domain.

Branch Administrator

These agents are master wielders of their patch and can bring much-needed power in addressing an Epsilon Vice in an efficient and timely manner.

Branch Coordinator

Branch Coordinators are often enlisted to help search for the particularly elusive Epsilons within the Branch Domain, especially in maturity. Multiple agents are often enlisted to increase the odds to locating the exhibition quickly.

Blight Specialist

Due to their extensive networks, Epsilon Vices often trigger chronic blights, which can be addressed and relieved by a resident Blight Specialist, if severe; though many forego treatment so as to not suppress the symptoms that communicate Vice activity. Blight Specialists, in this case, are often on standby to monitor blights and provide insight into possible changes in Vice activity.

Zeta Vices

A Zeta core has a unique epithelium that attracts hormones from throughout the body, acting as a lightning rod that allows them to feed consistently through all life stages. Because of this, Hosts with Zeta Vices tend to display extreme, visible signs of fatigue. These Vices have advanced storage capacity and are able to hoard more resources than the average Vice, in addition to having a penchant for establishing rumina. If allowed to mature, Zeta Vices can be extremely difficult to address due to their established, often numerous energy reserves.

- **Threat Level:** High
- **Intelligence:** Moderate
- **Core Reactivity:** Low
- **Energy Use:** Storage
- **Relative Core Size:** Medium
- **Exhibition:** Giga-defensive
- **Advent:** Gradual

A Zeta core's unique biology is key to its elevated feeding efficiency. While most larval cores feed passively, larval Zeta cores are the only classification to actively attract hormones from throughout the body. Additionally, Zeta networks seem to suggest a more efficient "capture" system with specialized tracks; though, this has proven difficult to study in a controlled setting, as networks are difficult to observe up close and Zeta Vices are generally rare. Even after establishing a network in adolescence, Zeta cores continue to attract hormones, allowing them to catch any stray hormones that manage to escape. In short, Zeta Vices have evolved to feed.

Despite the biological differences, Zeta cores do not appear any differently on a VGMS and cannot aid in early classification. Due to the current limitations of imaging, a VGMS is not able to suggest three-dimensional differences outside of denser objects appearing more opaque. Because the epithelium surrounds the entire core, it appears the same as others.

Zetas are, instead, often detected because of their immense strain on the Host's endocrine system. Many Hosts initially seek treatment from an endocrinologist and are subsequently referred to our Primary Care agents. While Zetas do not completely inhibit hormone absorption, they prevent roughly 60% of excreted hormones from reaching their intended destination. Many Hosts present symptoms found in those that have hypothyroidism. It is recommended to

not supplement with medications that will increase the body's output, as this will only work to further fuel the Vice's growth. After rescission, many Hosts return to normal.

Where other Vices may threaten with increased intelligence, the threat behind a Zeta lies in its ability to withstand attacks in the Branch Domain. Using their excessive storage, Zetas can reroute resources to bolster their exhibition or even repair it. While Delta and Epsilon Vices prey on frustration and aversion, Zetas are often approachable at the start of production. Their intimidating stature and immense defensive capabilities, even in the larval stage, cannot be understated. These exhibitions do not have much in the way of offensive features, but they don't need them. Branch times can quickly become lethal if the proper resources are not available.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

Like most Vices, larval Zetas are relatively docile. While they do not avoid Branches altogether like Epsilons do, they don't go out of their way to initiate them, either. Larval Zetas are generally nonreactive and focused primarily on feeding. Zeta larvae are likely to only initiate Branches in direct response to threat; otherwise, they lay low.

Contrary to popular belief, Zeta cores are smaller than Epsilon cores and closer in size to Beta, and even Alpha. Exhibition size has no bearing on core size; rather, the core shrinks and grows as the amount of information it stores decreases and increases respectfully. Due to their simple Branch Policy, Zeta cores are not terribly dense and do not get very big.

Most larval Vices come with fatigue, especially early on, but the fatigue that results from larval Zeta Vices is unmatched. Many Hosts report a full-body, aching fatigue that prevents them from participating in their normal activities. In addition to their honed feeding capabilities, Zeta Vices also tend to have the --sigma subclass, meaning their diet is varied and indiscriminate, some going so far as to consume non-hormonal substances like plasma and synovial fluid. Larval Zeta Vices in particular are the least picky, with their palate narrowing as they age.

Rescission Guidance

Because exhibitions will only become more difficult as they age, it is highly recommended to rescind a

Zeta Vice during the larval stage, if possible. Their exhibitions are still defensive, but have not had the opportunity to enhance their makeup between multiple Branches. Because they do not yet have a network, larval Zeta exhibitions cannot heal themselves, making this life stage the perfect time to attempt rescission. Larval Zeta exhibitions can, in theory, be rescinded alone, but multiple Adjuncts are recommended so as to not let the Branch drag on longer than necessary.

Stage 2: Adolescent

Adolescence is an interesting stage of heightened activity for Zeta Vices. The otherwise notoriously sluggish Vices increase Branch activity, using these Branches to establish their network and make explosive germination progress, a process it has otherwise neglected between Branches.

Zeta networks, even in adolescence, can become extremely complex after only a few Branches. Because of the sheer amount of progress made during production, any damage received as a result of a commit is likely not enough to fully undo the network's progress. Because of this progress, and due to an established network, many Hosts begin to report excessive, chronic drape blights.

In adolescence, Zeta exhibitions tend to evolve the most intensely; though, they don't necessarily change features between Branches. Rather, adolescent Zeta exhibitions enhance their defensive characteristics. For example, an exhibition with a thick hide may work to thicken it, or harden the scales that cover its body. Adolescent Zeta exhibitions can quickly become unmanageable if the appropriate patch is not available.

Rescission Guidance

While adolescent Zeta Vices are no more cunning than their larval counterparts, if one is not addressed in early adolescence, their exhibition can quickly evolve out of control where multiple Adjuncts are required for success. Because they have begun reinforcing their defensive characteristics, long-range piercing patches can help tear through the otherwise tough exterior. Vice Management Administrators are likely to enlist the help of a Branch Administrator to provide much-needed firepower. In the event of an inefficient patch, they may also refer a Host to an AV Specialist for patch calibration.

Stage 3: Mature

In maturity, Zeta Vices are the masters of defense and energy storage. Despite their simplicity, Branches at this stage can be deadly. The combination of a bulky exhibition, efficient feeding system, and potential "healing" powered by an external rumen can make Branches last for multiple, agonizing hours.

Mature Zetas pull back from their more aggressive adolescent tendencies and initiate Branches at a much slower rate. Between Branches, they mostly focus on energy storage, with many deigning to establish a rumen if conditions are appropriate. While most Hosts experience elevated levels of fatigue when infected with a Zeta Vice, it multiplies considerably once a rumen is established. The never-ending flow of resources between the core and its rumen places an immense strain on the Host's body, resulting in chronic joint pain, brain fog, and compromised immune responses. Learn more about rumina in *Vice Biology: Feeding & Energy Management*.

Mature Zeta exhibitions are intimidatingly large, with many standing as tall as 10 feet, with intense bulk to boot. Depending on its maturity, upwards of ten Adjuncts may be required to deal with its exhibition in a timely manner.

Rescission Guidance

Rescinding a mature Zeta Vice is extremely difficult. It is impossible to do alone, no matter the strength of one's patch. The sheer density of the exhibition's defenses will wear down a patch before it's able to make any meaningful progress. For this reason, we recommend pursuing rescission guided by a Vice Management Administrator. Many suggest a hybrid approach, combining Branch maintenance with regular AV shots to attack the network and inhibit rumen establishment. They may also refer the patient to meet with an AV Specialist for AV enhancement therapy to bolster a patient's AV output and naturally undo germination progress made during a Branch. If possible, we recommend manually detaching a rumen before pursuing rescission to cut the Vice off from its primary energy reserve and inhibit exhibition healing. A Public Deployment Branch Administrator can provide this service if the location of the rumen is known and the Host is present.

Branch Policy Properties

Despite their gradual advent, Zeta Branch Policies are quite simple and easy to prepare for. Their policies have been described as “utilitarian” in that there are often no bells and whistles, complicated mind games, or complex designs. Their biggest threat lies in their seemingly indestructible exhibition and never-ending supply of energy. The properties explored below are generalizations and are not guaranteed to apply to every Zeta Vice.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Most Vices with a gradual advent have a large, complex pool of experiences and triggers to pull from. Zeta Vices do not initiate Branches often, resembling the discernment observed in Epsilon Vices. Because of this, Zetas tend to have a relatively simple and straightforward pool of environment triggers and don’t seem to favor any properties in general. They do seem to choose highly-specific scenarios, however, such as specific phrases, sounds, and even emotions.

Branch Domain Blueprint

Zeta Branch Domains are unnervingly simple and straightforward, many reporting designs that mimic mundane, featureless environments like empty warehouses and backrooms. They are less concerned with the psychological mind games that many other classifications delight in playing, and instead pour the majority of their resources into exhibition presentation. A Zeta Branch Domain is relatively static throughout its life cycle, and does little in the way of evolving. Zetas tend to be quite utilitarian, and because Branch Domains are fundamentally the housing of a Branch, they don’t put much thought into the design outside of that.

Exhibition Presentation

Zeta exhibitions tend to have vague, blob-like exhibitions with no distinctive features like horns or claws. Fundamentally, exhibitions exist as a defensive layer around the core. While most have the secondary effect of inciting fear in the Host and their Adjuncts and can actively fight off core attacks, Zeta exhibitions are most concerned with the primary task at hand: protecting the core. Because of this, Zeta exhibitions often do not have limbs or other modes of ambulation, and tend to resemble slugs, snakes, and eels. Zeta exhibitions are often covered in protective scales or a thick hide, which manifest as drape blights that change

the texture of the Host’s skin. Unlike other classifications, Zetas are able to “heal” their exhibitions by rerouting VG stored in established rumina. Zeta exhibitions are not indestructible, but after multiple iterations, previous weak spots are likely to be addressed and reinforced between Branches, which can quickly lead to a seemingly impenetrable exhibition. This can be avoided by rescinding in the larval stage or early adolescence.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

Simply put, Zeta exhibitions do not attack. As a defensive exhibition, they instead focus on mitigating and reducing damage. Zeta Branches are somewhat unconventional; they are low-energy and simple, almost intimidatingly so. Most Zeta Branches are predictable; its large, defensive exhibition sits patiently in the middle of its domain and braces for attack. Like Epsilon Vices, Zeta Vices aim to prolong Branch times, allowing sufficient time for augmentation. If its exhibition is severely damaged, it will likely reroute resources from its rumen if one has been established. This is particularly the case with mature Zetas.

Core Priorities

Throughout its life cycle, a Zeta Vice is primarily concerned with feeding and utilizing its energy to establish additional energy reserves, either by maximizing its network potential or by establishing a rumen. Outside of Branches, Zetas are focused on feeding and resource management, unlike most Vices that attempt to make germination and augmentation progress at an extremely slow pace; for this reason, Zeta Branches tend to be drawn out to provide the Vice with additional time to augment and germinate.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address a Zeta Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice’s behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Branch Administrator

These agents are master wielders of their patch and can bring much-needed firepower to addressing a Zeta Vice in an efficient and timely manner.

Branch Coordinator

Due to their bulk, Zeta exhibitions often require multiple Adjuncts to chip away at their outer defenses, with Branch Coordinators providing support for Branch Administrators.

AV Specialist

An accurate and efficient patch is key to addressing a Zeta Vice. In the event of a weak or unhelpful patch, an AV Specialist can provide patch calibration, wherein they work with the patient to influence the design and function of their patch. AV Specialists can also provide AV enhancement therapy to boost a patient's AV output and tame any germination progress made during a Branch.

Blight Specialist

Due to their extensive networks, Zeta Vices often trigger chronic blights, which can be addressed and relieved by a resident Blight Specialist, if severe. Blight Specialists are often on standby to monitor blights and provide insight into possible changes in Vice activity.

Theta Vices

Theta Vices thrive on chaos and are notorious for their trademark explosive Branch after a period of sustained feeding. Theta Vices have a wider-than-average staging radius and aim to admit as many tertiary Adjuncts as possible to this attempted dispersion. Though intimidating, these Vices can be easily addressed if caught early.

- **Threat Level:** Medium
- **Intelligence:** Low
- **Core Reactivity:** Low
- **Energy Use:** Germination
- **Relative Core Size:** Small
- **Exhibition:** Meso-offensive
- **Advent:** Sudden

In their early stages, Theta Vices are relatively nonthreatening. In fact, many of them are initially misclassified as Alphas due to their sudden advent and straightforward Branch Policy. Their threat mainly lies in their potential explosive Branches—called Super Branches—with the only indication being a sustained dormancy period of excessive feeding beforehand. If their attempt at dispersion is suspended or committed, they are likely to try again after their resources have been replenished.

In between dispersion attempts, Theta Branches are generally simple, though their exhibitions can prove to be more difficult than the average Alpha exhibition. While they are primarily offensive, they tend to attack in short bursts, coming in close to deal damage, then quickly backing away before one can react. Ranged and thrown patches work well against Theta exhibitions.

Theta Vices use Branches primarily as a way to gauge a Host's abilities. Their staging radius remains relatively average during this time. While most Branches can be easily addressed, their Super Branches are often initiated during times of stress or illness. They also extend their staging radius to increase the number of potential tertiary Adjuncts. Because these Super Branches rely on queuing multiple tertiary Adjuncts, Thetas tend to have lean, but extensive networks. Before these Branches, multiple stolons are released to queue potential Adjuncts.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

Larval Theta Vices are often mistaken for Alphas, leading to incorrect classifications and a false sense of security. While Thetas are not particularly active during the larval stage, it is imperative to begin learning its Branch Policy as soon as possible so as to avoid surprises in the adolescent stage. A Theta will not initiate a Super Branch during the larval stage. It simply does not possess the energy to do so.

The Branches that larval Thetas initiate tend to be relatively easy to predict, as the narrow pool of properties present at advent provide a short list of potential triggers. The Branch triggered at advent will be the blueprint of most Branches initiated during this stage, down to its Branch Domain and the exhibitions presentation and attack strategy.

Theta exhibitions tend to be quite frail but can hit hard, often referred to as the “glass cannons” of the Vice world; though, in the larval stage, their offensive power has yet to be established. Most larval Theta exhibitions can be addressed quite easily. Theta Branch Domains are similar to those of Alphas and are generally simple, especially in this stage.

Rescission Guidance

Unlike Alpha Vices, Theta exhibitions are quite frail, no matter their life stage. Even in the larval stage, their exhibition can be quite easy to address, if one can manage to catch it. Though they are young and inexperienced, larval Theta exhibitions can still move quickly and avoid attacks with impressive reflexes. Ranged patches can allow extensions to continue attacking, even after the exhibition has backed away. They are easily caught and overwhelmed by a seasoned CVRS agent, such as a Vice Management Administrator. Vice Management Coordinators are often trained on larval Theta exhibitions, as they require quick thinking and precision, but ultimately pose no threat if the Branch is simply committed.

Stage 2: Adolescent

The true threat of Theta Vices begins to reveal itself in adolescence. Branches become more common, almost exponentially, as the Vice aims to establish its network. Adolescent Thetas make exceptional germination progress during Branches, and their networks often appear quite faint on a VGMS compared to other classifications'. Their network is

much less complicated than a Zeta's, for example, but it becomes established throughout the body much quicker. It appears faint on VGMS because it is less dense, but the groundwork for future expansion has been laid.

Adolescent Thetas are regarded as one of the most impulsive, least discerning classifications. They initiate Branches often with seemingly no foresight. If a situation passes QAC, an adolescent Theta is likely to initiate a Branch. This predictability tends to lure Hosts into a false sense of security, and after a series of consecutive, mundane Branches, it will enter a period of dormancy, where it feeds and stores energy to inevitably initiate a Super Branch.

The period of dormancy leading to a Super Branch can be almost palpable, many Hosts complaining of inexplicable fatigue and brain fog. Thetas use their extensive network to ensnare passing hormones all throughout the body, and during this excessive feeding, this can lead to hormonal fluctuations. If you notice these symptoms, contact your Vice Management Administrator immediately, as a Super Branch is imminent.

Super Branches are not any more complex than standard Branches; though, they do tend to be classified as "rogue" so as to intentionally catch the Host off guard. Their "super" modifier primarily alludes to the expanded staging radius. Where the average Vice's staging radius is roughly 12 feet, a Theta's is a whopping 36 feet, greatly increasing the scope of potential tertiary Adjuncts. What's more, Thetas use their multiple stolons to detect when the Host has entered a high-traffic area, such as a concert or bus.

While the staging radius may be wider, the actual time spent in staging is quite short compared to other classifications. This is primarily to reduce the amount of time potential tertiary Adjuncts have to break free, but this also reduces the time available for secondary or primary Adjuncts to join. Once the Branch enters production, it becomes more difficult to snap out of the trance induced by being queued, though it is often quite manageable.

Knowing tertiary Adjuncts are likely to self-dismiss, Thetas are indiscriminate in their queuing process, adding everyone in the staging radius. This, of course, proves to be quite a risky endeavor. Most tertiary Adjuncts self-dismiss, but there is always the possibility of admitting someone who has an

intimidating patch or heightened combat skills. If this proves to be the case, the Adjunct will be dismissed, which requires considerable effort and can backfire, distracting the Vice during combat.

Due to its shorter staging time, Super Branch Domains remain quite simple, though a Theta's exhibition is typically wild and disorienting upon entry. Thetas use the addition of tertiary Adjuncts to distract its Host and increase its reach if dispersion is achieved. But the threats of a Super Branch stop there. Otherwise, in the Branch Domain, a Super Branch can be addressed as one would a standard Branch.

Rescission Guidance

Rescinding an adolescent Theta Branch is just as straightforward as doing so in the larval stage. Super Branches prove slightly more intimidating with their deviation from the Branch Policy, short staging, and the addition of tertiary Adjuncts. Most standard Branches can be addressed with the proper patch, and Super Branches can be prepared for if one is aware of their condition. At the first sign of dormancy, often manifesting as inexplicable fatigue, contact your Vice Management Administrator to begin preparing for the Super Branch.

Stage 3: Mature

Mature Theta Vices are not all that different from adolescents. Maturity is mostly observed through their slight increase in discernment—though it isn't much—and any slight enhancements to the exhibition or Branch Domain, but these properties of the Branch Policy are typically not prioritized.

While Thetas somewhat wrangle their impulses in maturity, they are still regarded as one of the most impulsive and active classifications. If anything, mature Vices are often easier to handle than their adolescent counterparts, considering there is a lot less Branch activity, allowing time for the Host to better prepare between Branches.

Rescission Guidance

There are not many differences between rescinding adolescent and mature Theta Vices. As with any Vice, caution is always recommended, and building a proper care team can ensure a successful rescission. A Vice Management Administrator is likely equipped to perform rescission alone, though some may enlist a Branch Coordinator for backup.

Branch Policy Properties

Like Alpha Vices, Theta Branch Policies are relatively straightforward; though, because of their Super Branches, Thetas are known for occasionally initiating rogue Branches. Paying close attention to Vice behavior between Branches can help a Host prepare in advance for any potential Super Branches. The properties explored below are generalizations and are not guaranteed to apply to every Theta Vice.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Due to their sudden advent, this pool of triggers tends to be quite small. Especially in adolescence, Thetas are indiscriminate in their preferences, and pull from any and all properties present in advent. Super Branches, however, are typically rogue, deviating from the established property.

Branch Domain Blueprint

Theta Branch Domains tend to be simple and small, with a few established areas where the exhibition can briefly retreat and avoid combat, such as behind shelves, doors, or desks. Theta Branch Domains often closely mimic the environment present at advent.

Exhibition Presentation

Theta exhibitions are the glass cannons of the exhibition world, typically with sharp features and thin, limber bodies. Exhibitions tend to be aerodynamic and smooth, with few protrusions like horns, tails, and wings. Because of this, Hosts often report drape blights in common junction areas like the shoulders, neck, and elbows.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

In the Branch Domain, exhibitions prefer close combat, coming in near the host to deal damage, then fleeing to safety before the Host can retaliate. It doesn't stay hidden for long, and will often come out of hiding on its own to initiate another attack. This cycle is repeated ad nauseum, with the Vice hoping to wear the Host down.

Core Priorities

Thetas prioritize their Super Branches, which hinge on queuing as many tertiary Adjuncts as possible during their short staging period. In order to accomplish this, a Theta Vice needs a large, limber network, which it achieves by performing explosive germination during regular, repeated Branches.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address a Theta Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice's behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Branch Coordinator

While not necessary for rescission, these agents are often enlisted to support a Vice Management Administrator in the Branch Domain.

Lambda Vices

Lambda Vices are a relatively rare classification of Vice that deviates from all expected behavioral norms. Lambda Vices always have a sudden advent, but the Branch initiated at advent is leaps and bounds more complex than any other classification's. Hosts with a Lambda Vice should be addressed by a Branch Administrator. If the Branch is addressed, future Branches will drastically decrease in severity.

- **Threat Level:** High
- **Intelligence:** Low
- **Core Reactivity:** Moderate
- **Energy Use:** Advent Branch
- **Relative Core Size:** Medium
- **Exhibition:** Macro-offensive
- **Advent:** Sudden

Most Branches that result from a sudden advent are weak and can be addressed alone, even without a patch; Branch Domains tend to be simple, and exhibitions are inexperienced and brittle. An initial Lambda Branch, however, has an uncharacteristically complex Branch Domain and a large, powerful exhibition that can easily overwhelm the new Host. These Branches essentially cannot be addressed without the proper resources and support from a team of CVRS agents.

That being said, not all hope is lost. Learning to recognize the warning signs of an impending Lambda advent can be the difference between life and death, for both you and for others. Target Hunters are often scanning public spaces for these exact behaviors and symptoms.

Hosts typically display a distinctive set of behaviors in the time leading up to the Branch. Hosts claim they become unreasonably aggressive and agitated, yelling loudly and getting into arguments or even committing acts of physical violence. They are also often seen pacing and engaging in anxious subconscious behaviors such as skin picking or chewing their nails. Physiological symptoms can be mild—such as goosebumps and blown pupils—or extreme, threatening the Host's wellbeing with elevated heart rates and anaphylaxis. Hosts claim to feel disconnected from their bodies and unable to control their behaviors.

These behaviors and symptoms often prove difficult to explicitly classify as Vice-related, as many can be experienced outside of a Vice-induced situation.

Fortunately, a single, distinct symptom occurs in all Lambda Hosts that can signal a Lambda advent is imminent. Roughly half an hour before advent, Hosts can be seen emitting expulsion blights, such as smoke or electricity. Experts are still struggling to fully understand this phenomenon and how it occurs. Because blights are products of a Vice's core or network, a Host having this symptom is simply unheard of. The current theory is that advent occurs, and the resulting Branch is a delayed reaction. Because expulsion blights emanate from the core, an established network is not needed.

If the initial Lambda Branch is committed, all subsequent Branches will become significantly easier, devolving drastically between initiations. Due to the sheer amount of energy needed to initiate the advent Branch, Lambdas do not have the opportunity to establish proper energy processing or storage systems, resulting in faulty biology that "leaks" its resources. Over time, Branches become quite simple, mimicking those of larval Alpha Vices. Most Lambda Vices do not make it to maturity.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

The most tumultuous stage of Lambda Vices, larvae are unnaturally aggressive, going against all biological norms. Experts are still unsure in what conditions result in a Lambda Vice. Their intimidating advent Branch alone is what elevates these Vices to a high threat level.

Even though larval Lambdas begin to devolve after their initial advent Branch, larval Branches should not be underestimated. Branch activity tends to be quite high in the larval stage, almost as if they know they are on borrowed time. Periods between Branches are generally quite short, and the first few consecutive Branches after advent can still pack quite the punch.

Like the advent Branch, consecutive Branches are often given away by excessive expulsion blight activity in the moments leading up to initiation. Call your Vice Management Administrator or Public Deployment team at the first sign of elevated blight activity. Expulsion blights should be otherwise calm or nonexistent between Branches.

Rescission Guidance

The same strategy used in addressing a Lambda's advent Branch can be applied to its consecutive

Branches. While exhibitions may not be as intimidating and Branch Domains are less detailed, the same level of caution should still be applied, and any rescission attempts should be made with a Vice Management Administrator and the team they deem necessary for success. Patches are also likely to manifest shortly after advent, before the next Branch.

Stage 2: Adolescent

Most adolescent Vices are impulsive and aggressive, but Lambdas tend to lose steam by adolescence, resulting in weak, brittle exhibitions and simple Branch Domains. While not as uncommon as mature Lambdas, they are relatively rare, as most Hosts with a Lambda Vice have sought treatment via CVRS, and most Vice Management Administrators are able to rescind Lambdas before they reach adolescence.

Rescission Guidance

Though an adolescent Lambda is likely to have devolved enough to no longer be a threat, they should still be approached with caution. The strategies used to address larval Lambda Vices can easily be used for their adolescent Branches, though the same degree of strength is often not required. We still recommend pursuing rescission with a Vice Management Administrator, just in case.

Stage 3: Mature

Not much is known about mature Lambda Vices, as they rarely reach this life stage. Because of their devolution over time, mature Lambdas essentially have the same threat level as a Phi Vice, making them easy to rescind.

Rescission Guidance

The strategies used to address larval Lambda Vices can easily be used in their maturity, though the same degree of strength is often not required.

Branch Policy Properties

The Branch Policy of Lambdas, despite their explosive advent, tend to be quiet simple. In fact, as they mature, they actually tend to simplify, with certain properties essentially devolving between Branches. The properties explored below are generalizations and are not guaranteed to apply to every Lambda Vice.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Lambda Branch triggers pull from those at advent, almost exactly. As other properties may seem to

devolve, this property stays relatively static. The conditions of advent that are references are typically quite distinct, leaning into more objective categories such as smells, sounds, and tastes.

Branch Domain Blueprint

The initial explosive Branch contains a Branch Domain that is not necessarily complex, though it is extremely detailed. Early Lambda Branch Domains are almost exact replicas of the recent conditions found at advent. This can create an extremely disorienting effect during one's advent Branch where the Host may struggle to distinguish between realms. Though, as the Vice matures, details tend to fade, and the domain simplifies drastically.

Exhibition Presentation

Early Lambda exhibitions are large, formidable foes. Lambda exhibitions prioritize attack and typically have features that support those endeavors, such as large fists, sharp claws, or thick tails. Lambda exhibitions are often bipedal humanoids. Their simple designs allow for explicit focus on attack strategy.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

Especially in its initial Branch, Lambda exhibitions are honed to attack as hard and as often as possible. Their bipedal nature allows them to efficiently throw devastating punches, often their primary mode of attack. They are generally slow and lack defenses, but due to the Host's inexperience, they are often not equipped to fight back, let alone defend from its onslaught of attacks. As the Vice matures, however, it seems to run out of steam.

Core Priorities

The entirety of a Lambda's existence is poured into its advent, starting off strong to hit as hard as possible. If a Host has the proper resources to address this initial Branch, the Vice typically does not have the biology established to maintain its hard-hitting Branch Policy, resulting in its devolution over time. Though, if a Host is unable to gather the proper resources prior to advent, dispersion is likely, resulting in this classification's high threat level.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address a Lambda Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

After the advent Branch has been addressed, these agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice's behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Target Hunter

As a Public Deployment agent, Target Hunters are always on the lookout for explicit Lambda advent behaviors in public. If targeted, an agent will either call its Branch Administrator to commit the Branch or suspend the Branch and refer the Host to Urgent Care for Branch remediation.

Branch Administrator

These agents are master wielders of their patch and can bring much-needed firepower—especially during one's initial advent Branch—to addressing a Lambda Vice in an efficient and timely manner.

Branch Coordinator

Often on patrol with Branch Administrators, these agents are typically enlisted to support a Branch Administrator in the Branch Domain, especially for an initial advent Branch.

Xi Vices

Xi Vices are often misclassified as Alpha Vices due to their relatively predictable early life. As these Vices mature, Branches become more complex, including exhibitions. While some tweaking to the Branch Policy between Branches is to be expected, the rate at which these properties evolve in Xi Vices can quickly become threatening.

- **Threat Level:** Medium
- **Intelligence:** High
- **Core Reactivity:** High
- **Energy Use:** Branch Policy
- **Relative Core Size:** Small
- **Exhibition:** Meso-balanced
- **Advent:** Sudden

Aside from Omega Vices, Xi Vices are the most commonly misclassified, even in later stages. Because of their relatively mundane early life stages, many are incorrectly classified as Alpha Vices, but when their Branch Policy inevitably evolves, they are sometimes reclassified incorrectly as an Epsilon Vice. What sets them apart from Epsilons is that there is no deception involved. Instead, what happens between Branches is the evolution of the Branch Policy. The general properties stay roughly the same, but they increase in severity. For this reason, they are often regarded as the opposite of Lambda Vices. Learn more about these changes in *Branch Policy Properties* below.

In their early life stages, Xi Vices are quite manageable. Because of their sudden advent, their Branch Policy is straightforward. Their Branch Domains are simple, and their exhibitions can easily be countered. But if they are allowed to mature, these properties can evolve out of control to the point where exhibitions are expertly crafted combat machines that use every square inch of their Branch Domains to their advantage.

The majority of a Xi's energy between Branches is directed toward enhancing their Branch Policy, but during Branches, they use their heightened intelligence to assess the optimum place to direct their resources. Most Vices use Branches as an opportunity to gain augmentation and germination progress, but in early stages, Xi will instead use Branches to document Host and Adjunct behavior, essentially "taking notes" on how to improve their strategy for future Branches. Once they recognize the Host is having trouble in the Branch Domain, they will then begin to make germination progress, and later augmentation

progress. Like Theta Vices, adolescent Xi networks are relatively sparse, but they become established throughout the body much quicker.

While it may not seem like it, even in its early stages, a Xi Vice is documenting, observing, and assessing every piece of data it can gather. As the Host, it is imperative to repay it with the same level of meticulous attention. Pay special attention to a Xi's Branch Policy, even in the larval and adolescent stage. At the first sign of heightened optimization, contact a Vice Management Administrator.

Life Cycle

Stage 1: Larval

Larval Xi Vices are almost indistinguishable from Alpha Vices. Their sudden advent and predictable Branches often lead to an incorrect initial classification. Hosts are likely not at risk during this stage, but as the Vice matures, enhancements will begin to be made to the Branch Policy.

Like Alpha larvae, Xi larvae aren't terribly responsive and are likely to only initiate a few Branches during this life stage. Within the Branch Domain, they also share a similar core reactivity. Both Alpha and Xi larvae tend to retreat at the first sign of damage.

Perhaps the only distinguishing characteristic between larval Xi and Alpha Vices is their exhibition and its behavior in the Branch Domain. They are often roughly the same size, though Alpha Vices tend to have more established offensive characteristics, such as horns and claws; whereas, Xi features are often dulled. Alpha exhibitions are more impulsive in the Branch Domain and prone to attack, while Xi exhibitions seem more wary, as if they are gauging the Host's abilities before it attacks.

Paying attention to these behaviors in the select Branches initiated during the larval stage can lead to a proper classification and prompt rescission after gathering the appropriate team.

Rescission Guidance

At this stage, rescinding a Xi Vice is relatively straightforward, perhaps even more straightforward than larval Alpha rescission. Because their exhibition is less defensive and more balanced, inflicting lethal damage is generally achievable. However, their core reactivity is quite high, and any inaccurate blows can cause the Branch to be terminated before the core is

destroyed. For this reason, we recommend establishing care with a Vice Management Administrator.

Stage 2: Adolescent

Adolescence is when many Hosts begin to experience the enhancement of the Vice's Branch Policy. Like most adolescent Vices, Branch activity begins to pick up in this stage. And like Alpha Vices, they show no discernment in initiating Branches; however, as explored below, certain aspects of the Branch Policy begin to evolve during this stage. Exhibitions become more honed for combat and begin better using their Branch Domain, which has slowly become more detailed and aids in both hiding the exhibition and causing the Host to become distracted or overwhelmed.

As mentioned previously, deception is not part of a Xi's strategy. They are simply using the data they have gathered to better enhance their chances in the Branch Domain. Short Branch times result in a tweaked Branch Policy, while longer Branch times begin to prompt germination.

Xi adolescents aren't known for any one behavior or ability. More than anything, they adapt to counter the Host, leading to some minor discrepancies in the timing of biological developments. Depending on a Host's ability, one adolescent may have a sparse, but established network, while another can have barely one at all. Xi adolescents use this phase of elevated Branch activity to learn everything they can about their Host. If allowed to mature, they can become expertly-crafted combat machines evolved specially to counter their Host, making for longer Branch times and difficult rescission. For this reason, we recommend rescinding a Xi Vice at this stage, if possible.

Rescission Guidance

Adolescent Xi rescission tends to vary in difficulty between individual Hosts. Vices with more established networks and larger cores are larger threats than those still attempting to find their footing. Regardless, it is imperative to rescind a Xi Vice at this stage and to prevent it from reaching maturity. Many Hosts manifest their patch during this stage, which can prove extremely helpful in catching the meticulous Vice off guard. Adding Adjuncts can also swing Branches in the Host's favor.

Stage 3: Mature

Some mature Xi Vices can match the threat levels of Epsilon and Zeta Vices. Regardless of where they are at in adolescence, it does not take a Xi long to learn their Host's behaviors. These Vices have perfected their observational abilities, and after one or two Branches in maturity, these Vices can begin to greatly prolong Branch times, leading to more augmentation and germination progress.

Mature Xis tend to have denser networks, making chronic blights more likely. Blight Specialists can closely observe this blight activity and preemptively warn Hosts of any exhibition enhancements between Branches.

Mature Xi domains are roughly the same size as those in adolescence, but they are substantially more detailed to an almost disorienting degree. Many Hosts claim they find it difficult to concentrate or focus during Branches, as the detailed environment can be overstimulating.

Mature Xis are not indestructible, however, as leaning heavily on their data sets allows them to be easily caught off guard by surprises, such as adding new secondary Adjuncts or instigating a Branch. Doing so will likely result in an enraged exhibition upon entry to the Branch Domain and should be accounted for in advance.

Rescission Guidance

Similar to adolescent Xis, mature Xis tend to vary in difficulty, though they should all be treated with the same degree of respect. After they feel comfortable doing so, most Vice Management Administrators will instigate a Branch with the intent of rescission and enlist multiple new Adjuncts. Often, the combination of instigation and new Adjuncts are enough to throw the Vice off its balance, which can often be easily overwhelmed with a few Branch Coordinators or Branch Administrator.

Branch Policy Properties

Thanks to their sudden advent, Xi Branch Policies tend to be quite straightforward, often leading to misclassification as an Alpha Vice. If allowed to mature, these properties do not change, but they will increase in efficiency, gradually raising the risk with each new Branch. The properties explored below are generalizations and are not guaranteed to apply to every Xi Vice.

Environmental Branch Triggers(s)

Xi Branch triggers pull from its sudden advent, but tend to be generally vague. What starts out as a seemingly straightforward trigger can morph over time into something more broad, only tangentially related to the original trigger. Xis tend to favor less concrete triggers, such as emotions, or triggers with many potential deviations, such as songs. For example, if a specific song was playing at advent, its subsequent trigger could encompass songs by that same artist or songs that use instruments in a similar way.

Branch Domain Blueprint

Xi Branch Domains start out generally large, but quite simple, often pulling from the environment present during advent. At a glance, the Branch Domain seems to mimic advent, but when observed up close, details become fuzzy. As the Vice matures, these details begin to fill in, eventually resulting in a perfect replica of the advent environment. Xi Vices intend to use this to their advantage, hoping the increase in details prompt emotional distress or inaction.

Exhibition Presentation

Young Xi exhibitions are generally nonthreatening, lacking prominent features like claws, fangs, or horns. Any horns present tend to be dulled, and claws or fangs are often short. As they mature, however, these features can become much more imposing between Branches as they grow larger and sharper. Their initially lean bodies often gain excessive bulk or harden existing scales.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

Xis are among one of the only classifications to have balanced exhibitions, meaning no one attack strategy is favored. Xi are observant and adaptable, able to modify their strategies to best suit the situation at hand. In one Branch they may focus on attack, while they avoid combat in the next. Because of their strict data collection, Xi Vices do not like surprises. The introduction of a patch or the addition of a new Adjunct are easy ways to throw a Xi off balance, no matter its life stage.

Core Priorities

Xis are dedicated to perfecting every facet of their Branch Policy to devise the greatest advantage against their Host in the Branch Domain. These Vices are observant and calculating, devoting much of their

processing power to maintaining an internal database of the Host's behaviors.

Proposed Care Team

While all Vices are different, the proposed care team below can give a general idea of the skills and equipment needed to properly address a Xi Vice.

Vice Management Administrator

These agents will construct a holistic, comprehensive understanding of the Vice and facilitate care accordingly. Vice Management Administrators are experts on your specific Vice's behavior, meaning they can enlist the help of other agents where extra support may be needed.

Vice Management Coordinator

These agents are often enlisted to help Vice Management Administrators keep track of the subtle Branch Policy enhancements made between Branches. In fact, many Vice Management Coordinators are the first to recognize the characteristic Xi behaviors.

Solutions Architect

These agents are trained in detecting an exhibition's weak spot, as well as their blind spots in combat. As a Xi matures, they are often welcomed additions to the team.

Branch Administrator

These agents are master wielders of their patch and can bring much-needed firepower to addressing a mature Xi Vice in an efficient and timely manner.

Branch Coordinator

These agents are often enlisted during rescission attempts to support a Vice Management Administrator in the Branch Domain as well as catch the Vice by surprise with new Adjuncts.

Blight Specialist

Meeting regularly with a Blight Specialist can help track changes to the exhibition by closely observing blight activity.

Phi Vices

Phi Vices are a somewhat uncommon and bizarre classification that is so chaotic and dysfunctional in its makeup that it barely has enough energy to maintain its form—let alone the Branch initiated at its sudden advent. While these brittle Vices can easily be addressed, Hosts should remain vigilant, as the advent of a Phi Vice indicates a susceptibility to infection that can result in contracting another Vice.

- **Threat Level:** Low
- **Intelligence:** Low
- **Core Reactivity:** High
- **Energy Use:** N/A
- **Relative Core Size:** Small
- **Exhibition:** Micro-hasty
- **Advent:** Sudden

Perhaps the most perplexing classification, Phi Vices do not survive past their advent Branch. Their sudden advents can be jarring, but are nowhere near threatening. The Branch Domain blueprint tends to be disjointed and incomprehensible, many remarking that it has uncanny similarities to neural net images. Phi exhibitions are incredibly nonthreatening, often taking the form of prey animals such as deer, goats, or rabbits. There is often something offputting about their exhibitions as well, which seem normal at first, but have uncanny features, such as eyes that seem to belong to a different animal.

Upon entry to the Branch Domain, the Host will be placed in front of the exhibition. It may twitch, scamper around, or fall over, but it will never attack or even acknowledge the Host's presence. Many claim the exhibition's movements mimic those of a sick animal, like a deer with prion disease. While one may be able to use objects from around the Branch Domain to rescind the Vice, if enough time passes, the Vice core will peter out, rescinding itself. The Branch will be terminated, and the Host will be cleared.

Hosts with Phi Vices should stay vigilant, as the chances of reigniting with a different classification are fairly high. The presence of a Phi Vice confirms that the Host has the necessary conditions to become infected. Roughly 60% of Hosts with Phi Vices have another advent that results in a new classification of Vice within the next three years. Fifteen percent reignite with another Phi Vice, raising their 60% chance of reignition to 75%.

While rescission will be achieved during the advent Branch, we still recommend seeing a Vice Management Administrator for followups to monitor for possible reignition.

Omega Vices

This extremely rare classification is often applied post-dispersion, as the properties of Omega Vices tend to shift in unexpected, unprecedented ways that other classifications do not, often resulting in lethal misclassifications. The Omega classification is reserved for Vices that cannot be categorized by any of the other classifications, essentially acting as a fringe category of Vices.

- **Threat Level:** Critical
- **Intelligence:** Extreme
- **Core Reactivity:** Nonresponsive
- **Energy Use:** Branch Policy
- **Relative Core Size:** Varied
- **Exhibition:** Giga-balanced
- **Advent:** Gradual

Omega Vices most commonly resemble Epsilon Vices in their ability to withhold parts of their Branch Policy, though even experienced Vice Management Administrators have difficulty deciphering an Omega Vice's Branch Policy, even after multiple Branches.

Exhibitions tend to be fairly consistent, but are often unbearably massive compared to most exhibitions and tend to evolve and grow at rates not observed in other Vices, sometimes even exceeding the limits of giga-exhibitions. Omega Vices have been known to scrap and rework exhibitions on a whim, displaying behaviors seen in Delta Vices, but what sets Omegas apart is their ability to do so within the Branch Domain during an active Branch.

Branch Domains range from being incredibly simple to maze-like and vividly complex, with some Omegas being able to change the Branch Domain during production, not unlike Epsilon Vices unveiling new stages of their domain. What sets Omegas apart, yet again, is their ability to do so during production.

Altering the Branch Domain and exhibition both entail copious amounts of energy, which is why it is often done outside of an active Branch. Omegas doing so in production suggests a level of intelligence and awareness that far exceeds the deceptive Epsilon and focused Xi Vices. Because of this, --gamma subclasses always accompany Omega classifications. Where other --gamma Vices are restricted to single words or broken sentences, Omegas have been documented as carrying on full conversations with their Hosts and even any Adjuncts present. Some have even reported that their Vice has been able to speak to them outside

of the Branch Domain, though this has proven difficult to replicate under a controlled environment. Hosts claim this speech is not through words, like they are in the Branch Domain, but through thoughts and suggestions, similar to intrusive thoughts.

While Omegas all seem to differ in their exhibition attack strategy, they are all quite conservative in initiating Branches. Much like mature Epsilon Vices, they seem to observe and wait for opportune times, rather than act on external stimuli or impulse. While it is possible to “trick” an Epsilon Vice into initiating a Branch, Omega Vices do not typically respond to threats, even those as direct as AV Shots. Likewise, in the Branch Domain, an Omega Vice can sustain incredible amounts of damage before terminating a Branch, drastically prolonging Branch times that aid in excessive germination and augmentation. For this reason, Omega networks are generally well-established, and often result in chronic blights, most commonly extrusion blights.

“Uncertainty” seems to be the unifying theme of Omega Vices, making this classification the most difficult Vice to treat. Features and behaviors vary so greatly between individual Vices that trying to outline similarities has proven to be futile. Many Omegas are initially incorrectly classified because of their greatly varying characteristics and behaviors. At the first sign of deviation from an established Branch Policy, please reach out to a Vice Management Administrator to begin treatment and observation.

Subclasses

In certain cases, further classification may be applied to provide a more complete understanding of a Host's Vice, called subclasses. Subclasses differ from primary classes in that they are unique behaviors or characteristics found throughout all classifications. They are typically concerned with a single behavior or characteristic, rather than a set of criteria.

Subclasses are a fairly new facet of Vice research, primarily contributed to and conducted by Behavioral Analysts. Subclasses are denoted with a leading double-hyphen and are always lowercase (e.g. Epsilon--gamma) and do not impact threat levels, though some can be unique to specific threat levels. Subclasses can also be stacked, for example: Epsilon--gamma--sigma.

The current subclasses are --gamma, --omicron, --sigma, and --rho.

--gamma

This relatively rare subclass is applied to Vices that exhibit a level of intelligence that far surpasses the intelligence of even mature Vices with a high threat level. While all Vices are thought to display some level of sentience, --gamma Vices interact with their Hosts in ways that suggest an advanced understanding of not only the self, but of their Hosts as well. Quantifying these behaviors has proven relatively difficult, though some common examples are an ability to communicate with the Host, either by using words, understanding thoughts, or sharing sensations, and a subjectivity in initiating Branches.

These unique behaviors--and how they differ from similar behaviors in other Vices--are outlined to the best of our current understanding below.

Communication

Speech manifests differently among individual --gamma Vices, and even varies in complexity between the different realms, with the highest mastery typically manifesting in the Branch Domain. Some Vices have difficulty forming complete sentences, others have expansive vocabularies, and some have even held full, complex conversations with the Host and their Adjuncts. In the Branch Domain, Vices use their exhibition as the vessel through which they project

their speech. Voices are about as varied as exhibitions, though their accents tend to mimic Hosts', with greater variation in their pitch, talking speed, and quirks. Maturity tends to affect this ability as well, with most larval Vices struggling to communicate. As the Vice matures and observes its Host for longer, communication seems to come somewhat easier.

Outside of the Branch Domain, however, communication is much less straightforward and objective. Literal words are not said, as a Vice has no means of vocalization; rather, communication tends to take the form of sharing sensations. They're not necessarily complete sentences, but they do convey feelings and ideas in a relatively abstract way, directed straight to the Host's brain. In return, Vices seem to be able to "understand" the Host's thoughts, often responding with novel sensations in return. Some Hosts have reported a foreign sense of guilt emanating from their core when they discuss rescission techniques with their Vice Management Administrator, almost as if the Vice is pleading for its life. Some Vices have even expressed attachment to or affection for the Host.

One may think the ability to communicate with their Vice would swing things in the Host's favor, but this often introduces another avenue for the Vice to take advantage of its Host. Within the Branch Domain, many --gamma Vices use their speech capabilities to manipulate, confuse, or lie to the Host to gain the upper hand, either in the current Branch or future Branches. The introduction of foreign emotions outside of the Branch Domain can also affect a Host's decision-making and muddy details in pursuing treatment.

Branch Instigation Subjectivity

Most Branches can be prepared for by studying a Vice's Branch Policy. An important facet is understanding the environmental triggers that result in Branch initiation, typically established at and pulled from the Vice's advent. In the larval stage, Branches are not initiated often, but in adolescence, most Vices initiate Branches when any external conditions meet the environment triggers of their Branch Policy. As Vices mature, they begin to exhibit restraint and are able to "assess" the environment to make more informed decisions about Branch initiation.

Where --gamma Vices are set apart lies in their ability to perform this assessment through a subjective lens. This indicates an understanding that surpasses a Vice's

typical abilities of “logging” environmental properties and weighing them against each other in a mathematical formula; instead, --gamma Vices are able to pick up on differing tones—even going so far as being able to pinpoint passive aggression or sarcasm—and can assess the situation through the Host’s point of view based on internal, personal, and even unrecognized emotions. Some --gamma Vices have even suggested a Branch initiation subjectivity based on supposed emotions, sometimes conveyed to the Host through sensations, as explored above.

Rather than weighing the conditions in an established, static numerical system, as most Vices do, --gamma Vices introduce an unpredictability to their Branch initiations, making their Branch Policy extremely difficult to understand. This ability makes it near impossible to bait or trigger Branches into being initiated.

While intelligence and observational skills can make other Vices difficult to deal with, ultimately with enough resources, we are able to learn why they take certain actions, as it all boils down to instinct and a drive to procreate or survive. When subjectivity and emotions are introduced into the mix, it becomes much more difficult to draw conclusions and make hypotheses about how a Vice can be expected to behave, making --gamma Vices incredibly difficult to address.

Addressing --gamma Vices

--gamma Vices are quite difficult to handle, as it almost feels impossible to escape their watchful, calculating eye. Many Hosts report the constant, unnerving feeling of being watched, and --gamma Vices always seem prepared for any new strategies the Host discussed with their Vice Management Administrator. Catching a --gamma Vice by surprise is near impossible, and it’s not fully understood what all these Vices are able to observe.

Many Vice Management Administrators address these Vices by instigating a Branch without an explicit plan and enlisting the help of multiple Solutions Architects to help concoct a plan once the Branch moves into production. When a Vice seems to be prepared for everything, sometimes the best plan is not having one at all.

--omicron

--omicron Vices are capable of camouflaging their network with a technique called “masking”. These Vices have evolved to emit a dense, neutralizing particle that can coat both their core and the tracks of their network, preventing them from detection, even with Parsing Goggles. This technique is implemented as a way to lure Hosts into a false sense of security by keeping activity hidden. In some instances, this ability has also prevented accurate or timely classification.

Larval --omicron Vices tend to avoid masking, as doing so often requires more resources than most larval Vices can establish without a network. However, some Vices of a higher threat level are able to manipulate energy resources early on in their life cycle. As most Vices move into adolescence, they will practice masking by primarily targeting the core, especially in early adolescence before a network becomes well-established. As --omicron Vices reach maturity, they will strategically target the network to mask activity and hide any established rumina. Non--omicron rumina are easily detected using Parsing Goggles to track the path of the stolon from the Host to the rumen. Without the ability to see the network, this path is not visible.

Research suggests that masking does impose a drain on the Vice’s resources. Because of this, the “intensity” of the cloaking tends to fluctuate based on environmental readings from the Vice’s network and the Vice’s activity. Simply speaking, this cloaking mechanism is a spectrum, and it is not always maxed out.

This camouflaging mechanism, while on a spectrum, can also be pin-pointed to target specific areas of the network. Oftentimes, mature Vices with a rumen will camouflage the network and the stolon, but leave the rumen visible. Without the stolon visibly connecting the two, associating a rumen with its Host can be quite difficult. When observing a rumen, if the stolon is not visible, one of two things may be happening, depending on the VG output. If the rumen is steadily leaking VG into the environment, the rumen has been severed from the Host, but if the rumen simply has VG hovering around its body, it is likely still connected with the Host, but the stolon has been camouflaged. Disposing of the rumen in this instance is risky, and connected --omicron rumen are typically left alone.

Regular visits with a Vice Management Administrator or Record Proctor can help track the Vice's progress based on other characteristics and symptoms. Many Vice Management Administrators will purposefully initiate a Branch after collecting the proper resources in an attempt to force the Vice to lower its cloaking abilities. Additionally, our Manufacturing team is currently working on a new type of lens for Parsing Goggles to address this issue.

Branch Domain Benefits

Masking is a process that evolved to primarily affect the Vice in the corporeal realm, but in the metaphysical realm, experts believe there may be some benefits to masking. Most classifications cannot alter their exhibition during an active Branch—though Delta and Epsilon Vices sport unique abilities. --omicron Vices, however, are able to “cloak” the exhibition, going so far as to manipulate its supposed size and stature to hide in plain sight or evade detection. Meso- and macro-exhibitions can have masks as small as one foot, and vice versa.

These metaphysical illusions are difficult to maintain and will lose effectiveness if interacted with. They are often triggered as a stalling tactic, observed most commonly in Vices that prioritize germination, such as Beta, Epsilon, and Theta.

Discussion

Due to this metaphysical benefit, --omicron subclasses have begun to appear more commonly in Delta and Epsilon Vices, and many researchers seem to suggest their exhibition-altering abilities are related. What sets this subclass apart from these primary classifications is a Vice's ability to mask once the Branch has entered production. There is current discussion whether or not the --omicron subclass should be promoted to a primary classification, potentially as a branch off of Epsilon Vices.

--sigma

--sigma Vices have wider diet preferences, most commonly observed in, but not unique to, Zeta Vices. Where other Vices feed on hormones, --sigma Vices are much more permissive and feed on other bodily substances such as plasma or synovial fluid in addition to hormones. --sigma Vices typically have a gradual advent, are more likely to reach maturity, and are known for more complex Branch Policies.

A --sigma palate is much less particular, and they can shift their primary energy source depending on resource availability. They are much more adaptable and resilient in times of scarcity, where other Vices may need to sacrifice growth. --sigma cores are often larger than others, though they do tend to be less structurally sound and are more susceptible to damage from AV or attacks in the Branch Domain. Despite their permissive palate, Vices biologically benefit best from the consumption of hormones, so if a --sigma Vice doesn't keep a varied diet that also includes hormones, its form can be compromised.

Due to the elevated feeding habits of most larval Vices, many with a --sigma subclass are actually initially discovered by health professionals outside of CVRS. Because their feeding is not confined to hormones, --sigma Vices often result in adverse medical effects and can be initially detected using medical imaging or blood tests.

--rho

While most Vices have a single, stationary core, --rho Vices have multiple, smaller cores throughout the Host's body connected by an extremely dense network that often presents as stiff joints. This subclass typically accompanies Vices of a higher threat level and are often stacked with the --gamma subclass. Vices with established networks often receive this subclass, such as Zeta and Epsilon Vices.

--rho Vices start out with a single core that houses and processes information. As they mature, they create more cores in a process not dissimilar to advent, wherein the VG coursing throughout the body colonizes a benign mass. Cores created post-advent act like rumina until the main core is threatened, either by a patch in the Branch Domain or by manual intervention with an AV Shot. Even after sustaining damage, the core is able to send the bulk of its information—including its Branch Policy and other data—to a different core using the network. This process is near-instantaneous, taking no more than a few seconds to send the information from head to toe. All Vice cores will need to be destroyed in order for the Vice to be properly rescinded.

The Branch Phenomenon

Learn common Branch terminology and discover the options available as the Host of a Branch. Prepare for the Branch Domain and learn how to enlist the help of Adjuncts.

Branch Policy includes the environmental Branch trigger(s), the Branch Domain blueprint, exhibition presentation and attack strategy, as well as the priorities outside of the Branch Domain.

A Host is likely to experience anywhere from 10 to 30 Branches in a single Vice's life cycle. Larval Vices are less likely to initiate Branches, if at all, while adolescent Vices tend to be quite impulsive and initiate the majority of Branches in a Vice's life cycle. Mature Vices tend to exhibit more discernment and are more thoughtful before initiating Branches.

This dissociative phenomenon is the side effect of the overwhelming influx of vitiumglomerorum (VG) emitted when a Vice attempts the expansion of its core or network. The term "Branch" encompasses all three stages and presents the Host with three options: suspending, committing or rescinding the Branch. During production, a Host temporarily loses contact with their body, and their consciousness is transported to the Branch Domain, a metaphysical—but finite and limited—environment where the Vice's exhibition can be fought and the core can be damaged. This out-of-body experience is often described as a hallucination or dream, though actions taken in the Branch Domain can have very real consequences.

As explored in *Vice Biology*, Vices feed on our hormones, most commonly indulging in those released during high-stress situations such as cortisol, adrenaline, and norepinephrine. They often wait for particularly triggering situations where these hormone levels are elevated. Once the Vice detects the sharp increase in hormones, it performs an environmental check, then releases VG from its core to sedate the Host and begin to expand its core or network undeterred.

Branches are comprised of three phases: initiation, staging, and production, each explored in detail in Branch Phases. Collectively, the details of these phases are part of a Vice's Branch Policy, a relatively static set of criteria and behaviors that can help a Host prepare for and even avoid future Branches. The

Branch Mechanics

Branches are an incredibly complex phenomenon with many aspects that are still under rigorous observation by our Branch Analysts and Exposure Analysts. The mechanics outlined below can help provide a clearer understanding of what to expect if one finds themselves in a Branch.

***Branch Phases* 57**

Branches are comprised of three phases—initiation, staging, and production—each having unique properties that can serve the Host and Adjuncts valuable information that can aid in future Branches and even inform rescission tactics.

***Branch Policies* 62**

Every Vice has a set of relatively static data that influences Branches, known collectively as the Branch Policy. This data is typically established at advent and tends to remain generally the same throughout a Vice's life cycle, though some properties can increase in complexity.

***Branch Options* 64**

Hosts and Adjuncts have three options when addressing a Branch, depending on the Branch phase. During staging, an Adjunct can suspend the Branch, and during production the Host or an Adjunct can commit or rescind the Branch.

***Exploring Exhibitions* 67**

Only present in the Branch Domain, a Vice's exhibition shields the vulnerable core from the Host, Adjuncts and their patches. Exhibitions also influence blights, as many properties present in the exhibition are mirrored as blights, most commonly seen as horns, teeth or skin textures. Exhibitions are incredibly unique and vary greatly between Hosts, though experts have begun grouping them by size and attack strategy.

***The Role of Adjuncts* 69**

While it is possible to address Branches alone, many Hosts benefit from the support that Adjuncts can offer. Adjuncts can increase the success rates, typically by strengthening defenses, increasing firepower, or even serving as a distraction. Adjuncts can be classified as primary, secondary, or tertiary.

***Fringe Branch Events* 72**

While Branches of all kinds share the same three phases, there are some situations that can disrupt the expected flow.

Branch Phases

Branches are comprised of three phases—initiation, staging, and production—each having unique properties that can serve the Host and Adjuncts valuable information that can aid in future Branches and even inform rescission tactics.

The properties outlined below are most commonly found in Alpha and Beta Vices. While all Vices construct triphasic Branches, certain characteristics of these phases can vary between classifications, as explored in the individual classification pages under *Classifying Vices*.

Phase 0: Quality Assurance Check (QAC)

Adolescent and Mature Vices Only

Adolescent and mature Vices run a quick quality assurance check (QAC) after the core detects an increase in its desired hormone. All Branches must follow an increase in hormones, but not all hormone increases result in a Branch. A QAC is comprised of two checks, first assessing the status of the Host's body, then the external environment.

Because a Vice relies on its network to gather data about the Host's body, larval Vices cannot perform QAC checks. Instead, larval Vices wait for elevated hormone levels to reach an extreme, though this objective threshold is relatively high, resulting in little to no initiated Branches during the larval stage for most classifications.

The preliminary data gathered about the Host's body includes a comprehensive view of hormone levels—not just the level of its preferred hormone—AV output, and traditional vital signs such as temperature, heart rate, respiration rate, and blood pressure. This data tells the Vice if the hormone increase is an anomaly or the direct result of a specific event and if it is safe to pursue initiation, in the event of a lower AV output.

After the Vice determines the Host's body is in a state conducive to Branch initiation, they will then assess the environment. Using a stolon—a single, external track—Vices generate a log of the surrounding environment's properties. The complexity and number of properties logged differ between classifications and maturity levels. Common properties include general location (indoor vs. outdoor), proximity to others, sound level, and smells. Properties logged by more meticulous Vices can include, but are not limited to,

temperature and humidity, the amount of natural light, specific words or phrases based on sound waves, and even the presence of specific people.

After this second check, a Vice will only initiate a Branch if the environmental properties match at least three of those found at advent. This, of course, is relatively straightforward for sudden advents, but tend to be difficult to gauge for gradual advents. These properties are one facet of the Branch Policy, and tend to remain the same throughout the Vice's life cycle.

After the QAC is passed, the Vice officially initiates the Branch. When a Vice performs a QAC and opts to initiate a Branch despite no presence of advent properties, this is known as a rogue Branch, further explored in *Fringe Branch Events*.

Phase 1: Initiation

Initiation, though referred to as a phase, is more of a “toggle”, indicating the beginning of the Branch. The environmental and internal circumstances that result in the successful initiation of a Branch are a vital part of a Vice's Branch Policy and should be documented to more accurately predict or even avoid future Branches. These properties can also be used to try to “bait” a Vice into initiating a Branch, where instigation may be risky.

Branch initiation is marked by a physiological change to the Vice's network. By default, the vitiumnexa (VN) that make up the tracks in a Vice's network are tightly-packed and neutrally charged, but after initiation, the tracks' structural integrity is compromised as the VN becomes positively-charged and the molecules begin repelling one another, allowing for VG to escape into the Host's system.

Some Hosts are able to “feel” their own Branch initiation, most commonly experienced as a fluttering, irregular heartbeat or a sudden, inexplicable ice pick headache, both likely due to the change in the electromagnetic field within them. While not as common, other physiological indicators of initiation have been reported, such as goosebumps, twitching muscles, inexplicable nausea, sudden dizziness, and lockjaw.

Phase 2: Staging

A Branch officially moves into staging once the VG—previously contained in the tracks—leech out into the Host's bloodstream due to the holes in the Vice's

tracks, resulting in a sedative effect. Hosts also report brain fog, depression, and anxiety during this time. Roughly 15% of Hosts have the opposite reaction to the increased VG and instead become erratic and volatile during staging. Regardless of this reaction, Hosts often feel like their actions are out of their control, like their body has been put on autopilot. While Hosts are aware of their surroundings during this time, they feel like they are in limbo as their body acts on its own.

As the VG level increases throughout the body, immune responses are more likely. Reactions can range from mildly irritating to excruciating. Itching, increased body temperature, sweating, and even anaphylaxis are all potential reactions, in addition to agitated blights and increased AV output. Additionally, the body releases stress hormones, which the Vice temporarily stores in its core or in network pockets to fuel its pending germination and core augmentation. Despite its best efforts, the Host's immune system is often overwhelmed during this time and is unable to defend against the onslaught of VG.

In the beginnings of staging, the altered electromagnetic field that marked initiation fans outward from the Host, becoming the “staging radius”. A standard staging radius extends roughly 12 feet, but can be as short as six or as wide as eighteen. Those within the staging radius report disorienting vestibular disturbances, with symptoms such as tinnitus, nausea, imbalance, and vertigo. Many also feel a slight “tugging” at the soles of their feet, resulting in the trademark “magnetic pull” of staging.

During staging, if physical contact is made with the Host, the person will be added to the Branch queue, a liminal space where Adjuncts linger while the Branch is being fabricated. A potential Adjunct must make and maintain physical contact with the Host throughout staging in order to be included in production. If contact is lost during this phase, the Adjunct will be “dismissed” from the queue, but can easily be re-added as long as the Branch is still in staging. Learn more about admitting Adjuncts to Branches in *The Role of Adjuncts: Branch Admission*.

As the Branch approaches production, some particularly intelligent Vices will briefly send bursts of energy not unlike hypnic jerks in an attempt to break contact, though this tends to be energy-intensive and is only performed by desperate or mature Vices. Much

like the Host, Adjuncts in the queue are aware of their surroundings, but feel like they are on autopilot.

Tertiary Adjuncts are added to the queue by the Vice extending external tracks, called stolons, to reach any people within the staging radius. This behavior is often observed in adolescent and mature Vices with a well-established network that are aiming for increased energy consumption during dispersion, as observed in Theta Vices. This connection can be easily lost, however, if the tertiary Adjunct is able to break free from the trance, which is relatively simple due to the lack of physical contact. This action is typically performed shortly before the Branch moves into production, wherein the connection is solidified and slightly more difficult to breach.

On the whole, staging typically lasts anywhere from one to three minutes, depending on the intended complexity of the Branch, with instigated Branches often having shorter staging times.

Suspension

At any time during staging, a patch can be summoned to aid in suspending a Branch, where the patch is more abstract in its form, with fuzzy edges and warping shapes due to its composition of AV. Suspension criterion differs between Vices, but is generally achieved by threatening the Vice core with bursts of AV, either from a patch or an AV Shot, without making direct, physical contact with the Host, as contact with the Host during staging will admit the person to the staging queue. Suspension should only be pursued as a last resort, as discussed in *Branch Options*.

Phase 3: Production

Production is the most complex of the phases and is where the majority of the action occurs. A Branch is officially in production once staging is complete and the Host is immobilized and unresponsive to external stimuli. Many Hosts recall the sensation of falling as they are admitted to the Branch Domain, marking the start of production. Adjuncts, on the other hand, remain in the queue for their designated admission time and are always admitted to the Branch Domain after the Host.

Production occurs in two realms: corporeal and metaphysical. The metaphysical realm refers to the events that take place in the Branch Domain, a shared “battleground” of sorts where facsimiles of the Host and Adjuncts, called “extensions”, duel against the

Vice's exhibition, a grotesque visage that surrounds and protects the Vice's core. The corporeal realm refers to the physical state of affairs outside of the Branch Domain, including core behavior and the physiological effects on the Host's body, as well as any physical interactions between the Host and Adjuncts.

The metaphysical realm operates on a different timeline from the corporeal realm, where five minutes of corporeal time can span anywhere from 10 minutes to an hour of metaphysical time. While these realms are separate, what happens in the metaphysical realm often loosely mirrors the events of the corporeal realm, and vice versa, each being able to influence the other realm. This relationship is not a direct one-to-one, and researchers are still trying to fully understand the degree to which the events that take place in each realm directly impact the other. It is generally understood how the events of the corporeal realm affect the metaphysical realm, but the opposite still requires extensive research. The metaphysical realm, and by extension the Branch Domain, is particularly difficult to observe and document from a strictly objective standpoint due to its unique properties between Hosts. The intricacies of these realms are explored further below.

The current theory as of now is that the actions that take place in the Branch Domain mirror the corporeal realm, and vice versa. Direct attacks on the exhibition translate to bursts of AV from Adjuncts or the Host; likewise, bursts of AV in the corporeal realm act as buffs to the extensions' patches in the Branch Domain. As with AV enhancement therapies and patch calibration, AV from external sources can bolster a Host's internal AV production, a process that occurs through physical touch. This process is not always guaranteed, and an inability to produce AV during an active Branch can translate to flubbed or ineffective attacks in the Branch Domain.

Branches are intended to be committed or rescinded during this phase, most commonly performed in the metaphysical realm, though some exceptions apply. Inaction while a Branch is in production can lead to a berserk or comatose Host, which often makes committing or rescinding the Branch more difficult. This phase does not last for a determined amount of time, but if ignored, a Vice can achieve dispersion in less than 10 minutes of corporeal time, sometimes as quickly as five in extreme circumstances.

The Corporeal Realm

Physically, Hosts have described this realm as almost dreamlike in quality, some even going so far as to liken it to drug-induced dissociative episodes. The overwhelming rush of VG has a sedative effect on the Host to deter interference with the core's expansion. The Host is also "disconnected" from their body in the sense that they do not react to stimuli once the Branch is in production. The only way to break a Host from this trance is to commit or rescind the Vice.

Because the Host has essentially been sedated, behavioral symptoms are generally mild, but the physiological reactions seen in staging often persist. Hosts are technically able to feel pain during this time, but are not typically able to recall in explicit detail, similar to the effects of anesthesia or nitrous oxide. Most events that transpire in the corporeal realm are recalled with muddy, vague details, not unlike trying to remember a dream after waking up.

Branches are typically not addressed in the corporeal realm, except in the extreme circumstances of manual and exposure rescission, experimental rescission methods that should only be performed as a last resort. Learn more about the different types of rescission in *The Branch Phenomenon: Branch Options* or talk to a Vice Management Administrator today.

The Metaphysical Realm (Branch Domain)

Production officially begins once the Host is admitted to the Branch Domain, where the majority of action takes place. Adjuncts are admitted to the Branch Domain in the same order they were added to the queue during staging, with a 1:8 ratio for wait times. That is to say, if an Adjunct joined the queue 15 seconds into staging, they would be admitted roughly 2 minutes after the Host is admitted to the Branch Domain.

Everyone experiences this intangible realm differently, but many have likened being in the Branch Domain to lucid dreaming or astral projecting. Those who have spent less time in this realm have difficulty orienting themselves, though it comes more naturally over time. While research is still being conducted, this environment is believed to be the "side effect" of having the body being overrun with VG, and the shared contact is what enables the "shared hallucination" to occur between those present for the Branch. The mechanics of the metaphysical realm continue to be a hot research topic and are continually

documented by the Observation team as well as agents present in the domain.

This arena typically mimics the properties of the environment around the Host during advent. Arenas vary greatly in size, ranging anywhere from the size of a standard room to multi-acre fields. The smaller arenas of Vices with a sudden advent tend to have sharper details with a focus on objects, while the larger arenas of Vices with a gradual advent tend to be less detailed, with an emphasis on feelings, sensations, and disorienting architecture. Mature Vices with high threat levels can sometimes accomplish both, creating complex, escheresque environments with strikingly realistic details.

The five senses can and are often aroused within the domain, with Hosts and Adjuncts able to recall sounds, smells, and even tastes after a Branch has passed. This environment typically does not change throughout a Vice's life cycle, but it may increase in complexity and expand to include a larger area or a different room, for example. Some intelligent Vices are capable of completely changing this environment between Branches, but this is incredibly rare overall.

Experts believe Vices use the blueprint of the Branch Domain to gain the psychological upper hand over the Host, even though those with lower intelligence are likely not doing so knowingly. As a Vice's consciousness begins to form in direct response to the increase in stress, they come to associate the physical environment around the Host with that of readily available hormones. Vices make this "homage" back to the environment at advent, expecting an increase in hormones to fuel its planned augmentation or germination.

Because of these often uncannily accurate callbacks to the advent site, some Hosts are at risk of "getting lost" in the Branch Domain, especially in its early stages as Hosts are trying to find their footing. Branch Domains are disorienting enough as-is, but with the often successful attempts at triggering strong emotions, navigating a Branch Domain can be incredibly difficult. Learning to "control" one's extension is not intuitive and requires practice and concentration. Strong emotions can muddy the connection between a Host and their extension, making it difficult to think quickly and clearly. As a Host becomes berserk, this connection becomes much more difficult to maintain. Comatose Hosts are almost completely detached from their extensions.

Vices with a higher threat level often use psychological tactics to further dissuade action by projecting visages of people from the Host's life. These projections typically pull from the Host's memories and are used to discourage or distract the Host from acting promptly, triggering strong emotions or psychologically trapping them in past scenarios. When observed closely, these projections can be somewhat unsettling. They are often likened to images generated by young neural nets, resulting in uncanny reconstructions that tend to put people on edge. These projections can and will react to speech or touch, but typically in incoherent or uncharacteristic ways. While these projections may seem threatening, they cannot physically harm the extensions of the Host or Adjuncts.

Another facet of a Vice's Branch Policy is its exhibition, a visage only seen and deployed in the Branch Domain. Its purpose is to both intimidate the Host and protect its core from attacks, which the visage is constructed around. In the Branch Domain, exhibitions can be as small as a house cat or span as much as 5 times taller than the average human. A Vice's exhibition tends to remain largely unchanged throughout its life cycle, though a select few have been observed to alter their characteristics between Branches. Some suspect that core placement in the body can mimic core placement in the Vice's exhibition; though, this has not been substantiated and is a massive generalization, as many exhibitions do not share our anatomy.

Exhibitions most commonly mimic animals—spanning the breadth of the animal kingdom from mammals to reptiles to insects and everything in between—often preying on our innate fear of predators or even personal phobias. Less commonly, exhibitions extend beyond our zoological roster and present as amalgamations of multiple animals and can even mimic those found in science fiction and horror films. A Vice's threat level typically informs the complexity and novelty of its exhibition. Learn more about exhibitions in *Exploring Exhibitions*.

Within the Branch Domain, patches can be summoned to fight the exhibition and threaten or destroy the Vice core. The form that patches take in production are more concrete and stable than their form in staging. If a patch is summoned during staging and the wielder is brought in as an Adjunct, the patch will already be active once they enter the Branch Domain. Learn more about using patches in the Branch Domain in *Branch*

Options, or learn about the process of establishing one in *AV and Patches*.

Any and all objects present in the Branch Domain can have an effect on and be used to defend or fight against the Vice's exhibition, though patches will always be the most efficient due to their composition. This includes both the Host and Adjunct's extensions, meaning hand-to-hand combat can be an effective means of action if a patch cannot be summoned. This also means that these extensions can be affected and damaged by the Vice's exhibition.

If a Host or Adjunct's extension is damaged by the exhibition in the metaphysical realm, similar injuries are incurred in the corporeal realm, though they will be significantly less severe. For example, if a Host's bone is broken in the metaphysical realm, it can present as joint stiffness in the corporeal realm, even lasting after the Branch has been addressed. The gap in severity varies from person to person, though Hosts tend to incur more serious injuries in the corporeal realm compared to Adjuncts.

If an Adjunct's extension is destroyed in the Branch Domain, they are immediately ejected. Due to the severity of the injuries incurred in the Branch Domain, they will quickly begin to see the effects of the Branch on their body through ailments such as deep bruises, lacerations, minor bone fractures or even acute illness. Vices do not typically destroy the Host's extension and tend to keep them trapped in the Branch Domain so as to not risk interference as they continue germination or augmentation.

Branch Policies

Every Vice has a set of relatively static data that influences Branches, known collectively as the Branch Policy. This data is typically established at advent and tends to remain generally the same throughout a Vice's life cycle, though some properties can increase in complexity.

A Vice's Branch Policy is comprised of the following properties, each further explained below:

- **Environmental Branch Trigger(s)**
the environmental conditions that result in Branch initiation
- **Branch Domain Blueprint:**
the layout of the Branch Domain
- **Exhibition Presentation:**
the exhibition's makeup and features
- **Exhibition Attack Strategy:**
how the exhibition behaves in the Branch Domain
- **Priorities:** overall, which process the Vice devotes the most energy towards

Contrary to popular belief, the time between Branches is not part of a Vice's Branch Policy, and is instead influenced by the method used in addressing the Branch (suspension vs commit) and how much the core was damaged. Learn more about this relationship in *Branch Options*. Additionally, different classifications and Vices in different life stages can have varying preferences. For example, larval Epsilon Vices initiate almost no Branches at all, while adolescent Alpha Vices can initiate Branches as often as bi-weekly. Learn more about these expected behaviors in *Classifying Vices*.

Environmental Branch Trigger(s)

This set of information is established at advent and is referenced during the Quality Assurance Check (QAC) before a Branch. If the current properties of the Host's environment match at minimum three of the properties found at advent, the Vice will likely proceed with Branch initiation. Examples of these properties most commonly include sounds and smells, but can even include temperature and the amount of natural light. Because of their numeric, formula-like approach, these triggers can easily be prepared for and anticipated in certain conditions.

Epsilon Vices and other Vices with gradual advents, however, can have a broad pool of conditions to pull from, making it difficult to map this facet in early development. Additionally, the --omega subclass

introduces a unique subjectivity into this decision-making process that can make it near impossible to parse.

Because larval Vices do not have the biological infrastructure to perform QACs, they instead assess internal conditions and are likely to initiate a Branch if the preferred hormone level exceeds a specific threshold.

Learn more about QACs and the conditions assessed in *Branch Phases*.

Branch Domain Blueprint

As discussed in *The Metaphysical Realm* (Branch Domain), the layout of the Branch Domain typically pulls inspiration from the environment around the Host at advent. Vices with a sudden advent typically result in smaller, compact domains that focus more on explicit details and the literal translation of environments. Small details can be difficult to parse when observed directly, much like attempting to recall the details of a dream. Gradual advents, on the other hand, result in larger, more complex domains that focus on the "feel" of the environment. This is typically an abstract concept, as many Hosts cannot relay the specific details that make them uneasy about the domain; rather, feelings gathered from the complex circumstances around advent are somehow imbued into the domain. These can differ between Hosts, but common feelings include urgency, dread, and overwhelm.

The overall blueprint of the Branch Domain stays roughly the same throughout a Vice's life cycle, but can and often does increase in complexity as the Vice matures, especially for those with a gradual advent or a higher threat level. As they mature, some Vices with gradual advents will reveal additional "stages" to their Branch Domain, tied together by disorienting, escheresque transitions, such as Epsilon Vices, for example. Delta Vices are able to completely abandon these blueprints and start from scratch in a process known as shedding. Some classifications are capable of constructing completely novel blueprints during their life cycle to better adapt to threats, but this is only observed in the extremely intelligent Omega classification.

Exhibition Presentation

Only present in the Branch Domain, a Vice's exhibition shields the vulnerable core from the Host,

Adjuncts and their patches. Exhibitions typically take the form of predatory animals—though the possibilities are endless. Some exhibitions are comprised of the properties present at advent, typically textures, smells or sounds and can even draw from the innate fears of the Host. The characteristics of the exhibition are also influenced by its attack strategy, and vice versa, an example being how defensive exhibitions typically have a thicker skin or protective outer shell.

Exhibitions are incredibly unique and vary greatly between Hosts, but tend to stay roughly the same throughout a Vice's life cycle. As with the Branch Domain blueprint, a Vice's exhibition can increase in complexity as the Vice matures. Exhibitions can be classified by size, and tend to stay in the same size grouping, even as complexity increases. Epsilon Vices often shroud characteristics of their exhibition presentation to later reveal as a trump card, Deltas can completely scrap and create new exhibitions as a result of shedding, and the intelligent Omega Vices are able to change exhibition characteristics, even during an active Branch. Learn more about exhibitions in *Exploring Exhibitions* or explore the different exhibition characteristics between classifications in *Classifying Vices*.

Exhibition Attack Strategy

This data set is relatively broad and refers to a Vice's M.O., that is, how the Vice interacts with the Host and Adjuncts within the Branch Domain. This attack strategy informs how the exhibition is classified, as offensive, defensive, hasty, or balanced. A Vice's attack strategy is not directly tied to its classification, though most classes tend to see higher concentrations of specific exhibition attack strategies. For example, Theta Vices typically have hasty exhibitions while Zeta Vices almost exclusively have defensive exhibitions.

Attack strategy also refers to the literal plan of attack once the Branch moves into production. This data is extremely broad, as every exhibition is different, but includes preferences such as which extensions the exhibition targets and how the exhibition interacts with the Branch Domain—if it uses objects or hides behind them. Learn more about exhibitions in *Exploring Exhibitions* or explore the different exhibition characteristics between classifications in *Classifying Vices*.

Priorities

This facet refers to what process(es) a Vice prioritizes during active Branches and even between Branches. Vices are capable of multitasking, though doing so often sacrifices efficiency and performance in multiple areas. Because of this, when presented with the decision of what to pursue, Vices typically have a preference. Much like the exhibition attack strategy, this is not necessarily tied to a Vice's classification, though it is influenced heavily.

For example, most Alpha Vices pursue augmentation, but Beta Vices prefer germination. Not all Vices choose between germination and augmentation, however. Delta Vices direct their energy toward shedding, and Zeta Vices use theirs to establish rumina.

This priority does not imply that a Vice will only use their energy to perform shedding or germination; rather, what this facet implies is a Vice's dedication to a given process. All Vices must perform germination and augmentation as they mature, but overall, a Vice that prioritizes germination will have a much more established and complex network compared to those that prioritize augmentation. Learn more about these priorities and what they imply for each classification in *Classifying Vices*.

Branch Options

Hosts and Adjuncts have three options when encountering a Branch, depending on the Branch phase. During staging, an Adjunct can suspend the Branch, and during production the Host or an Adjunct can commit or rescind the Branch.

Suspend (Staging)

Suspending a Branch requires an Adjunct to threaten the Vice's core during staging without making physical contact. What constitutes as "threatening" varies greatly between Vices, though it usually involves overwhelming the core with a burst of AV while the Branch is being staged. While Hosts, in theory, can suspend their own Branch using an AV Shot, as discussed below, staging typically sedates and compromises the Host, making it difficult to perform self-suspension.

Suspension is most commonly achieved in one of two ways, either by using a patch or an AVShot to facilitate this "burst" of AV. A bludgeoning patch is less "damaging" to the Host's physical body and tends to threaten the Vice core in a less invasive manner due to the burst of AV released from contact. Piercing and slashing patches are more concentrated and need to cut quite deep in order to threaten the core, which also runs the risk of triggering fusion if the patch comes too close. While AV Shots are not widely available, CVRS agents can administer them en lieu of using a patch, which is the recommended method of suspension as it avoids inflicting harm on the Host. The rush of AV works to threaten the Vice much in the same way a burst of AV from a patch would.

A Vice will also terminate the Branch if the Host loses consciousness during staging, either from natural causes or as the direct result of the damage incurred from a patch. It is not uncommon for bludgeoning patches to result in a loss of consciousness before the Vice is officially threatened, as the bursts of AV combined with repeated blunt trauma are typically enough to render the Host unconscious. For this reason, we recommend using an AV Shot rather than attempting suspension with a patch.

Suspending, compared to committing, is often regarded as a reckless approach with many downsides; this is because suspension:

- **exposes the Host to unnecessary bodily harm**
Regardless of the suspension approach, some degree

of harm must be imparted on the Host's body in order to be successful. Even if an AV Shot is used en lieu of a patch, the Host's body still has to undergo the side effects of flooding the body with AV, as explored in AV Enhancement.

- **reduces the time until the next potential Branch**
For example, if the typical down time between committed Branches is 6 weeks, but a Host suspends the Branch instead, another Branch could be initiated in less than two weeks.
- **can lead to rogue Branches or deviations in Branch Policy**
Vices tend to react poorly to surprises and interference, also seen in their negative reactions to instigated Branches. In an effort to regain control, a Vice is likely to initiate rogue Branches to catch the Host off guard and pursue to the progress that was previously impeded.
- **aids in the reproduction of Vices**
During staging, the VG coursing throughout the Host's body tend to seep out of the pores in the skin and spread across the epidermis in a thin layer. In the event of an amateur suspension, using a patch to perform suspension often works to actually spread VG, compared to attacking the core in the confines of the Branch Domain. This is particularly due to the fact that bludgeoning patches are the most common patch type when performing suspension outside of CVRS.
- **misses out on the opportunity to reduce overall core progress**
Committing a Branch reliably nullifies not only the progress made in germination or augmentation during the Branch, but also reduces the overall size of the core due to the damage inflicted. For example, during a Branch, a 30mm core may expand 5mm and create 3 new tracks in their network. Committing the Branch nullifies the newly-created tracks and can reduce the size of the core to 28mm. Conversely, suspending a Branch does no more than pause the germination or augmentation progress.
- **degrades patches quickly**
Using a patch outside of the Branch Domain can result in an unstable form, reducing its efficacy. Patches are intended to be wielded in the Branch Domain, where they receive much less wear and tear from use, making it easier to maintain the patch's form between Branches. The damage received during staging is typically so severe that it can be difficult to repair in full before the next Branch without AV enhancement therapy.

Due to these downsides, suspension should only be performed as a last resort after it is determined that more help or time to prepare is needed.

Commit (Production)

The circumstances around commits are fairly lenient, so long as the core is damaged during the production phase of an active Branch. Commits can be performed by an Adjunct or the Host himself in the metaphysical realm using any means necessary, including patches, their bare hands, or even objects found in the Branch Domain.

The degree of damage required to prompt Branch termination varies between classifications and even between individual Vices. Some are more quick to concede after minimal damage, while others require more substantial damage. Vices with a low threat level tend to be more reactive, while Vices with a higher threat level tend to be more intentional. Learn about this characteristic of the individual classifications in *Classifying Vices*.

In the metaphysical realm, Vices house their core in their exhibition, which acts as a dense barrier between its core and the Host, Adjuncts and patches.

Exhibitions react to and can be damaged by patches, where contact between the two typically results in a burst of energy that depletes the level of VG in the exhibition and the AV in the patch. Repeated manual combat can also damage an exhibition without losing AV, though it is less efficient.

Because both the exhibition and patches lose density and become less effective over time, technique and discernment are encouraged so as to not render patches useless during a Branch. Patches can be restored, though this is a timely process and not something many can afford to do during Branches. Despite repeated exposure, manual combat does not lose its effectiveness over time and is considered a suitable backup in the event of ineffective patches.

As explored in *Branch Phases*, a Branch in production has two realms: the corporeal and metaphysical. The corporeal realm consists of everything outside of the Branch Domain, while everything inside is the metaphysical realm. As of now, our current understanding is that the events that happen in one realm are more or less “mirrored” in the other. For example, Adjuncts who seem to be gaining ground and subduing the exhibition in the Branch Domain may have higher AV outputs that are contributing to the destruction of the Vice’s core in the Host’s body. The opposite is also true, in that higher AV outputs can

result in bolstered patches and critical hits against the exhibition.

When a Branch is successfully committed, due to the damage to the core, a Vice retracts any newly sprouted germination tracks and diverts the energy to focus on repairing the core. It is not likely that it will regain any growth progress, as its main focus is on repairing the damaged epithelium to better defend against future attacks.

It is difficult to pose a generalized statement about the relationship between core damage and the time between Branches, as this relationship is typically unique to individual Vices. While not part of the Branch Policy, with dedicated observation, this relationship can be parsed and used to prepare for future Branches. Though, as a general rule, the time between committed Branches will always be longer than suspended Branches.

Committing a Branch is always recommended over suspending a Branch for the following reasons:

- Committing a Branch provides the opportunity to inflict enough damage to the core for a Vice to lose progress. Suspending a Branch will never result in lost progress, as it merely halts its progress. Some more aggressive and efficient commits have been shown to reduce the size of a Vice core by nearly half.
- This lost progress buys a Host more time between Branches as it focuses on repair, compared to suspension.
- Branches provide the Host and any primary or secondary Adjuncts present with valuable information that can inform rescission methodology, whereas suspending a Branch before it moves into production doesn’t allow the Host to gather any new information
- Repeated summoning within the Branch Domain bolsters and solidifies patch markup, allowing for minor enhancements between Branches
- Allowing Adjuncts to regularly join and commit Branches can result in a primary Adjunct with a stronger tie to the Host and better footing in the Branch Domain. Primary Adjuncts are often integral to a successful rescission.

Rescind (Production)

Rescinding a Branch is the act of destroying a Vice core, ultimately killing the Vice. Rescission is a difficult process that requires strength, discernment, and precision. Weaker and more imprecise blows will merely damage the core and trigger the Vice to

terminate the Branch before the core can be fully destroyed. Terminating a Branch requires energy and entails reverting the charge of the vitiumnexa and corralling both the vitiumnexa and any stray VG throughout the Host's body to reform its network. If the core is damaged enough before it can react, it will be unable to terminate the Branch and the core will be vulnerable, allowing the Host or Adjuncts to completely destroy it.

The Host and Adjuncts will need to utilize the observations and information gathered in previous Branches to prepare the most efficient and extensive plan of attack, known as the rescission methodology. *Classifying Vices* briefly outlines tactics for rescinding the various classifications.

Having a diverse team of support for rescission is highly recommended, as the varying patches and vantage points offer a multitude of benefits. While the Host's patch is typically crafted as a bespoke weapon to combat their Vice's exhibition, sometimes a multi-tool approach needs to be implemented for more complex or defensive exhibitions. Solutions Architects are CVRS agents trained to detect weaknesses in a Vice's exhibition, and can be a valuable addition to a Host's treatment team.

Patients admitted to Primary Care may be briefed on the different rescission approaches available (standard rescission, exposure rescission, and manual rescission), and the final decision will depend heavily on the severity of the Vice's classification. A Vice Management Administrator can further explain these services, but in short:

Standard rescission is the act of destroying the Vice core within the Branch Domain, most commonly utilizing patches. This is the gold standard of rescission.

Exposure rescission entails gradually eating away at the Vice core using a series of AV Shots. This method is often employed in conjunction with standard rescission.

Manual rescission is performed by manually separating the core from the Host's body, typically with the use of surgical tools. This method is experimental and highly risky and should only be pursued as a last resort.

Exploring Exhibitions

Only present in the Branch Domain, a Vice's exhibition shields the vulnerable core from the Host, Adjuncts and their patches. Exhibitions also influence blights, as many properties present in the exhibition are mirrored as blights, most commonly seen as horns, teeth or skin textures. Exhibitions are incredibly unique and vary greatly between Hosts, though experts have begun grouping them by size and attack strategy.

Within the Branch Domain, a Host and their Adjunct(s) are pitted against the Vice's exhibition, a creature-like visage that shields the Vice's core from attacks. When a Branch is in production, the most surefire way to address the Branch is to either damage or destroy the Vice's core, which entails sparring with the Vice's exhibition.

The exhibition houses the Vice's core, which is stored in the same place for every Branch. Hosts and Adjuncts can use hand-to-hand combat to damage the core, but, if established, their patches are much more efficient. Patches are created to be direct counters to a Host's exhibition; for example, if a Vice's exhibition has a thick hide, a piercing patch is likely to be established. Learn more about patches in *Vices & Our Bodies: AV and Patches*.

While exhibitions are not tangible, corporeal objects, they are essentially the manifestation of the VG-rich epithelium that surrounds the core. Damage incurred by a patch in the metaphysical realm often directly correlates with bursts of AV from the Host or Adjuncts in the corporeal realm. Cores are able to fend against attacks from AV, but repeated, strong attacks can be enough to greatly damage the epithelium and begin directly attacking the core. Depending on the degree of damage incurred by AV, the Branch will either be committed or rescinded. Learn more about these processes in *Branch Options*.

Thicker epithelia typically correlate with larger, stronger, or more adept exhibitions. The details of the exhibition, however, are influenced by different sources. Their design can be pulled from the circumstances of advent, but they are also likely to pull from a Host's innate fears, even those undiscovered. Because of this, exhibitions often prey on our innate fears of predators or common phobias such as snakes and spiders. Both of these sources can influence the exhibition's textures, body composition, and even smell.

Exhibitions are capable of resembling anything the mind can conjure, some branching out from the typical animal-adjacent creature to mimic grotesque amalgamations akin to monsters in horror movies. Some have even been documented as resembling well-known movie monsters, such as the xenomorph from *Alien* or even Moder from *The Ritual*. Exhibitions can be as small as an armadillo or tower over a house; though, size and complexity do have limits, typically capped by the core's epithelial properties. Epithelia do not always directly correlate with larger exhibitions, but thinner epithelia typically do not produce large or complex exhibitions. Some classifications prioritize complex and grand exhibitions, while others prefer to focus more on their plan of attack. While their exhibitions may not be intimidating in their design, they are often intimidating in their own way by adeptly using their environment or in their stalking-like behaviors.

Exhibitions do not have to be bipedal, nor do they even need to have legs at all. Exhibitions can have wings, tails, spines, multiple sets of eyes, multiple heads, and multiple sets of limbs. Exhibitions can mimic insects, aquatic animals, birds, and even extinct species or creatures from pop culture like kaiju or cryptids. The possibilities truly are endless.

Most exhibitions remain largely the same throughout a Vice's life cycle, only increasing in complexity as it matures. Because of this, a Vice's exhibition is part of its Branch Policy. Typically, Vices do not make drastic changes to their exhibitions between Branches, as it is an energy-intensive task to perform and a risk many are not willing to take; however, some classifications are known for reworking or obfuscating their exhibitions, namely Delta and Epsilon Vices, respectively. Learn more about the differing exhibition properties between classifications in *Classifying Vices*.

Exhibitions also influence blights, and characteristics observed in the Branch Domain can be seen mirrored in the Host, manifested through blights. For example, if a Vice's exhibition has horns, is covered in scales, and can spit acid, the Host is likely to have similar horns, patches of scales, and acidic saliva. Learn more about blights in *Vices & Our Bodies: Blights*.

Exhibition Properties

Branch Analysts have devised broad categories for documentation and preparatory purposes. These

categories largely influence treatment plans and can help agents and Hosts prepare plans of attack.

While the specific details of exhibitions vary widely even within the same classification, most exhibitions within a classification share the same high-level properties explored above. For example, an Alpha Vice is likely to have a meso-offensive exhibition, while a Zeta Vice is almost guaranteed to have a giga-defensive exhibition. Learn about these shared exhibition properties in *Classifying Vices*.

Size

While size is not necessarily indicative of threat level, larger exhibitions often require a larger treatment team. Size in this instance refers to height, not weight. Exhibition sizes are categorized using the following prefixes:

Micro-

Micro-exhibitions are at most two feet tall. Hosts can typically address these exhibitions alone.

Meso-

Meso-exhibitions are between two and five feet tall. Hosts will benefit from the help of at least one Adjunct, typically two.

Macro-

Macro-exhibitions are between five and eight feet tall. Hosts will benefit from the help of at least three Adjuncts.

Giga-

Giga-exhibitions are eight feet or taller. Hosts will likely need a large, specially-curated team of at least five Adjuncts.

Attack Strategy

This classification informs the types of patches needed for efficiently addressing the Branch, and helps agents better formulate their plans of attack. The core purpose of exhibitions is to trap a Host and their Adjuncts in the Branch Domain as the core pursues germination and augmentation. The method in which they are able to do so is indicated by these categories and is a facet of the Vice's Branch Policy.

Offensive

Many offensive exhibitions prioritize attack over defense, and are typically regarded as "glass canons". They hit hard, but they are likely unable to take a hit. An offensive exhibition's plan is to damage the Host and Adjuncts early so they are unable to fight back.

Many offensive exhibitions begin attacking at the very start of production, the moment the Host is admitted. Because of this, Hosts will benefit from Adjuncts queuing early in the staging process. Large patches with broad surface areas that can be utilized for both offensive and defensive strategies will work well against these exhibitions.

Defensive

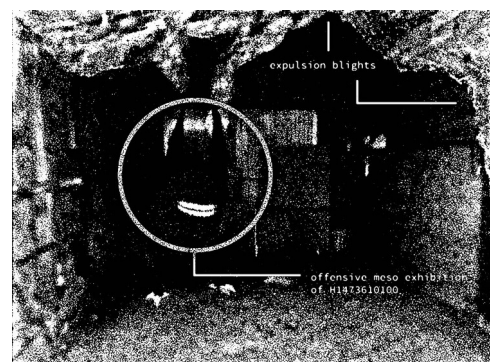
Defensive exhibitions typically do not focus on attacking extensions; rather, their aim is to put so much stock in their defense that the Host and Adjuncts are unable to make considerable progress in a timely manner, essentially trapping them in the Branch Domain as the Vice pursues germination and augmentation. Patches that can pierce and slash through their defensive outer layer will help to greatly reduce the time spent in the Branch Domain.

Hasty

These speedy exhibitions prioritize confusion and frustration with a "death by a thousand cuts" approach. While these exhibitions typically cannot hit hard, they hit often and avoid attacks with their elusive dodging. Some hasty exhibitions go so far as to even avoid combat altogether, hiding among detailed Branch Domains. Thrown or ranged patches work well to pin these elusive exhibitions down without having to close the gap and attack up close.

Balanced

Regarded as the "jack of all trades" classification, these exhibitions are actually the most dangerous, as they are able to switch plans of attack within an active Branch in reaction to the Host's strategy. If a Host and Adjuncts are on the offensive, it can prioritize defenses, and switch to a hasty or offensive approach after they have been worn down. Balanced exhibitions are often macro- or giga-exhibitions and typically require larger treatment teams with the added support of a Solutions Architect. Additionally, no single patch type will provide an advantage over balanced exhibitions; rather, a wide variety of patches from a varied team will aid in efficiently apprehending these exhibitions.



The Role of Adjuncts

While it is possible to address Branches alone, many Hosts benefit from the support that Adjuncts can offer. Adjuncts can increase the success rates, typically by strengthening defenses, increasing firepower, or even serving as a distraction. Adjuncts can be classified as primary, secondary, or tertiary.

Primary and secondary Adjuncts are queued during staging via physical touch, while tertiary Adjuncts are brought in during staging by a Vice extending its tracks to include those in the staging radius. Adjuncts are admitted to the Branch Domain after the Host has entered, typically based on the point in time they joined the queue during staging. For example, those who joined the queue shortly after staging begun will be admitted to the Branch Domain shortly after the Host and quit a bit before those who joined toward the end of staging. Learn more about the staging phase of a Branch in *Branch Phases* or learn more about *The Admission Process* below.

Primary and secondary Adjuncts must maintain contact with the Host during both staging and production. Due to their lack of contact, tertiary Adjuncts are often self-dismissed from Branches. During an active Branch, Adjuncts contribute to the Branch in both the corporeal realm and the metaphysical realm. In the corporeal realm, Adjuncts maintain physical contact with the Host and transmit a steady supply of AV to the Host to bolster their internal AV levels. In the metaphysical realm, Adjuncts spar against the Vice's exhibition and work to damage or destroy its core. As of now, our current understanding is that the events in both these realms mirror the other, so if an Adjunct increases their AV output in the corporeal realm, their patch may hit harder in the metaphysical realm.



Adjunct Tiers

Adjuncts can have effects on active Branches in multiple ways, and their proximity to the Host can affect their impact and abilities within the Branch Domain. Secondary and primary Adjuncts have similar admission procedures, and their distinction is typically more semantic and used to distinguish relationships in a CVRS patient's chart, though there are some minor physiological differences between the tiers.

Tertiary Adjunct (t!Adjunct)

Tertiary Adjuncts are a relatively rare phenomenon, typically unassuming strangers brought into Branches by a Vice to throw off the Host and increase energy consumption if a Vice is confident in reaching dispersion. Without anthropomorphizing these creatures, many consider tertiary Adjuncts as “hostages”, wherein they use these people to distract the Host or raise the stakes. This theory is likely held because tertiary Adjuncts often tend to be young children or those who cannot fend for themselves. Vices seem to target children in these instances, as they are more susceptible to being admitted and not being able to self-dismiss from Branches as easily as adults can.

As stated, tertiary Adjuncts are not common. These Adjuncts are typically only associated with specific Vice classifications, such as Theta Vices, or intelligent, calculating Vices, as the act of queuing and maintaining a connection with tertiary Adjuncts is quite energy-intensive.

In order to admit a tertiary Adjunct to the queue, the Vice extends its external tracks--called stolons--to latch on to those within the staging radius. This connection is weak during staging and can be easily lost, so Vices tend to employ this tactic moments before production. After these Adjuncts are admitted to the Branch Domain, their connection is somewhat solidified, though still relatively easy to break free from, which often occurs before the Branch is addressed. Tertiary Adjuncts cannot summon patches in the Branch Domain due to this weak connection and their distance from the Host. A Vice is also capable of easily dismissing a tertiary Adjunct if they become too much of a threat.

Secondary Adjunct (s!Adjunct)

Secondary Adjuncts are the most common, spanning anywhere from someone who is attending a Host's Branch for the first time to people who have been admitted to many. These Adjuncts are intentionally brought into Branches via physical touch while the Branch is being staged. Secondary Adjuncts are capable of summoning patches and are less likely to be dismissed than tertiary Adjuncts, though it is still possible for those who are less experienced. The more often a secondary Adjunct is brought in to aid in addressing Branches, the stronger the connection becomes, and the less likely they are to be dismissed.

Secondary Adjuncts are often used in CVRS care services, with the majority of agents that are brought in to aid in addressing Branches being secondary Adjuncts. Their ability to address Branches is no different than primary Adjuncts, and Branches can be committed or even rescinded by secondary Adjuncts.

Though the number varies between Hosts, after a secondary Adjunct has made several contributions to the success of Branches, be it analyzing the Branch Policy or facilitating commits, they are reclassified as a primary Adjunct. The number of Branches an Adjunct has been admitted to does not determine their classification; rather, their connection to the Host and situational awareness within the Branch Domain sets these Adjuncts apart. Generally, secondary Adjuncts have a less established connection--often emotional--with the Host. This can result in greater disorientation or increased difficulty in gaining their footing in a Host's Branch Domain. While the distinction between the two tiers cannot be measured, it can certainly be felt by both the Adjunct and the Host.

Primary Adjunct (p!Adjunct)

Primary Adjuncts have regularly aided in committing Branches for a Host and have a firm grasp of its Branch Policy. Because of this, primary Adjuncts are less common, but they are invaluable during Branches and rescission, especially. Many Vice Management Administrators quickly become a primary Adjunct for their patients after thorough analysis of their Branch Policy.

Due to their stronger connection, Primary Adjuncts are more difficult to dismiss, receive a boost to their patch's efficacy, and have a higher success rate when forcing entry with a Bypass. Trust and confidence are integral in setting primary Adjuncts apart and play a

large role in bolstering their connection to the Host during Branches. Because of this bond, primary Adjuncts are often able to perform fringe actions with the Host, such as merging patches, forcing entry, and even summoning reformed Vices in the Branch Domain more easily. AV also flows more freely between a Host and their primary Adjunct, resulting in a higher level of AV being accepted.

This tier is often reserved for those who have a personal relationship with the Host. Partners, close friends, family members, and even trusted CVRS agents are typically the ones awarded this distinction. Those who remain secondary Adjuncts, however, should not be offended, as this distinction has no implications about an Adjunct's ability to perform their duties.

Pseudo Adjunct

While not common in everyday Branches, CVRS utilizes pseudo Adjuncts to observe Branches from a distance and document Vice behavior and Branch properties. Solutions Architects in particular are brought in to detect weaknesses in a Vice's exhibition and pick up on patterns in early Branches, relaying this information to Vice Management Administrators and Branch Administrators.

These agents are able to join Branches via proximity, using a modified Bypass with a lower electrical charge. This lower charge and their lack of contact with the Host result in a fairly weak but nearly undetectable presence in the Branch Domain. Most Vices do not notice a pseudo Adjunct's presence in the Branch Domain as their visage is often nearly transparent and amorphous. Agents do not have a direct impact on the Branch and are only able to communicate with the primary and secondary Adjuncts or external agents using a MobiComm.

As opposed to Adjuncts on the ground, pseudo Adjuncts are able to manipulate their location to freely choose their viewpoint. This allows Solutions Architects and Research agents the ability to view the Branch from multiple vantage points and observe the details that those on the ground may not be able to see. Because of their weak connection, pseudo Adjuncts typically see the Branch Domain as more of an overlay that transposes the happenings of the two realms. They often remark that the metaphysical realm seems to happen in real time, while the corporeal realm happens in slow motion. Branch Analysts have made great strides in Branch research using this

technique, as they are able to observe both realms simultaneously and log happenings to help document the time differences between these realms.

After an extended period, a pseudo Adjunct's connection can become disorienting, and an agent make take a temporary break to ground themselves by self-dismissing. They can easily be re-admitted to the Branch as a pseudo Adjunct by using the same admission method of forcing entry with a Bypass. Vices who do manage to notice pseudo Adjuncts dismiss them by retracting or severing the tract that connects them.

The Admission Process

The process of admitting primary and secondary Adjuncts to a Branch is not unlike a queue, where making contact with the Host is similar to reserving one's space in line. Adjuncts are admitted to the Branch Domain in the same order they were added to the queue during staging, with a 1:4 ratio for wait times. That is to say, if an Adjunct joined the queue 15 seconds into staging, they would be admitted roughly a minute after the Host is admitted to the Branch Domain.

If contact is interrupted, the Adjunct is sent to the back of the queue and must re-reserve their space in line. If the Branch is somehow committed or rescinded while an Adjunct is in the queue, they are simply dismissed from the Branch. Adjuncts can be admitted simultaneously if contact was made at the same time, though primary Adjuncts tend to be given priority and may arrive a split second sooner.

If an unpredictable Branch has been initiated and all Adjuncts do not have time to make contact with the Host, making contact with each other will suffice, so long as at least one Adjunct is in contact with the Host. Doing so creates an exponentially staggered queuing effect of bringing in Adjuncts, where Adjuncts that are two or three times removed from the Host can take up to an hour of in-Branch time to be brought in.

The key to Branch admission lies in making direct physical contact with the Host. At Branch initiation, the tightly-packed, neutrally-charged VN making up the tracks of a Vice's network are electrified, temporarily exuding a positive charge. This compromises the track structure as the molecules repel each other and allows the VG previously stored in the tracks to leech into the Host's bloodstream. If a person makes contact during this time, the human body acts

as a conductor and expands the positively-charged electromagnetic field to include them. Breaking contact removes the flow of electricity and dismisses the Adjunct from the queue during staging, or from the Branch Domain during production.

The Benefits of Employing Adjuncts

The chart below shows how the number of secondary Adjuncts present in the Branch Domain increases the chances of success. The higher the threat level, the more Adjuncts required for higher rates of success. This increased rate of success extends to both committing and rescinding Branches.

		Number of Secondary Adjuncts				
		1	2	3	4	5+
Threat Level	Low	+42%	+56%	+63%	+67.2%	+70%
	Medium	+21%	+28%	+31.5%	+33.6%	+35%
	High	+14%	+18.66%	+21%	+22.4%	+23.33%
	Critical	+10.5%	+14%	+15.75%	+16.8%	+17.5%

Increased rates of a successful commit for varying numbers of s!Adjuncts included in a Branch

Primary Adjuncts tend to affect the above percentages, typically adding a buff of 1.3x. For example, if you have a Vice with a low threat level and one p!Adjunct, your chances of success increase by 54.6% instead of 42%. Likewise, if you have a Vice with a high threat level and two Adjuncts, one primary, the other secondary, your chances of success increase by 22.86% instead of 18.66%.

Fringe Branch Events

While Branches of all kinds share the same three phases, there are some situations that can disrupt the expected flow.

Adjunct Dismissal

Vices with a higher threat level or those that are more mature are sometimes able to dismiss an Adjunct from an active Branch. Dismissal removes the Adjunct from the Branch Domain and cuts off the electrical flow between the Adjunct and the Host. Dismissed Adjuncts are capable of forcing re-entry using a Bypass, but the chances of a successful entry are much lower than if an Adjunct was attempting to join a Branch for the first time.

This process is only performed if the Vice views the Adjunct as a threat that would either be capable of performing rescission or preventing the Vice from completing dispersion.

All Adjuncts can be dismissed, though the dismissal of primary Adjuncts is highly unlikely. Both tertiary and pseudo Adjuncts are easily expelled without much effort, if any, and secondary Adjuncts typically take a bit more effort due to their physical contact. Hosts are incapable of being dismissed from their own Branch.

The act of dismissal differs slightly between Adjunct tiers. Pseudo and tertiary Adjuncts are dismissed by the Vice retracting the tract that the Adjunct is connected to. Secondary Adjuncts can be dismissed similarly, though often due to their contact with the Host, the mere retraction may not be successful. For this reason, they may fully sever a tract in order to cut off the electrical flow, thereby dismissing the Adjunct. Primary Adjuncts, however, require a much more devious and energy-intensive tactic. Because retracting and even severing tracts are likely to be unsuccessful, some are able to deploy jolts of electricity that cause the Host to spasm, not unlike a hypnic jerk. This spasm can briefly cause the Adjunct to lose contact with the Host, thereby dismissing them from the Branch.

Branch Instigation

While Branches are typically initiated by the Vice as an attempt to expand their core or network, Branches can also be initiated by a Host or Adjuncts with the intent to commit or rescind the Vice. Branches are typically instigated by our Floor Managers in Urgent

Care when performing Branch remediation, which entails instigating a recently-suspended Branch so it can be properly committed. Vice Management Administrators in Primary Care also instigate Branches to collect observations throughout treatment or to catch a Vice off guard before pursuing rescission.

As a CVRS patient, instigation will be performed in the observation chambers, where a concentrated, positively-charged electrostatic shock is deployed and directed toward any stray tracks in the Vice's network. This triggers the VN to become positively-charged, resulting in an initiated Branch. Outside of the observation chambers, a Bypass can also be used to instigate a Branch in an emergency, and is often the instigation method of choice for Floor Managers. Some agents will instead attempt to bait Vices into initiating their own Branch to avoid some of the side effects associated with Branch instigation.

Instigation is generally regarded as a risky endeavor and should only be performed by trained CVRS agents. Instigated Branches typically have a shorter staging time, so any desired Adjuncts should be nearby and prepared before pursuing instigation. Patches should also be summoned in advance so they are in hand once the Branch moves into production, as many exhibitions tend to be enraged at the beginning of production. While a Vice Management Administrator may instigate Branches often throughout a patient's treatment, they are trained to do so with enough time in between so as to not prompt rogue Branches or permanent changes in the Branch Policy. This required "cool down" time between Branches varies between classifications and even between individual Vices.

Forcing Entry

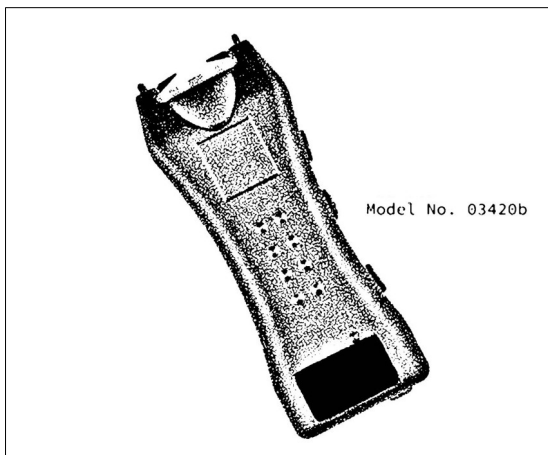
Adjuncts are able to force their way into an active Branch Domain by using a Bypass, a taser-like device issued to CVRS agents. A Bypass produces an electric charge that is drawn to any stray or easily-accessible tracks in the Host's network. This temporarily provides a "bridge" of contact for the user to bypass the queuing process and enter the Branch Domain as if contact had been made during staging. Bypasses have an admission rate of roughly 72% and result in the immediate admission to the Branch Domain, bypassing the staging queue.

Weak and newly-established tracks account for a large portion of the 28% of failed admissions, as the Bypass

overloads and destroys the track. For this reason, Parsing Goggles are often used to scout for more established tracks. Intelligent Vices are sometimes able to parry this connection by intentionally “blocking” the route of electricity with a young track, resulting in its destruction and a failed admission, though this is incredibly rare. Bypasses require a period of recharge after use, so multiple attempts cannot be made in quick succession.

During staging, VN—which are neutrally-charged by default—become positively charged and begin repelling each other, allowing any stored VG to infiltrate the Host’s bloodstream. Bypasses take advantage of these now-vulnerable tracks by emitting a bolt of electricity the same intensity and charge, essentially serving the same purpose as a Vice’s extended stolon to admit tertiary Adjuncts. Learn more about the admission process in *The Role of Adjuncts*.

Upon entry, the agent’s extension is weak, and contact must promptly be made with the Host in the corporeal realm in order to strengthen the connection and efficiently contribute to the Branch. If used too often or incorrectly, forcing oneself into a Branch can become painful for the agent, Host or any Adjuncts involved. If used outside of an active Branch, Bypasses have been known to instigate Branches, though sometimes this is done intentionally when standard instigation technology is unavailable.



Pseudo Adjuncts use modified Bypasses to admit themselves to an active Branch, providing a unique vantage point and a near-undetectable presence in the Branch Domain. The electrical charge emitted by the

modified Bypass is considerably lower, creating a weak connection, similar in intensity to the connection of a tertiary Adjunct. Pseudo Adjuncts do not need to make or maintain contact with the Host in order to remain an Adjunct; rather, the modified Bypass continues to emit the electrostatic charge, maintaining contact en lieu of physical contact.

If an Adjunct has been dismissed from a Branch, they may be able to use a Bypass to force re-entry to the active Branch, though the chances of success are considerably lower, closer to 15%. Primary Adjuncts, due to their stronger connection to the Host, have a slightly higher chance of success, still at only 21%. Pseudo Adjuncts are unique in that re-establishing their connection is effortless, due in large part to their weak connection.

While forcing entry can be the difference between life or death, it must only be performed after careful consideration. Side effects of using a Bypass include mild electrostatic shock, headaches, tinnitus, and lockjaw, and run the risk of inducing seizures if used too often or incorrectly.

Reformation

The relationship between a Host and their Vice is generally considered parasitic, posing no benefit to the Host, but after performing reformation, a Host is able to utilize their Vice’s strength in the Branch Domain. The benefits of reformation can only be reaped during an active Branch within the Branch Domain.

The act of reformation entails the Host’s extension consuming the Vice core during production. For reasons still being researched, doing so prompts half of the AV stored in the Host’s body to alter its genetic makeup. This change results in a solvent-like fluid that envelopes the Vice core. As the Host’s extension consumes the core in Branch Domain, the majority of the core is dissolved in the corporeal realm, leaving behind only its genetic material suspended in the liquid.

This liquid is dispersed throughout the Host’s body and avoids setting off the immune system due to its predominant makeup of native AV. After a period of roughly 24 hours, the Host can reap the benefits of a successful reformation. This rest period gives the core time to circulate, creating a rudimentary “network” between small deposits across the Host’s body. This fluid remains in the system anywhere from as little as

6 months to as long as 10 years, depending on maturity and core size and density.

Hosts are not considered cleared if this process has occurred, as the majority of the Vice core is still present in the Host's body and even poses the threat of congealing and reestablishing its form, though this tends to be quite rare. Learn more about the liminal status in *Host Statuses*.

Factors of Success

The act of reformation is rather difficult to see through to completion, as it requires a level of precision and skill in handling an exhibition. While all Vices can be reformed, adolescent Vices most commonly result in success due to their smaller, compact cores.

In order to properly reform a Vice, the Host must:

- incapacitate the exhibition without damaging the core
- take a large enough bite out of the core to prevent it from terminating the Branch, and
- consume the core in its entirety

Vices terminate Branches when their core has been damaged, which makes incapacitating the exhibition so the core can be accessed the first hurdle. If the Vice core sustains enough damage in the incapacitation process, the Branch will be committed before reformation can occur. Larval Vices are not commonly reformed, as their fragility leads to prematurely-terminated Branches, and damage is often easily inflicted when incapacitating the exhibition. Additionally, reforming a larval Vice will pose few benefits to the Host, as the reformed core is likely to circulate their system for an extremely short amount of time.

If the exhibition is successfully incapacitated, the second hurdle is consuming enough of the core in a single bite that the Vice doesn't have enough energy left to terminate the Branch. Too small of a bite can simply damage the core and render the Branch committed. Though, if these two requirements are met, the Host can consume the core in its entirety.

Benefits

After a successful reformation, the Host will now be able to initiate a transformation within another Host's Branch Domain, much in the same way a patch is summoned. Because exhibitions exist solely in the Branch Domain, a reformed Vice cannot be summoned in the corporeal realm. This transformation

is applied exclusively to the Host's extension, altering it to mimic that of their reformed Vice's exhibition.

A complete transformation takes roughly five minutes of in-Branch time and can be paused at different stages. This transformation depletes a not-insignificant amount of the Vice core in the Host's body, so some Hosts intentionally pause the transformation during an intermediate stage to reap the benefits, but prolong the amount of time these benefits are available to them.

This transformation, if brought to completion, results in a direct one-to-one copy of the Vice's exhibition, retaining its size, strength, speed, and defense. Because these features are merely enhancements to the Host's extension and are predominantly comprised of AV, when physically interacting with an exhibition in the Branch Domain, manual combat can be just as effective as wielding a patch.

The act of triggering the reformation process is not dissimilar to summoning a patch in the Branch Domain. As such, this process requires concentration and practice, but some are able to achieve reformation on their first try. Familiarity with the Vice's exhibition seems to be the common denominator between Hosts who are able to easily trigger reformation. Additionally, it is not uncommon for Hosts to struggle with pausing reformation at different stages, and many unintentionally pursue reformation to completion the first few attempts.

Risks

Reformation, while touting promising benefits, is an unreliable and imprecise process that poses the risk of being reversed without the Host's knowledge. Over time, the suspended genetic material can leech out of the mixture, and if enough of this material is freed simultaneously, it can congeal and begin the act of colonizing tissues. With enough time, this mass can become the Vice core once again, and threatens rogue Branches, often establishing a new and unfamiliar Branch Policy.

Reformation does not destroy the Vice's network, though it does begin to deteriorate over time. If the core is able to re-congeal and attach itself to its prior network, it can pursue exponential growth and re-establish itself in to time at all. Additionally, because the network has lost contact with the core, it begins steadily leaking the remaining VG and hormones out into the Host's bloodstream. Due to the VG now circulating freely in the Host's body, Hosts are much

more susceptible to agitated, chronic blights, especially shortly after reformation has occurred.

In some cases, Hosts who intend to reform their Vice fail to do so properly and subject themselves to longer Branch times, actually allowing the Vice core to spread further than it would if the Branch had been properly committed or rescinded in a timely manner.

Anecdotal evidence also reports that Hosts with reformed Vices can be uncharacteristically impulsive, aggressive and over-eager. While the act of reformation is regarded as a noble endeavor to help fellow Hosts, the process should be avoided until further research is conducted.

Rogue Branches

When Vices deviate from an established Branch Policy and initiate Branches unexpectedly, these are referred to as "rogue" Branches, observed primarily in aggressive adolescent Vices and those with a medium or high threat level. Rogue Branches are typically initiated when a Vice is agitated, threatened or compromised. For example, AV Shots are generally considered threatening, as they inhibit growth and attack the Vice's core.

Hosts who progress to the berserk phase during an active Branch are at risk of experiencing rogue Branches after the current Branch has been addressed, especially if the Host is infected with an adolescent Vice. Mature and larval Vices are less likely to partake in this behavior, though it cannot be fully ruled out as a possibility.

Rogue Branches can also be influenced by drastic changes in the natural environment, such as fluctuating electromagnetic fields or gas leaks, though this is far less common. Dense concentrations of VG, either from a detached rumen or recent dispersion, also tend to excite or agitate Vices and result in rogue Branches, most commonly observed in those with a lower threat level.

Initiating rogue Branches is a particularly risky move for the Vice, as deviating from the established Branch Policy introduces unknown factors that can potentially skew the Branch in Host's favor. Despite this risk, most Vices regardless of classification will attempt at least one rogue Branch in their life cycle, likely in the adolescent stage.

While most Hosts are sedated during staging, about 15% have the opposite reaction and become agitated and volatile. This percentage increases to 25% if the Host is experiencing a rogue Branch.

While this deviation from Branch Policy makes them particularly hard to prepare for, rogue Branches are not completely undetectable. If a Vice foregoes initiating a Branch during a situation that would otherwise align with its Branch Policy, it is likely reserving energy in preparation for its rogue attack. Rogue Branches also often follow periods of inexplicable or uncharacteristic fatigue, the result of its increased feeding and stockpiling for the upcoming rogue Branch. Not all periods of fatigue precede a rogue Branch, but any changes in mood, appetite, or energy levels should be monitored or reported to your Vice Management Administrator.

Vices & Our Bodies

Learn about blights, patches and Host phases, and how our body communicates with us when infected with a Vice.

Host statuses give caregivers an idea of Vice activity and can inform treatment plans. Blights also play a role in signaling a Vice's intentions and can warn Hosts of an advancing Vice. As a form of defense, many Hosts are able to summon large concentrations of AV, called a patch, that can be used to defend oneself or protect others. Establishing a patch is often the body's way of warning the Host of sudden, drastic changes in a Vice's makeup.

Infection Criteria

Vices can be contracted at any age, though most people contract their first Vice between the ages of 15 and 25. Hosts as young as 4 and as old as 93 have been documented as contracting a Vice. While age does not necessarily impact classification, some classifications are less likely to be found in younger Hosts, such as Lambda Vices.

The criteria for contracting a Vice cannot be simplified into an easily-digestible list. Any and all people are technically capable of contracting a Vice, though some have an increased risk. Those with weaker immune systems and people who have experienced recent or repeated trauma are at higher risk.

People are also able to contract multiple Vices throughout their life, having an increased risk if any of their previous Vices had a sudden advent or the Phi classification. Due to the complexity of Vices with a gradual advent, it is believed that the Host's body has adapted to use a more well-rounded defense strategy and is better equipped to detect the vague physiological factors that result in a gradual advent.

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Hosts have a variety of statuses that communicate urgency and drive treatment plans. While a Host is infected, they can further be categorized by the degree that the Vice has spread within their body.

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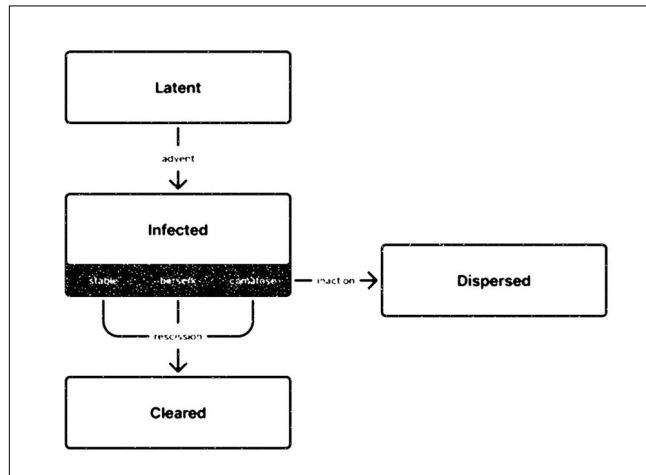
In the same way the immune system might prompt a rash when battling a virus, blights are the body's response to being infected with a Vice. Blights are influenced by the Vice's exhibition and can be a valuable insight into changes in Vice activity.

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As Vices have evolved, so, too, have our bodies. Our bodies learned to produce and release a counter-molecule called antivitumglomerorum (AV) in direct response to the growing complexity of Vices.

Host Statuses

Hosts have a variety of statuses that communicate urgency and drive treatment plans. While a Host is infected, they can further be categorized by the degree that the Vice has spread within their body.



Latent

This status is referred to primarily in retrospect, when agents are studying or discussing advent properties and the experiences that may influence a Vice's Branch Policy. A Host's physiological, biological, and even psychological status during latency can provide valuable information to CVRS agents and can even aid in classification. For example, Zeta Vices are often birthed after periods of extreme depression, while Delta Vices tend to manifest after drastic life changes.

Infected

A Host is officially infected once a Vice has been successfully detected with a Vitiumglomerorum Detection Scan (VGDS), the diagnostic screening performed by a Record Proctor following a brief screening questionnaire. This rudimentary scan detects dense concentrations of VG in the Host's body using a VG Meter; a localized reading of 4.0 or higher indicates the presence of a Vice core.

After advent, the Vice's core size and growth progress can be monitored with regular Vitiumglomerorum Management Scans (VGMS) ordered by a Vice Management Administrator and performed by a Record Proctor. These scans produce low-resolution black and white images much like an ultrasound and

determine the size and density of the Vice core. Classification can now occur based on the information gathered at advent and its behavior between the initial Branches; however, classification is not guaranteed and largely hinges on the Vice's behavior in its early life. Most Vices are classified within 6 months of advent.

Shortly after advent, the Host's body begins producing antivitiunglomerorum (AV) as a direct response to the invasive parasite. Over time, an infected Host's body will learn to control and concentrate the flow of AV, which can result in establishing a patch. Learn more about this process in *AV & Patches*.

While a Host is infected, they fall into one of three categories: stable, berserk, or comatose, with a fourth "liminal" status reserved for Hosts with reformed Vices. These substatuses are determined by the Vice's behavior and how the Host's body is reacting to it, as outlined below.

Stable

While a Host is infected, they will spend the majority of their time in this phase. Being stable does not imply the Host is asymptomatic or not at risk; rather, it means that both the Host and the Vice are behaving "in character". Blights are not agitated and the Vice core is not growing at an alarming or unnatural rate.

Hosts experiencing Branches are still considered stable, so long as the Vice is not performing excessive augmentation or germination. A stable Host's immune system is on standby, monitoring the Vice core activity.

Stable Hosts do not typically exhibit blights, though Hosts with mature Vices will sometimes display consistent, mild blights such as sharpened incisors or small, nubby horns, known as chronic blights. These blights are caused by concentrations of VG rather than exacerbated Vice activity. Acute blights are typically only observed during Branches, and are expected to resolve after the Branch has been addressed.

Berserk

A Host becomes berserk when the Vice pursues considerable core growth—a process known as augmentation—during a the production stage of a Branch. While Vices can augment their core outside of Branches, it is performed at a near-imperceptible pace that does not alert the Host's immune system. The growth that results in a berserk Host is sudden and

brazen, some Vices being able to double their core size during Branches.

During augmentation, the Host's immune system is deploying its natural defenses against threats, which includes flooding the body with hormones like adrenaline and cortisol. As discussed in AV and Patches, our bodies have adapted to release AV alongside hormones as a defense mechanism against a Vice's network deploying its tracks to ensnare the passing hormones. Because the body is being overrun with VG during this time—and because VG and AV cancel each other out—the AV is eventually overwhelmed by the sheer number of VG released from the Vice's tracks. This steady supply of hormones fuels the Vice's core growth for the remainder of the Branch.

Due to the increase in VG throughout the body, blights are visibly agitated in this phase. Extrusion blights grow in size, drape blights expand in surface area, and expulsion blights increase their output. Berserk Hosts will have different reactions depending on their relation to the Branch Domain. Inside the Branch Domain, berserk Hosts can become erratic, impulsive, and even hostile. Outside of the Branch Domain, a Host's muscles will be taut and their jaws are likely to be clenched, often resulting in small tremors that can manifest as hypnic jerks, which risk Adjuncts breaking contact with the Host. Berserk Hosts with weaker immune systems are also at risk of excessive sweating, uncontrollable coughing, emesis, and even seizures, even further increasing the risk of losing their Adjuncts.

If possible, it is highly recommended to pursue rescission if a Host is berserk. Committing a Branch will stabilize the Host, but there will be less time between Branches compared to committing Branches when a Host is stable. For example, if a Vice typically has two to three weeks of down time between committed Branches, committing a Branch while the Host is berserk will likely result in only a week of down time. Suspending the Branches of a berserk Host is likely to do more harm than good and should only be performed as a last resort. If a Branch goes unaddressed, a Host will become comatose as the Vice begins to initiate fusion.

Comatose

A Host becomes comatose once the Vice core has begun the process of fusing its recently expanded core with the Host's body. Fusion is the process of the Vice

core infiltrating organs and viscera and intertwining its makeup with these structures. As the contents of the Vice core mix with the viscera, this mixture becomes extremely rigid and solidifies, essentially killing the tissues it has fused with. Learn more about fusion in *Vice Biology: Reactivity and Defense Mechanisms*.

During this time, the Host's body is shutting down and losing motor control. Because the core is often fused with hormone-secreting organs, such as the pituitary gland or brain stem, the overproduction of hormones is triggered even further, fueling the Vice's continued expansion and fusion. Comatose Hosts exhibit the same physiological symptoms as berserk Hosts, though they do tend to be exacerbated. Because of the unrestrained release of hormones, Hosts can also develop severe acute reactions, such as serotonin syndrome or thyrotoxicosis.

Due to the increase in VG throughout the Host's body, Blights are extremely agitated and out of control, potentially causing harm to those around them. Within the Branch Domain, Hosts may find it difficult to think clearly and make rational decisions. Some even feel like they have less control of their body and find it twice as difficult to move in the ways they intend to. Adjuncts are imperative to success in this phase.

While the core is fused with the Host's body, doing so has stretched it extremely thin, making the core vulnerable in both the corporeal and metaphysical realms. Due to this vulnerable state, rescission is still achievable, even if a Host is comatose. If a Host is able to rescind their Vice during this phase, the Host will be cleared but will likely suffer extreme lingering blights and can even develop autoimmune disorders, damaged joints and chronic pain. In extreme cases, amputations or organ transplants may be needed. AV Shots may buy the Host time, but are ultimately futile at this phase, as the VG coursing throughout the Host's body almost immediately defuses the burst of AV.

If a Host is unsuccessful at rescission, the Vice will complete the fusion process and begin the act of dispersion.

Liminal

In the rare instance of reformation, a Host can still be infected, but at a much lower risk of dispersion and Branch initiation. The components of a Vice are still present throughout a liminal Host's bloodstream, but the core and its network are in a scattered,

disconnected state. Vices that have been reformed cannot feed on hormones or initiate Branches, but they do have the very low probability of congealing and re-establishing the core. Hosts with reformed Vices are able to use their power to bolster their extension in the Branch Domain by taking on the form of its exhibition. Learn more about the process of Vice reformation in *The Branch Phenomenon: Fringe Branch Events*.

Reformed Vice cores are immediately dissolved in a fluid and scattered throughout the body, while the Vice's network stays relatively intact, but cannot function as intended. While the general layout of the Vice's network remains unchanged, it cannot transport VG or hormones. Because it has lost contact with the core, the network begins steadily leaking the remaining VG and hormones out into the Host's bloodstream.

Due to the VG now circulating freely in the Host's body, Hosts are much more susceptible to agitated, chronic blights. While annoying, these typically pose only minor threats, depending on the original severity of blights. AV Shots can be administered for blight management, but also lessens the time a Host is able to wield their reformed Vice. Liminal Hosts have reported being more sensitive and reactive during this time, generally attributed to the supplementary hormones leaching into the bloodstream.

Reformed Vices typically cycle through the Host's bloodstream for roughly a year. The Host's steady deployment of AV eats away at the scattered remains of the Vice core, but summoning the Vice's exhibition in the Branch Domain can deplete the core by up to 50%. As the percentage of the core decreases, the severity of chronic blights decreases as well.

Rescission is the act of destroying a Vice core, so once the last bit of the core is passively destroyed by the body's AV or it is used to bolster the Host's extension in the Branch Domain, the Vice is officially rescinded. This process is not dissimilar to exposure rescission. Even if a liminal Host has stopped having blights, it is recommended that they visit a Vice Management Administrator to confirm rescission.

Cleared

A cleared Host is the result of a successful rescission, which is only achieved once the Vice core is destroyed. Rescission can be achieved in multiple

ways, which can be discussed with your Vice Management Administrator.

More mature Vices tend to leave trace amounts of its network behind after rescission. Similar to the experience of liminal Hosts, these lingering fragments can result in chronic blights, though they are often much less severe, as the remaining network of a rescinded Vice tends to be relatively incomplete. A Vice Management Administrator or Blight Specialist can help with lingering blights and facilitate post-rescission treatment, if needed.

Cleared Hosts become more susceptible to contracting another Vice as time progresses. Experts posit that cleared Hosts have a higher tolerance to VG and consequently require a higher concentration of it to spark another advent, but over time, this tolerance is likely to lower.

Content Warning

The passages below contain information that may be uncomfortable for some readers. The act of dispersion entails the mutilation of the human body, which is discussed below. Proceed with caution or skip to the next section (*pg: 90*).

Dispersed

This status is applied to Hosts postmortem, as the process of dispersion kills the Host. Dispersion is the result of an unaddressed Branch, where a Vice was able to expand its core throughout a comatose Host's body and perform the act of fusion, wherein its entangled core hardens and clings onto the organs and viscera around it.

In the blink of an eye, the Host's body is sucked in on itself and absorbed into the Vice's core. It quickly recedes into a dense ball of flesh, no more than two inches, then explodes in a violent burst that sends a wave of VG in every direction.

Hosts who have been dispersed are unable to be reclaimed, even in small amounts, as the act of retracting the Host's body into the core liquefies its contents to be utilized as fuel for the explosive dispersion of VG. Learn more about this process in *Vice Reproduction: Dispersion*.

Blights

In the same way the immune system might prompt a rash when battling a virus, blights are the body's response to being infected with a Vice. Blights are influenced by the Vice's exhibition and can be a valuable insight into changes in Vice activity.

Simply speaking, blights are the side effect of being infected with a Vice. Different kinds of blights are triggered by different parameters, and by extension, communicate different information. Understanding these differences can provide valuable insight into a Vice's activity or status, especially if a patient is self-treating.

Blights tend to mimic the Vice's exhibition. For example, if a Vice's exhibition is covered in scales and exudes electricity, the Host is likely to have a couple patches of scales on their arms or face and lightly shock others when touching. If the Host progresses to a more severe status or the Vice is more mature, the Host might have their entire upper body covered in scales and have uncontrollable bouts of electric pulses.

When discussing the impact of blights, it is important to also include the duration of the condition, as acute and chronic blights signal different Vice behavior to a Blight Specialist or Vice Management Administrator. Acute blights are sudden, drastic changes in size, number or surface area, including the onset of new blights. Chronic blights tend to be less severe, and refer to those that have remained visible for over 6 months, despite fluctuations in Vice activity. Acute blights indicate a sudden change in Vice behavior, such as Branch initiation or a reroute in resources, while chronic blights suggest a mature Vice has a well-established network.

Types of Blights

Blights can be split into four categories: expulsion, drape, extrusion, and pseudo. These categories give insight to the Vice's activity and status, which guides Vice Management Administrators and Blight Specialists in making treatment decisions.

Expulsion Blights

As the name suggests, expulsion blights originate from the Vice core and are expelled by the Host through the mouth, nose, ears, or pores. A Host typically only has one kind of expulsion blight for the entirety of a Vice's life cycle. Expulsion blights are the only type visible

during the larval stage, and are consequently the first blight that manifests as a result of Vice activity.

Because of their proximity to the core, expulsion blights exhibit drastic increases in output in response to any changes from the core. These changes include augmentation, Branch initiation, and even a redirection of resources—in either direction—between the core and an established rumen. Additionally, expulsion blights caused by a Delta Vice can signal the act of shedding, wherein the Vice pinches off a facet of its core containing part of its Branch Policy.

Examples of expulsion blights include smoke, static, and acid. Those that mimic dangerous or harmful substances do not harm the Host, but can harm others on contact. Not all Vices trigger expulsion blights, making this type more uncommon compared to other blights. Due to their prioritization of augmentation, expulsion blights are more commonly associated with aggressive Vices of a lower threat level. Expulsion blights are almost always acute and communicate sudden changes in core activity.

Drape Blights

Drape blights lay close to the skin, rarely straying far from the Host's body. These blights begin, and often stay, in localized patches across the skin and are sometimes considered a sort of "heat map" of the Vice's network. Collections of tracks found in junctions like shoulders and knees tend to contain dense concentrations of VG, triggering the production of these drape blights. In severe cases, they have been known to nearly cover a Host's entire body.

When agitated, drape blights are itchy, prompting many to pick at these patches. These blights can be removed from the skin, but often leave behind welts and lesions that can easily become infected if not properly cared for.

Examples most commonly include fur, scales, and feathers; though, some Hosts have noted unconventional presentation of these features, such as velvety scales or leathery patches lined with fur. Drape blights are more often observed in Vices with a higher threat level, likely due to the Vice's established network. Agitated drape blights suggests germination progress and tend to be chronic as a result of the ever-present network.

Extrusion Blights

Extrusion blights are unnatural extensions of a Host's body, typically originating and extruding from existing bone or deep within tissues. Extrusion blights from bone are stationery, while those that originate from tissues are able to be manipulated and articulated. These are the most commonly observed blights and have been known to present in many different ways, Hosts often being inflicted with multiple extrusion blights at a time.

The larger and further away from the body an extrusion blight is, the more sensitive or painful the base becomes due to strain. Extrusion blights are often heavy, dense, and uncomfortable, and larger blights often drive Hosts to seek treatment. Examples of smaller extrusion blights are fangs, blunt horns, and claws, while larger, more painful extrusion blights can be tails, long horns, or spikes down the spine.

Many Vice Management Administrators and Blight Specialists measure the growth of these blights as a quick, non-invasive indicator of the Vice's progress, as larger, more prominent extrusion blights directly correlate with increased core size. Because of this, comatose Hosts are typically overwhelmed by their extrusion blights, resulting in a deep-seated pain that resonates throughout the body. Smaller extrusion blights tend to be chronic, while sudden growth is typically acute. During Branches, extrusion blights are often agitated and can grow quite quickly, but after the Branch has been committed, they tend to shrink back to their size pre-initiation.

While they are extensions of the Host's body, extrusion blights also tend to be quite dense with VG, some going so far as to have a faint black mist hanging around them. Extrusion blights are essentially "pockets" of VG that have been deposited by the network, which are agitated by the rush of VG during Branches. The wide distribution of VG during Branches often aids in contributing VG to these pockets, which exacerbate their growth.

Other Blight Categorization

Pseudo Blights

Pseudo blights are lingering blights that remain even after a Vice has been rescinded. These blights are often the result of more mature Vices that put a strain on the Host's immune system and have left traces of its network behind; though, they can also be the result of

a reformed Vice due to the VG and fragments of the Vice's core are scattered throughout the Host's body.

While pseudo blights can be any of the types listed above, drape blights tend to be the most common, as the denser collections of tracks found in the shoulders and knees when the network is active are the fragments most commonly left behind after rescission. These blights are typically more brittle and only manifest in scattered patches, rather than dense swaths of scales and feathers. These blights can easily be removed from the skin and are less likely to leave lesions when doing so.

After the Host has been cleared, the immune system and hormone levels can take roughly a month to equalize as it works to address any remaining traces of the Vice. Liminal Hosts are likely to deal with blights for the duration of their reformed Vice's lifespan, which lasts typically no more than a year.

IntraBranch vs. InterBranch Blights

When documenting blights, the circumstances under which the blight is experienced provides much-needed context for Blight Specialists and Vice Management Administrators. IntraBranch blights are those experienced while a Branch is active, when the Branch is either in Staging or Production. IntraBranch blights primarily determine a Host's status, as elevated blights during this time can imply progression to berserk and comatose phases. InterBranch blights occur between active Branches, and give insight into Vice activity, such as germination.

Anomalies

Some blights have deviated from the expected behavior and documented manifestation. Features that drastically alter a Host's anatomy have been reported, such as eyes sprouting down a Host's arm or the creation of additional limbs. While extrusion blights can extend tissue and bone, articulation is relatively rare, with the exception of tails. Other documented anomalies include wings, the addition of joints, and extensions of the spine. Blight anomalies tend to affect the Host's musculoskeletal system the most, though some soft tissue anomalies have been reported as well. Soft tissue anomalies include armor-like hardening, gaping maws, and gangrenous welts. Blight anomalies tend to be quite painful and can be expected to linger as pseudo blights after rescission.

These anomalies are typically only observed in comatose Hosts, though less aggressive versions have been noted in stable Hosts infected with Zeta and Omega Vices. Anomalies can be acute or chronic and range anywhere from moderately uncomfortable to debilitating. The manifestation of these blights tends to suggest extremely mature Vices with highly established networks. Rescission is highly recommended if a Host is manifesting blight anomalies.

While these blights are still considered anomalies, many can also be further classified into the categories explored above. Most soft tissue anomalies can be categorized as drape blights, while musculoskeletal changes are often extrusion blights.

Treating Blights

Excessive blights can be treated with Suppressants or AV Shots in repeated blight management sessions, typically administered by a Blight Specialist. Though, it is important to keep in mind that the manifestation of blights is a way in which our bodies communicate with us, and excessive blights are often indicative of an underlying issue. Some bodies are simply more reactive to VG, however, and these treatments can provide relief by taming these exorbitant symptoms.

Cleared and liminal Hosts are also likely to pursue treatment for their psuedo blights. In the case of liminal Hosts, a Blight Specialist will likely prescribe a single dose of Suppressants to provide relief for lingering blights without impacting the remaining core; whereas, cleared Hosts can benefit from AV Shots and AV enhancement therapies to break up any remaining network fragments.

Learn more about these and other available treatments by contacting CVRS Primary Care today.

AV & Patches

As Vices have evolved, so, too, have our bodies. Our bodies learned to produce and release a counter-molecule called antivitiumglomerorum (AV) in direct response to the growing complexity of Vices.

AV: Our Natural, Ever-Present Defense Mechanism

Antivitiumglomerorum (AV) are the perfect opposite of vitiumglomerorum (VG), and direct contact between the two results in the destruction of both particles. When AV and VG interact and destroy each other, a slight negative charge is left behind from the AV. Because of this, AV Shots often have light static shocks as a side effect, similar in intensity to the small zaps one can feel on a dry winter day. AV can also eat away at the tracks that make up the Vice's network. The slight negative charge of AV can disrupt the bonds between vitiumnexa (VN), creating holes in the tracks and releasing the VN into the Host's bloodstream to be disposed of and processed by the immune system.

AV is stored and distributed in varying ways between Hosts. Depending on the location of the Vice core, various organs have adapted to produce AV, such as the adrenal glands, hypothalamus, and liver. AV is typically deployed in tandem with the hormones released as a stress response. The AV released alongside hormones attack the thin, wispy tracks deployed by the Vice's network to ensnare the passing hormones, allowing these hormones to reach their intended destination.

Our bodies naturally begin to produce AV after a Vice's advent. Depending on the advent's intensity, Hosts can take anywhere from a few days to multiple months to begin creating AV. Because AV are our primary way of combating Vices, CVRS offers multiple services to support and bolster our AV production.

AV Shots

This invasive treatment is often administered to patients with unmanageable acute blights. Shots can also be administered to combat an advancing Vice or suspend a Branch. An AV Shot is similar in appearance and mechanics to an epinephrine auto-injector. Injection sites vary, but it is recommended to be administered to low-fat muscular areas such as the thigh to trigger rapid uptake into the blood and

surrounding tissues, quickly dispersion across the patient's system.

AV Shots are generally regarded as band-aids to buy agents time to properly address the situation with the required resources. These shots are used in certain cases for Blight Management, administered by a Blight Specialist. Additionally, AV Shots are often used in Urgent Care services to address situations where time is of the essence.

AV Enhancement Therapy

While most bodies produce AV at an acceptable level, some Hosts have lower output and require AV enhancement therapies. This therapy is typically long-term and is administered to address lower AV outputs rather than immediate threats. The crux of AV enhancement therapy is prolonged agent-to-patient contact, wherein the agent uses a pair of Summoning Gloves to transmit a steady flow of AV that is received by the patient. Every patient's body is unique, and different areas have differing levels of receptivity. Talk to a Vice Management Specialist today about trying AV Enhancement therapy.

Patches: Fighting Back

As the production of AV became a more standard defense mechanism across the population, our bodies began to concentrate these molecules into tangible objects used to defend ourselves against advancing Vices, known as patches.

A patch is a densely-packed concentration of AV—often in the shape of simple, traditional weapons—that can help Hosts and Adjuncts successfully address Branches. Patches summoned outside of the Branch Domain have a fluid, shifting form that emanates a bright, cool light due to its composition of AV. Within the Branch Domain, patches have a more solid and detailed form with flourishes and details unique to both its weapon class and the Host it belongs to.

For example, if two Hosts have patches that imitate swords, one could have a simpler design while the other has engravings and embedded jewels. These differences in design often pull from the Host's personal experiences, and can even go so far as to mimic actual objects from the Host's life. A Host can also have multiple patches at once, though they will be the same and often at the expense of overall size. Examples include dual handaxes and collections of throwing stars.

During staging, a patch can be used to threaten the Vice core or render the Host unconscious without making contact so the Vice is forced to prematurely terminate the Branch. During production, a patch can deal devastating damage to both the Vice core and its exhibition. Learn more below in *Wielding a Patch*.

Patches are typically created as a direct reaction to having a Vice, though the circumstances in which they are created vary greatly between Hosts. Some Hosts receive their patches early in their Vice's life cycle, while others can take years. Patches are still able to be summoned even after the Vice has been rescinded. If a Host contracts another Vice after rescission, their initial patch is likely to change shape over time to properly defend against the newly contracted Vice.

The process outlined below details the process of a Host establishing their first patch.

Establishing a Patch

Patches are first observed in a Host as a burst of AV and can present in multiple ways, often emitted from the nose, mouth or pores. Many Hosts recall a light tickle in the back of the throat that results in a sparkling cough or sneeze, or a chalky residue on their hands that leaves a trail of shimmering dust.

Establishing a patch takes time, roughly two to three weeks depending on its intended complexity. While it starts as an amorphous cloud of dust, over the next few weeks, the body learns how to properly concentrate and form the expelled AV and the patch begins to take its shape. Summoning Gloves and other Hosts can help to speed up the process by aiding in the output of AV, though many report that this expedited process can be unbearably painful if forced too quickly.

The final structure of the patch cannot be chosen and is understood to be determined by the body itself, influencing the shape to best combat the Vice's exhibition. For example, if a Vice's exhibition has a defensive outer shell, a large blunt weapon like a hammer or club may be established. While patches are generally considered to be intentionally designed, not all patches end up being helpful in the Branch Domain. In this instance, we recommend enlisting the help of Adjuncts or CVRS agents with the desired patch design. Alternatively, a patch can also be calibrated.

Patch Calibration Services

In the event of unhelpful or insufficient patch

establishment, an AV Specialist can work with patients to influence the design and function of their patch to better suit combat in the Branch Domain. AV Specialists are unique agents who are able to influence a Host's patch design with repeated hand-to-hand sessions. Patches that have received calibration still belong to the Host, but are simply taking a temporary form influenced by an AV Specialist. Learn more about this process by contacting CVRS Primary Care today.

Summoning a Patch

After a patch is properly established, an inexplicable warmth can be felt in the palms, signaling that it is ready to be summoned. The patch can now be summoned at will through the body's summoning site, which is in the palm of the Host's dominant hand by default. When first summoning a patch, a Host must become aware of the AV flowing through their body in order to reroute it to the summoning site, ultimately spawning the patch. This is likely to take multiple tries and requires patience. We encourage rehearsing the process during slower times so that it will come naturally when the situation is urgent. This same mindfulness is required to relocate a summoning site, wherein a Host must concentrate on the flow of AV to migrate the summoning site throughout the body to the desired location.

In its early stages, a summoned patch can be wielded as intended, though its efficacy is typically low due to its lower structural density. With time and repeated practice, the structural integrity strengthens and is able to both deliver and receive blows without much compromise. Summoning gloves are used by CVRS agents to boost their body's output of AV and effortlessly summon their patch. Alternatively, Hosts can be referred to an AV Specialist to receive AV enhancement therapy to naturally bolster their AV production.

Wielding a Patch

Patches can be utilized during staging to suspend a Branch or during production to commit or rescind a Branch. It is important to understand the structural differences between these two options, as these differences will impact how the patch is handled. During staging, the patch has a bright, fluid form due to its composition of AV, but within the Branch

Domain, the patch is detailed and solid, closely resembling the weapon it mimics.

During Staging

Effectively wielding a patch during staging requires immense concentration. Though it can generally retain its shape while being held, once movement is introduced, its form becomes less rigid and can “smear”, spreading its AV across a wider surface area and reducing its efficacy. The same mindfulness needed for summoning and site migration should also be applied when wielding a patch during staging. With dedicated practice, it comes more naturally, and less concentration is needed.

Patches tend to degrade more quickly outside of the Branch Domain as well, so precision and timeliness are the keys to success. Summoning Gloves can be used to “stabilize” the fluid composition of patches by increasing the output of AV and solidifying its form. This results in lower AV lost from contact and aids in accuracy.

Patches can also be merged during staging, though this is typically only performed by AV Specialists as part of patch calibration therapy.

Merging Patches

The concept of merging patches is a relatively new phenomenon quickly gaining popularity as a new approach to addressing Branches, most often exercised by peers, rather than CVRS agents. Patches can only be merged during staging, outside of the Branch Domain, where their composition is the most fluid and malleable. While there are no interpersonal requirements to merging patches, many have reported higher rates of success when merging the patches of the Host and their primary Adjunct(s). The act of two Adjuncts merging a patch has been reported, but not documented.

The process of merging patches is as straightforward as it sounds and entails simply “mashing” the two patches together gently, so as to not damage them. The structure and details of the merged patch will only be visible once the Adjunct(s) has entered the Branch Domain and the Branch is in production.

It should be noted that the end product will not always be helpful, nor is stability always guaranteed. A merged patch can be wielded by either party, but two separate patches will always merge into one, so one half of the party will not enter the Branch Domain with a patch. Dual patches merged with single patches

can result in either one or two merged patches. Two sets of dual patches are likely to result in a dual merged patch, and so on. Dual merged patches can simultaneously be wielded by both of the owners.

After the Branch has terminated, merged patches are separated into their pre-merged compositions and returned to their respective owners. Merging is not guaranteed to result in the same product every time—nor is merging guaranteed to be successful every time—and should not be relied on as a method for addressing Branches. The act of merging patches is a novel concept and has not been studied thoroughly. Research and case studies are currently being conducted by our body of Branch Analysts. Due to its variability, CVRS cannot recommend merging patches as a viable method in addressing Branches, and instead recommends establishing a care team with various patch options.

During Production

Wielding a patch during production comes much more naturally and requires less concentration, as the Branch Domain is the intended environment for a patch. When a patch is used against a Vice’s exhibition, both will be damaged in the process.

Summoning Gloves donned before production will also be present in the Branch Domain and can aid in bolstering a patch’s makeup. This is particularly helpful for newly-established patches, which can otherwise become overloaded when subjected to repeated blows in quick succession. Those planning to wield a patch in the Branch Domain often summon it outside of the Branch Domain before making contact with the Host in staging.

“Thrown” weapons like arrows or handaxes can easily be sent off, and then summoned back within the wielder’s range. Doing so entails decommissioning the weapon and then re-summoning it.

Enhancing Patches

During production, patches can be combined with objects found around the Branch Domain, in a process known as patch enhancement. Not every combination yields a viable product, but if a patch is compatible with an object, there will be a brief shift in the patch’s makeup, resulting in what feels like a quick burst of haptic feedback.

Patch enhancement also performs differently depending on the patch’s maturity. Younger patches are more susceptible to enhancement, but often yield

less helpful results. More mature patches tend to be more discerning in what objects it deigns to fuse with, but yields stronger, more durable and complex results.

Patch enhancements are typically performed to bolster a patch or increase its damage output. For example, a club combined with a brick can become a greathammer. Patch enhancement can even be used to alter the function of a patch. For example, a small dagger patch combined with a wooden broom handle can become a javelin. The combination possibilities are endless, bound only by the limits of the Branch Domain. Patch enhancements are not permanent, but do maintain consistency between Branches. It is relatively difficult and time-consuming, but an enhanced patch is capable of being undone. Enhanced patches with a higher complexity are typically more difficult to undo, and the act of undoing an enhancement will vary between combinations.

Patch enhancement is, however, limited to the objects found in the Branch Domain of a Branch initiated by a Host's Vice. That is to say, an Adjunct cannot perform patch enhancement in the Branch Domain of another Host's Vice. Though these modifications do carry over to other Branch Domains if performed in the Host's original Branch Domain.

Patch Maintenance

Within the Branch Domain, and during staging especially, a patch will degrade as it comes in contact with VG. During staging, if a patch makes contact with a Host, the VG that have overwhelmed the body interact with the AV of the patch and neutralize each other. The same concept applies to the Branch Domain as well, where the patch neutralizes the Vice's exhibition at the point of contact. Typically, patches degrade more quickly in the short minute of staging than they do within a Branch's entire production, this being another reason why committing will always be recommended over suspension.

Over time, the body will naturally siphon AV to replenish what was lost. Rest and keeping stress low during this time can help speed up the process. AV Shots can also be administered if a patch was severely damaged, but should be done so with caution, as they can agitate the Vice or unintentionally instigate a Branch. Your Vice Management Administrator can refer you to an AV Specialist, who can provide AV enhancement therapy to bolster AV production without the risk of AV Shots.

Types of Patches

Generally speaking, patches are not limited to a set pool of options and have even strayed outside the realm of weapons in niche instances, but they are crafted with the sole intent to counter a Host's Vice, which typically results in a weapon-like object. Patches are organized into the categories below, strictly based on the intent of the object.

Piercing

These patches are manifested with the intent to stab and puncture thick hides or scales. Examples include short knives and daggers, thrown weapons like javelins or spears, long-range weapons like arrows or tridents, or more unconventional weapons like ice picks, needles, or darts.

Slashing

These patches are manifested with the intent to slash and cut through relatively fleshy, soft exhibitions. They can also be used to sever limbs or carve through excessive fat layers. Examples include weapons with large blades, such as axes and swords, serrated weapons like saws, or unconventional weapons such as bread knives or scalpels. Some weapons used for strangulation are included in this classification, such as piano wire and garrotes.

Bludgeoning

These patches are manifested with the intent to inflict blunt force trauma on the exhibition by damaging thick, outer shells or compromising skeletal structures. Examples include traditional weapons such as staffs, hammers, and clubs, while more modern examples include baseball bats and brass knuckles. Unconventional examples include lead pipes, golf clubs, and the ever-comical steel chair.

While the argument can be made that anything thrown with enough force could be classified as a bludgeoning weapon, what truly classifies a patch is the intent of the object. If bludgeoning is a secondary effect of the patch, such as the stock of a gun or the handle of an axe, it is not classified as bludgeoning.

Defensive

These patches have the express intention of shielding the Host or Adjunct from the exhibition's attacks. Some consider defensive patches to be subclasses of bludgeoning patches, as they can also be used to inflict blunt damage in close range, though it still relies on intent, and these patches are manifested to defend. Examples include standard wood or metal shields, but

can also extend to improvised shields like trash can lids or sheets of plywood. Improvised defensive patches are extremely rare, as defensive patches in general are already quite uncommon.

Fringe

A catchall grouping that houses patches that do not fit into any of the above categories. Because of this, patches that belong to this category often do not have any shared characteristics. “Fringe” does not necessarily mean “unconventional” in this instance, as some rare and unique patches can still be classified by the above categories due to the types of damage they can theoretically cause. Patches of all types have been classified as fringe, ranging from complex mechanical weapons like guns and grenades to non-damaging objects like sports balls, books, or nets.

While non-damaging weapons may seem counterintuitive to the purpose of patches, they were not manifested on a whim, and many Solutions Architects will urge Hosts to pay careful attention to a Vice’s behavior within the Branch Domain, as well as its exhibition, to discover ways in which these unique patches can swing the Branch in their favor.

Admission Guidance

Our team of dedicated agents are equipped with years of intense training to guide you through your Vice journey. We'll be here every step of the way. Take back control and schedule a consult today!

For more information, call us at (214) 877-8423 or send an email to info@cvrs.com.

Notice

While we do our best to serve our communities in an efficient and timely manner, due to the rise in cases over the last few years, wait times are likely to be long whether you've called our hotline, sent an email, or arrived in-person. We appreciate your patience.

Please self-admit to your nearest Urgent Care if you are experiencing a Vice-related emergency.

In an attempt to consolidate our communication channels, all requests have been centralized and are fielded through our hotline: (214) 877-8423 and our email: info@cvrs.com.

General Inquiries

To find your designated station number, check your account balance, or for general admission guidance, call (214) 877-8423 or send us an email at info@cvrs.com.

Request for Public Deployment Services

If our event patrol, rumen disposal, or Branch site cleanup services are desired, call (214) 877-8423 or send us an email at info@cvrs.com.

Urgent Consult Requests

All urgent matters should be handled through Urgent Care, including recently suspended Branches. Visit your nearest local Urgent Care to initiate the self-admission process. Don't worry about finding the correct station. All Urgent Care offices treat any and all patients with urgent needs.

Non-Urgent Consult Requests (New Patient)

New patients who have experienced recent Vice activity and are not in immediate danger can visit their local Primary Care for evaluation by a Record Proctor. To find your designated station, call (214) 877-8423 or send us an email at info@cvrs.com. Non-urgent matters can only be addressed by your designated CVRS station.

Non-Urgent Consult Requests (Established Patient)

Established patients who have experienced recent Vice activity and are not in immediate danger can visit their local Primary Care for evaluation by a Record Proctor. We offer an online chat feature through our patient portal to send questions to a member of our staff. The portal can also be used to schedule in-person or virtual appointments. Non-urgent matters can only be addressed by your designated CVRS station.

CVRS Cheat Sheet

CVRS is divided into two sectors: Public Health & Safety and Research. Each sector has unique goals, but often collaborates with the other to aggregate or share data. Public Health & Safety is primarily public-facing and provides hands-on care, while Research primarily aggregates and studies data submitted by Public Health & Safety, with limited interaction with Hosts.

Public Health & Safety

The Public Health & Safety sector is broad in its skillset, though its main focus is on administering medical care and treatment and providing support to patients. Within Public Health & Safety, agents with the same title can belong to different teams that with different roles. These teams consist of Primary Care, Urgent Care, and Public Deployment and respond to threats of varying urgency. Primary Care facilitates long-term care, Urgent Care addresses immediate threats, and Public Deployment mitigates threats.

Primary Care (Patient-Facing Team)

Primary Care agents provide long-term treatment for patients who have been screened and admitted by a Record Proctor. These agents are equipped with the knowledge and training to help patients along their Vice journey and even perform rescission when appropriate.

During a patient's time with Primary Care, they will likely encounter many different agents. While a Vice Management Administrator will be the primary practitioner, further support may be enlisted through a Vice Management Coordinator, Branch Administrator, Branch Coordinator, Blight Specialist, or Solutions Architect.

While every Primary Care team is different and not every station has a fully staffed team, the agent roles below all play an important part in facilitating and executing long-term treatment plans.

- Branch Administrator
- Branch Coordinator
- Solutions Architect

- Branch Recovery Specialist
- Vice Management Administrator
- Vice Management Coordinator
- Record Proctor
- Blight Specialist
- AV Specialist
- Branch Proctor
- Intake Coordinator

Primary Care agents provide long-term treatment for patients who have been screened and admitted by a Record Proctor. Primary Care agents are equipped with the knowledge and training to help patients along their Vice journey and even perform rescission when appropriate.

- Vice Management
- AV Enhancement
- Blight Management
- Patch Calibration
- Management Scans
- Rescission

Urgent Care (Patient-Facing Team)

Agents in Urgent Care provide acute care and treat at-risk patients from both Primary Care and Public Deployment, as well as public admissions. Urgent Care is trained to commit threatening Branches and refer patients back to Primary Care to resume or begin treatment.

- Branch Administrator
- Branch Coordinator
- Solutions Architect
- Branch Recovery Specialist
- Intake Coordinator
- Floor Manager
- Traffic Coordinator

Agents in Urgent Care provide acute care and treat at-risk patients from both Primary Care and Public Deployment, as well as public admissions. While Urgent Care agents are predominantly focused on addressing urgent Branches, they can also monitor patients after threatening Branches or help them recover.

- Activity Monitoring
- Branch Remediation
- Branch Recovery

Public Deployment (Public-Facing Team)

Agents in Public Deployment are on-call 24/7, often patrolling high-traffic hot spots, led by their resident Target Hunter. These agents respond to public Branches or can be requested to monitor a potential

threat. These agents also address post-Branch cleanup to ensure no anomalies have occurred.

- Branch Administrator
- Branch Coordinator
- Branch Recovery Specialist
- Target Hunter

Our agents are on-call 24/7, responding to public Branches or monitoring potential threats at public gatherings. These agents can also dispose of rumina and address post-Branch cleanup to ensure no anomalies have occurred.

- Branch Site Cleanup
- Event Patrol
- Rumen Disposal

Research

The Research Sector is comprised of analysts, engineers and researchers working to expand our understanding of Vices while designing equipment to aid in their research endeavors. Research is split into three teams: Aggregation, Observation and Manufacturing. Aggregation compiles and sorts data, Observation attends and documents patient Branches, and Manufacturing creates the technology and gear that supports our agents.

Aggregation (Behind-the-Scenes Team)

The Aggregation team primarily curates, sorts, and prioritizes information submitted by the Observation team and agents from Public Health & Safety. These agents parse large amounts of data to find patterns and changes in Vice behavior and biology.

- Lead Station Aggregator
- Forecast Specialist
- Report Coordinator

Observation (Behind-the-Scenes Team)

Observation is a unique team of pseudo Adjuncts who accompany both the Primary and Urgent Care teams in Branches of all types, from standard to rogue to instigated. These agents do not interfere with or have an impact on active Branches and send their observations to Aggregation for review.

- Research Proctor
- Vice Analyst
- Branch Analyst
- Behavioral Analyst
- Exposure Analyst

Manufacturing (Support Team)

This specialized team of designers and engineers are responsible for the gear and technology that optimize agent productivity. From the iconic Parsing Goggles to the innovative Bypasses, this team is always researching ways to make the jobs of agents easier.

- Product Engineer
- Textile Engineer
- Technician

Sector Advocate (Support Role)

Integral to agents' success, both sectors have a designated Sector Advocate. These agents do not engage with patients or facilitate research; instead, they perform the administrative duties for the agents of their respective sector, including hiring, employee relations, and funding requests.

Glossary

Familiarize yourself with common industry terms likely heard during the screening process or in appointments.

Adjunct

Anyone admitted to a Host's Branch during staging by making and maintaining physical contact with the Host while the Branch is being staged. Once inside the Branch Domain, Adjuncts can optionally summon a patch and commit or rescind the Branch. Some Adjuncts are admitted to the Branch Domain through alternative means. Adjuncts are split into four tiers: primary, secondary, tertiary, and pseudo, which all have differing levels of impact on an active Branch.

Advent

The birth of a Vice—categorized as either sudden or gradual—that officially classifies a Host as infected. Sudden advents occur when the Vice's birth is directly tied to a specific event, and the manifestation of a detectable Vice core immediately follows. Sudden advents also result in a Branch, known as the advent Branch. Gradual advents occur when the Vice core slowly manifests over time, and no singular event is tied to its creation. The properties present at advent influence the Branch Domain and revisiting these properties often result in Branch initiation.

Antivitiumglomerorum

(AV, plural: *antivitiumglomerora*)

The human body's natural defense against vitiumglomerorum (VG), AV is its perfect counter-molecule. When an AV particle collides with a VG particle, a small burst of energy is released and both molecules are destroyed. AV can be naturally observed in patches summoned outside of the Branch Domain and glow a bright cyan. While AV are produced by the body naturally, it is often in small amounts and only

activated after sudden, drastic changes in VG levels. Artificial AV sources—such as an AV Shot or Summoning Gloves—and regular sessions with an AV Specialist can help boost the body's natural production. Because vitiumnexa (VN) are considered relatively similar in composition to VG, AV are also capable of attacking and nullifying newly-established tracks.

Augmentation

Throughout its life cycle, beginning in adolescence, a Vice will create and establish a network that branches through the Host's body, originating from its core. When conditions are favorable, most commonly during a Branch when the Host's immune system is overwhelmed, a Vice will begin the process of augmentation, expanding its core along the nutrient-rich paths of its network. Augmentation is the intended goal of initiating Branches, and this growth paves the way for a Vice to initiate fusion and perform dispersion.

AV Shot

This device floods a Host's body with AV to combat an advancing Vice and is similar in appearance and mechanics to an epinephrine auto-injector. The AV attacks both the Vice's network and the core; however, AV Shots pose the risk of instigating a Branch, and in the case of mature or intelligent Vices, simply agitate the core and can actually increase growth. AV Shots can be used by CVRS agents to facilitate suspension if needed, and in regular, monitored doses can even facilitate exposure rescission. Blight Specialists may also use AV Shots to provide relief from acute blights.

Berserk

This status is applied to Hosts when the Vice core has made sudden, exponential progress expanding along its network, and the Host is in danger of the Vice core fusing with their body. While not always, this process often occurs while a Host is trapped in a Branch. Outside of a Branch, a berserk Host (sometimes abbreviated as b!Host) is often unpredictable, and can even be aggressive and hostile as their body is frantically trying to defend against the advancing Vice. The telltale sign of a b!Host is uncharacteristically overactive blights. If a b!Host is left unaddressed, they will become comatose. The safest way to defend against an advancing Vice is to commit (or even rescind) a Branch.

Blight

In the same way the immune system might prompt a rash when battling a virus, blights are the body's response to being infected with a Vice. Blights can be categorized as expulsion, drape, or extrusion blights. Regardless of its type, blights are informed by the Vice's exhibition and can be a valuable insight into possible changes to the exhibition between Branches. More aggressive blights are indicative of an advancing Vice core or an established network and should not be ignored.

Branch

This dissociative phenomenon is the side effect of the overwhelming influx of VG emitted when a Vice intends to expand its core, also known as augmentation. The term "Branch" encompasses all three stages (initiation, staging and production) and presents the Host with three options: suspending, committing or rescinding the Branch. During production, a Host temporarily loses contact with their body, and their consciousness is transported to the Branch Domain, a metaphysical—but finite and limited—environment where the Vice's exhibition can be fought. This out-of-body experience is often described as a hallucination or dream, though actions taken in the Branch Domain can have very real consequences. A Vice takes advantage of the Host's vulnerable state during a Branch and typically pursues either germination or augmentation.

Branch Domain

This liminal space is where the production stage of a Branch occurs, also known as the metaphysical realm. The domain is comprised of a fabricated environment, the Vice's exhibition, and extensions of the Host and Adjuncts, as well as their patches. The Branch Domain originates from the Vice core, making the core the true center and the lone corporeal object of the Branch Domain. This environment stays largely the same through a Vice's life cycle, as its properties draw from those experienced during advent. Over time, this environment can grow to be more complex as the Vice has more energy to devote during staging, though it typically keeps its core components.

Branch Policy

A Branch Policy is the comprehensive view of a Vice's approach to Branches, including environmental

Branch triggers, the Branch Domain blueprint, exhibition presentation and attack strategy, as well as the priorities while the Branch is active. A Vice's Branch Policy stays largely the same throughout its life cycle, and familiarizing oneself with these properties can help lead to a quicker, more efficient rescission. Certain classifications of Vices—namely Delta and Epsilon Vices—intentionally change or obfuscate their Branch Policy, respectively.

Cleared

"Cleared" is the label applied to a patient after the Vice core has been destroyed by a successful rescission. Cleared patients can have lingering blights and traces of the previous network, though neither of these pose considerable threats. They often dissipate gradually over time, but can be expedited with the help of Suppressants or a monthly AV Shot. Cleared patients do pose a risk for reignition, but the probability is relatively low. Research suggests that cleared patients have a slightly stronger immune system and consequently require a higher concentration of VG to result in another advent.

Comatose

This precarious phase is applied to a Host whose Vice has begun fusing its expanded core with the Host's physical body due to the lack or failure of action during the berserk phase. In this phase, motor control is inhibited and the Vice has flooded the system with lethal amounts of serotonin. High fever, seizures, and heart arrhythmia are indicative of a comatose Host. The Vice core is stretched extremely thin during this process and is incredibly vulnerable to attacks from patches, though attacks do pose a considerable risk to the physical body of the Host due to its fusion with tissue and organs. A comatose Host is unresponsive to the physical world, and any attempts at rescission need to be made swiftly, as Hosts do not last long in this phase. Though rescission does pose potential harm to the Host's physical form, the benefits of a successful rescission far outweigh the finality of dispersion.

Commit

One of the three potential paths to take during Branches, committing a Branch entails damaging the Vice's core during production, typically by using a patch. This is the most common action taken during a Branch and is what is recommended if rescission is not attainable. Initiating a Branch is a costly maneuver

for the Vice, and when committed, forces the Vice to retract any fresh growth achieved during augmentation or germination to repair its structural integrity. Committing a Branch buys more time between Branches as the Vice repairs its core, and often provides the Host or any present Adjuncts with more information to perform a successful rescission.

Core

Understood to be a Vice's life source, when the core is destroyed, the Vice is rescinded and the Host is cleared. A Vice's core houses its biological processes, such as energy processing, the creation of VG, Branch Policy, and even intelligence and sentience. The inner-workings of cores are currently unable to be researched due to their defense mechanisms. Vice cores typically reside inside the Host's physical body, much like a tumor or parasite, and are created when a high concentration of VG is embedded in soft tissue or a benign mass. Many physical and behavioral characteristics of the core differ between classifications.

Dismissal

Vices are able to dismiss Adjuncts, resulting in the removal of an Adjunct from an active Branch. Dismissed Adjuncts are capable of forcing re-entry using a Bypass, but the chances of a successful entry are much lower. Dismissal is typically only observed in mature Vices with a higher threat level, as it is only performed if the Vice views the Adjunct as a deadly threat. All Adjuncts can be dismissed, though the dismissal of primary Adjuncts is highly unlikely. Tertiary and pseudo Adjuncts are easily expelled without much effort, if any, and secondary Adjuncts typically take a bit more effort due to their physical contact. Hosts cannot be dismissed from their own Branch.

Dispersion

Dispersion is the ultimate goal of a Vice, wherein the Vice core overtakes, fuses with, then consumes the Host's body from the inside out. After the body is completely consumed by the core, it explodes into a fine mist of VG, or fungus-like spores, that can be embedded into those nearby. If a comatose Host is left unaddressed, they will be dispersed. Every Branch poses the risk of dispersion, if not prepared.

Exhibition

Only present in the Branch Domain, a Vice's exhibition shields the vulnerable core from the Host, Adjuncts and their patches. Exhibitions typically take the form of predatory animals—though the possibilities are endless. Some exhibitions are comprised of the properties present at advent, typically textures, smells or sounds and can even draw from the innate fears of the Host. Exhibitions also influence blights, as many properties present in the exhibition are mirrored as blights, most commonly seen as horns, teeth or skin textures. Exhibitions are incredibly unique and vary greatly between Hosts, though experts have begun grouping them by size and Branch strategy.

Extension

These metaphysical facsimiles of the Host and Adjuncts—only present in the Branch Domain—are near-perfect mirrors of their corporeal counterparts. However, within the Branch Domain, extensions are capable of physics-defying feats, much like the logic that allows people to fly or breathe under water in dreams. More severe injuries sustained within the Branch Domain—such as lacerations or broken bones—can manifest afterward as shallow cuts and muscle aches. Extensions can directly impact the outcome of a Branch through either committing or rescinding the Branch.

Germination

Germination refers to the process of a Vice expanding its network. This process occurs at a near-imperceptible pace, starting in adolescence, and paves the way for augmentation and ultimately dispersion. During Branches, Vices take advantage of the Host's compromised immune system and perform germination alongside augmentation, though they tend to prioritize one over the other. Prioritizing germination leads to complex networks that typically result in a more efficient, quicker dispersion and chronic blights.

Host

The term “Host” refers to someone infected with a Vice and is most commonly heard in research spaces. The relationship between a Host and their Vice is evident from this terminology, which is often regarded as parasitic. Everyone possesses the ability to become

a Host, but the probability fluctuates based on environment, personal characteristics, and past Vice-related encounters. It is estimated that roughly 68% of the population are currently infected with a Vice.

Network

The network is a mycelium-like collection of tracks that branch throughout the Host's body, originating from the Vice core at the beginning of adolescence. The network monitors physiological changes and collects various hormones or other energy sources to send back to the core where it feeds. During Branches, the core grows and expands along this nutrient-rich path. Particularly established networks tend to be rigid and result in achy joints, even going so far as to restrict range of motion in extreme cases. While the network is predominantly internal, in more mature Vices, it can extend beyond the Host's body to monitor external conditions or create a rumen as an external energy reserve. Networks can be seen through Parsing Goggles though some Vices are able to camouflage their networks.

Patch

As a dense collection of AV naturally produced by our bodies, patches are understood to be the physical manifestation of our bodies' attempt to protect us. Not all Hosts obtain patches and they cannot be intentionally created; therefore, lack of patch creation typically suggests a Vice with a lower threat level. Research posits that patches are only created when the Host is in danger, typically triggered by sudden changes in the physiology of the Vice core, such as resource hoarding or exponential network expansion or core growth. Patches range in appearance and function and often resemble weapons or defenses, designed especially to counter the Vice's exhibition.

Rescind

Rescission is the act of destroying a Vice's core, most commonly using a patch in the Branch Domain. Vice Management Specialists offer a rescission service through multiple methods: standard rescission, exposure rescission, and manual rescission. Upon achieving successful rescission, a Host is labeled as cleared, with a low possibility of reignition. Lingering blights are not uncommon, and can be treated with the help of Suppressants or monthly AV Shots.

Rumen

(plural: rumina)

Typically observed in Vices with a higher threat level, rumina are external resource hoards where a Vice stores extra energy gathered from a Host, typically during times of excess. It is connected to the Vice core through a densely-packed collection of stolons, sometimes visible to the naked eye. Many Hosts with a rumen report symptoms such as depression, fatigue, executive dysfunction, as well as muscle or joint stiffness. A rumen can detach from its Host if they stray too far, and are capable of surviving separate from their Host for a few weeks, depending on their size. Detached rumina gradually disintegrate over time, releasing a steady flow of VG and can aid in Vice reproduction. A detached rumen is able to reattach if the Host is back in proximity for an established length of time, typically around a week.

Stolon

These external tracks are more commonly found in certain classifications or mature Vices. While the majority of a Vice's network is contained inside the Host's body, a Vice will sometimes extend tracks outside of the body to monitor external conditions, scout for potential rumen, or even admit tertiary Adjuncts to Branches.

Suppressant

These extended release pills are best suited for treating patients with chronic blights. Once ingested, a Suppressant gradually releases a steady stream of AV, slightly boosting the patient's overall AV level. After a month of repeated use, many patients report not only decreased blight activity, but less fatigue and higher energy levels. However, because blights are our bodies' way of communicating with us, many view the suppression of blights as potentially dangerous and are only prescribed by trained CVRS agents and those familiar with individual patient cases. Suppressants are typically prescribed as part of Blight management or Branch recovery services.

Suspend

One of three potential paths to take during Branches, suspending a Branch entails threatening the Vice core while the Branch is being staged, by using either an AV Shot or patch. This is typically ill-advised, as doing so often agitates the Vice and results in more

frequent Branches, among many other downsides. Suspension should only be performed as a last result, particularly to buy more time to prepare, then Branch remediation should be performed by CVRS agents in Urgent Care.

Track

This hypha-like appendage extends from the Vice's core once it begins establishing its network in adolescence. They are simply densely-packed vitiumnexa (VN) surrounding a thin stream of VG and occasional hormones. New tracks are extremely fluid and easily damaged, but as they become more established, higher levels of AV are needed to damage them. While the primary purpose of tracks is to monitor surroundings and send nutrients back to the core, it is also the path that the core expands along during a Branch. Collectively, the tracks are known as the Vice's network.

Vitiumglomerorum

(VG, plural: vitiumglomerora)

VG are extremely light, spore-like cells expelled by the Vice core as a form of reproduction. While dispersion is their preferred method, VG can also be expelled by rumina in smaller concentrations. Due to the recent rise in Vice infections, VG are found in detectable amounts throughout our world and can even be seen with the naked eye in high concentrations. VG most commonly enter our body through orifices and microscopic tears in the skin, but are small enough to enter through our pores as well. Over time, large concentrations of VG in the body can drastically alter the genetic makeup of soft tissue and benign masses to result in the birth of a Vice. VG are also responsible for the dream-like, sedative effects of Branches.

Vitiumnexum

(VN, plural: vitiumnexa)

VN are unique, extremely small cells that make up the majority of tracks in the Vice's network. VN have proven to be difficult to study, as other Vice-specific molecules have, due in large part to both their size and Vices' reactivity and defense mechanisms. What we do know is that these molecules relay rudimentary environmental information back to the core, while also receiving core feedback to expand or retract in specific environmental conditions. Because tracks are so densely packed with VN, their form is relatively

porous and can shift its outer layer of VN to ensnare passing hormones with a net-like configuration and send them back to the core for processing.